Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 9 · DAYS 235-301

# The Davidic Covenant

*1-2 Samuel, 1 Kings 1-11, Psalms I-II integrated*

God establishes his kingdom through a king. The covenant with David and its eternal promise.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

*The largest block. The psalms of David beside his story (32 and 51, 63, 34) and the royal and Zion psalms (2, 20, 21, 45, 72, 48, 84, 87, 101).*

UNIT 9

# In this unit

WEEK 34

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 235 | 1 Samuel 1:1-2:36 | *Reading* |
| 236 | 1 Samuel 3:1-4:22 | *Reading* |
| 237 | Psalm 1 | *Psalm* |
| 238 | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

WEEK 35

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 239 | Psalm 2 | *Psalm* |
| 240 | 1 Samuel 5:1-7:17 | *Reading* |
| 241 | 1 Samuel 8:1-10:27 | *Reading* |
| 242 | 1 Samuel 11:1-13:23 | *Reading* |
| 243 | Psalm 3 | *Psalm* |
| 244 | Psalm 4; Psalm 5 | *Psalm* |
| 245 | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

WEEK 36

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 246 | Psalm 6 | *Psalm* |
| 247 | 1 Samuel 14:1-15:35 | *Reading* |
| 248 | 1 Samuel 16:1-17:58 | *Reading* |
| 249 | 1 Samuel 18:1-20:42 | *Reading* |
| 250 | Psalm 7 | *Psalm* |
| 251 | Psalm 11; Psalm 12 | *Psalm* |
| 252 | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

WEEK 37

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 253 | Psalm 13; Psalm 14 | *Psalm* |
| 254 | 1 Samuel 21:1-23:29 | *Reading* |
| 255 | 1 Samuel 24:1-26:25 | *Reading* |
| 256 | Psalm 18:1-30 | *Psalm* |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **257** | Psalm 18:31-50 | *Psalm* |
| **258** | Psalm 54; Psalm 59 | *Psalm* |
| **259** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

**WEEK 38**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **260** | Psalm 64; Psalm 70 | *Psalm* |
| **261** | 1 Samuel 27:1-31:13 | *Reading* |
| **262** | 2 Samuel 1:1-3:39 | *Reading* |
| **263** | Psalm 20 | *Psalm* |
| **264** | Psalm 21 | *Psalm* |
| **265** | 2 Samuel 4:1-6:23 | *Reading* |
| **266** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

**WEEK 39**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **267** | 2 Samuel 7:1-29 | *Reading* |
| **268** | Psalm 22:1-21 | *Psalm* |
| **269** | Psalm 24 | *Psalm* |
| **270** | 2 Samuel 8:1-10:19 | *Reading* |
| **271** | 2 Samuel 11:1-12:31 | *Reading* |
| **272** | Psalm 32 | *Psalm* |
| **273** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

**WEEK 40**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **274** | Psalm 51 | *Psalm* |
| **275** | 2 Samuel 13:1-14:33 | *Reading* |
| **276** | 2 Samuel 15:1-17:29 | *Reading* |
| **277** | Psalm 63 | *Psalm* |
| **278** | Psalm 61 | *Psalm* |
| **279** | 2 Samuel 18:1-19:43 | *Reading* |
| **280** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

**WEEK 41**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **281** | 2 Samuel 20:1-22:51 | *Reading* |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **282** | Psalm 34 | *Psalm* |
| **283** | Psalm 56; Psalm 57 | *Psalm* |
| **284** | Psalm 30 | *Psalm* |
| **285** | Psalm 35 | *Psalm* |
| **286** | Psalm 38; Psalm 39 | *Psalm* |
| **287** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |
| **WEEK 42** | | |
| **288** | 2 Samuel 23:1-24:25 | *Reading* |
| **289** | 1 Kings 1:1-2:46 | *Reading* |
| **290** | Psalm 45 | *Psalm* |
| **291** | Psalm 72 | *Psalm* |
| **292** | 1 Kings 3:1-5:18 | *Reading* |
| **293** | 1 Kings 6:1-7:51 | *Reading* |
| **294** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |
| **WEEK 43** | | |
| **295** | 1 Kings 8:1-66 | *Reading* |
| **296** | Psalm 48 | *Psalm* |
| **297** | Psalm 84 | *Psalm* |
| **298** | Psalm 87 | *Psalm* |
| **299** | Psalm 101 | *Psalm* |
| **300** | 1 Kings 9:1-11:43 | *Reading* |
| **301** | Review and Reflection | *Review and Sabbath* |

DAY 235 · WEEK 34

# 1 Samuel 1:1-2:36

*Hannah's prayer; Samuel born and given; Eli's corrupt sons*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 1:1-2:36. A new book begins, and it starts with a barren woman at a sanctuary. Read Hannah's prayer in chapter 2 slowly, and notice how it looks far beyond her own situation.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The book of Judges ended with the words, "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes." The books of Samuel pick up the story at that low point. The priesthood is corrupt, the nation is scattered, and the ark is at Shiloh. 1 and 2 Samuel were originally one book, and they tell how Israel moved from the judges to the monarchy, and how God chose David. The story begins with one woman's prayer.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. Elkanah has two wives. Peninnah has children, and Hannah, whom he loves, has none, and Peninnah provokes her (1:1-8).
2. Hannah prays in bitterness of soul and makes a vow: if God gives her a son, she will give him to the LORD all his life (1:10-11).
3. Eli the priest thinks she is drunk, then blesses her, and "her face was no longer sad" (1:12-18).
4. Samuel is born, and when he is weaned, Hannah brings him to Eli at Shiloh: "For this child I prayed" (1:20-28).
5. Hannah's song begins, "My heart exults in the LORD; my horn is exalted in the LORD" (2:1).

6. “There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God” (2:2).
7. “The LORD kills and brings to life… He raises up the poor from the dust” (2:6-8). The song ends with “his king” and “his anointed” (2:10).
8. Eli’s sons, Hophni and Phinehas, “were worthless men. They did not know the LORD” (2:12), and a man of God announces judgment on Eli’s house (2:27-36).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The opening scene is quiet and domestic, yet it sets the tone for the whole book. God works through the weak. Hannah is barren and humiliated. The priest misjudges her. The nation is corrupt. Yet from this pain comes the prophet who will anoint Israel’s kings. It echoes Sarah, Rebekah, and Rachel, the barren mothers of Genesis, and it shows that God’s plan often begins where human strength has run out.

Hannah’s prayer is honest and costly. She does not hide her bitterness. She pours out her soul before the LORD. And she vows to give back what she asks for. When Samuel is weaned, she keeps her vow, and she leaves her only son at the sanctuary. The gift is real, and it is received in joy: she worships rather than grieves.

Her song in chapter 2 is the theological center of the section, and it announces the theme of the whole book. The LORD reverses human expectation. The mighty are broken, the feeble gird on strength, the full hire themselves out for bread, the barren bear seven. “He raises up the poor from the dust.” The song ends by looking forward to “his king” and “his anointed.” Hannah does not yet know that Israel will have a king, but she already sees that God’s kingdom turns the world upside down.

Against this stands the failure of Eli’s house. His sons take the sacrificial meat by force and sleep with the women who serve at the tent. Eli rebukes them gently, but he does not restrain them. The prophecy against his house shows that God will not be mocked in his own sanctuary. He will raise up a faithful priest.

The chapter sets two houses side by side. One is a house of prayer and faith, and the other is a house of privilege and corruption. The LORD honors those who honor him, and those who despise him will be lightly esteemed.

STEP 5

## Connection

Mary's Magnificat in Luke 1:46-55 echoes Hannah's song closely, with its themes of the mighty brought down and the lowly lifted up. Hannah is the first to speak of God's "anointed" (the Messiah) in the Bible. Jesus, like Samuel, grew in "favor with the LORD and also with man" (2:26; Luke 2:52). Paul says that "God chose what is foolish in the world to shame the wise" (1 Corinthians 1:27).

STEP 6

## Application

Bring something you are bitter about to God honestly, as Hannah did.

Read Hannah's song aloud. Ask which line you most need to hear.

Think about what you have been given that you could dedicate back to God.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Pray honestly about something you have been holding back from God.
- Thank him for lifting the poor from the dust.
- Ask him to help you give back to him what he has given.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 236 · WEEK 34

# 1 Samuel 3:1-4:22

*God calls Samuel; the ark captured; Ichabod*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 3:1-4:22. These chapters tell how God called Samuel and how the ark was lost in battle. Notice how the word of the LORD comes to a child and how Israel treats the ark as a charm.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The word of the LORD was rare in those days, and visions were not widespread (3:1). Samuel, still a boy, serves in the sanctuary under Eli. The scenes that follow show God breaking the silence, and then a terrible defeat when Israel goes to war against the Philistines. The chapters belong together: in the first, the word of God is heard, and in the second, it is ignored, with disastrous results.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. The lamp of God had not yet gone out, and Samuel was lying down in the temple of the LORD where the ark was (3:3).
2. The LORD calls “Samuel!” three times, and Samuel thinks it is Eli (3:4-8).
3. Eli tells him to answer, “Speak, LORD, for your servant hears” (3:9).
4. God tells Samuel that he will judge Eli’s house forever, “because his sons were blaspheming God, and he did not restrain them” (3:13).
5. Eli says, “It is the LORD. Let him do what seems good to him” (3:18).
6. “And all Israel from Dan to Beersheba knew that Samuel was established as a prophet of the LORD” (3:20).

7. Israel is defeated by the Philistines and brings the ark of the covenant from Shiloh, and the Philistines hear the shout and are afraid (4:1-7).
8. The ark is captured, Hophni and Phinehas are killed, Eli falls and dies, and Phinehas' wife names her son Ichabod, "The glory has departed from Israel" (4:10-22).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The call of Samuel is among the most loved stories in Scripture, and it carries a sharp lesson. "Samuel did not yet know the LORD, and the word of the LORD had not yet been revealed to him." He served in the sanctuary, but he had not yet been addressed by God. Religious activity is not the same as hearing God. The LORD takes the initiative, and he calls a child.

Eli's response is a mixture of failure and faithfulness. He was a poor father who let his sons go unchecked. Yet when Samuel is called, Eli tells him the right words, "Speak, LORD, for your servant hears." Even a flawed leader can point someone toward God. And when he hears the word of judgment, he accepts it humbly. There is something moving in his submission, though it does not erase his guilt.

Samuel's first prophetic task is heavy: to tell his master that judgment is coming. He is afraid. But Eli asks him to speak plainly, and he does. This is the first test of a prophet: to say what God says, even when it is hard.

Chapter 4 shows the cost of ignoring the word. Israel loses a battle, and instead of repenting, the elders decide to bring the ark, as though it were a lucky charm. "Let us bring the ark of the covenant of the LORD here from Shiloh, that it may come among us and save us from the power of our enemies." They treat God's presence as a tool. The Philistines are afraid, but God does not fight for people who use him. Israel is crushed, the ark is taken, and the corrupt priests die.

The name Ichabod captures the meaning: "The glory has departed." It is the lowest point in the story so far. But the God who is not bound to an object will soon show his power in Philistia.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus said, "Whoever is of God hears the words of God" (John 8:47), and "My sheep hear my voice" (John 10:27). James 1:22 calls us to be doers of the word. Jeremiah 7:12-14 points back to Shiloh as a warning not to trust in the temple. Hebrews 1:1-2 says that God, who spoke in many ways, has now spoken by his Son.

STEP 6

## Application

Pray Samuel's prayer, "Speak, LORD, for your servant hears," before your next time in Scripture.

Ask whether you treat any religious object, place, or habit as a charm.

If someone has said a hard word to you from God's Word, consider listening with Eli's humility.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Pray, "Speak, LORD, your servant hears," and then listen for a moment.
- Ask him to keep you from treating his presence as a tool.
- Thank him for the Word made flesh.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 237 · WEEK 34

# Psalm 1

*Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 1. It is the doorway to the whole Psalter. Read it slowly, and notice the contrast between two ways of life.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 1 has no title and no named author, and it serves as the introduction to the Psalter. It places two ways in front of every reader: the way of the righteous and the way of the wicked. It begins with the word "blessed," the same word that opens many of the most important sections of Scripture. After the story of Eli's sons and Israel's failure, the psalm shows what a blessed life looks like.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked, nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers" (v. 1).
2. "But his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his law he meditates day and night" (v. 2).
3. "He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season, and its leaf does not wither" (v. 3).
4. "In all that he does, he prospers" (v. 3).
5. "The wicked are not so, but are like chaff that the wind drives away" (v. 4).
6. "Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment, nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous" (v. 5).
7. "For the LORD knows the way of the righteous" (v. 6).

8 “But the way of the wicked will perish” (v. 6).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Psalm 1 uses three verbs in verse 1 for the downward slide of the wicked: walk, stand, sit. A person first walks with the wicked, then stands in their way, then settles in as one of them. The slide is gradual. The first step is to take their counsel. It starts with what we listen to.

The positive picture is a tree. The righteous person is rooted in God’s word. His delight is in the law of the LORD, and he meditates on it day and night. The word “meditates” means to mutter or murmur, to go over the words quietly again and again. It is the opposite of casual reading. The tree is planted by streams of water, and its roots go deep, so that it bears fruit in season and does not wither.

Verse 3 says, “In all that he does, he prospers.” This must be read carefully. It does not promise worldly success in every case. The psalms themselves show righteous people suffering. It describes the fruit of a rooted life, and it points to the ultimate outcome. A person planted by the water will be fruitful, even if the fruit is not always visible.

The wicked are like chaff, the dry, weightless husk that the wind blows away. They have no root and no substance. The contrast is between weight and lightness, depth and surface. Verse 6 gives the reason behind it all: “The LORD knows the way of the righteous.” This is covenant knowledge. He watches over them and cares for them. The way of the wicked perishes because it leads nowhere.

Psalm 1 sets the tone for everything that follows. The Psalter is the prayer book of those who delight in God’s word. The key is the law of the LORD, which at this point in the story is the book of Moses, and which will be fulfilled in the one who perfectly kept it.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the truly blessed man who never walked in the counsel of the wicked and who delighted in the Father’s will (John 4:34). Jeremiah 17:7-8 echoes the tree image, and Revelation 22:2 shows the tree of life by the river. Jesus said, “I am the vine; you are the branches” (John 15:5). Paul says that we are “rooted and grounded in love” (Ephesians 3:17), and “rooted and built up in him” (Colossians 2:7).

STEP 6

## Application

Ask whose counsel you listen to most. Is there a voice you need to turn down?

Choose a short passage to meditate on throughout the day. Return to it often.

Thank God that he knows your way.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God you want to be a tree planted by his streams.
- Ask him to root you in his word and keep you from the counsel of the wicked.
- Thank him that he knows your way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 34

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

DAY 238 · WEEK 34

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Samuel 2:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"There is none holy like the LORD: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God."

1 SAMUEL 2:2

REST

## Meditation

Hannah's prayer is one of the great statements of faith in the Bible, and this verse is its center. She says it after she has given up her only son, with a heart full of joy.

"There is none holy like the LORD." Holiness means being set apart, utterly distinct. There is no one who is like the LORD in purity, power, and goodness. This is a statement of worship. When we compare God to anyone or anything else, he is incomparable.

"For there is none besides you." It is a statement of exclusivity. There is no other god. The gods of the nations are nothing. The great problem of Israel in the days of the judges was that they forgot this. Hannah remembers.

"There is no rock like our God." A rock is a symbol of security, strength, and permanence. In a world of shifting sand, there is something solid. In the Song of Moses, God is called the Rock (Deuteronomy 32:4). Hannah takes it up in her own song. When everything else gives

way, he stands.

For the Christian, the verse is a joy and a confession. Jesus is the Holy One of God (Mark 1:24), and he is the cornerstone on which the church is built (Ephesians 2:20). He is the rock that does not move, and the one in whom all who trust find security. Say it in your own words today: There is no one like you.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you began the books of Samuel. You read of Hannah's prayer and the birth of Samuel, and her song that proclaimed the God who raises the poor from the dust. You saw the corruption of Eli's sons and the word of judgment on his house. You read how God called the boy Samuel in the night and made him a prophet, and how Israel lost the ark in battle because they treated it as a charm. You began the Psalter with Psalm 1, the portrait of the blessed man who is like a tree planted by water. The week taught that God exalts the humble, that he speaks to those who listen, and that his presence cannot be used as a tool.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

Hannah's prayer was honest, costly, and answered. What is one thing you need to bring honestly to God this week?

Israel treated the ark like a good luck charm. Where are you tempted to use religious things as a substitute for a living relationship with God?

Psalm 1 describes a person who delights in God's word and bears fruit. What would it take for you to be more like that tree, and where in your day could you begin?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that there is none holy like him.

Thank him for answering prayer and speaking to those who listen.

Rest in him today.

DAY 239 · WEEK 35

# Psalm 2

*Why do the nations rage?, the anointed Son*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. This is the second psalm of the Psalter, and one of the most important messianic psalms. Read it as a drama with four voices: the nations, the LORD, the king, and the psalmist.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 is a royal psalm, probably used at the coronation of a king in Jerusalem. It begins with nations in rebellion, moves to God's answer from heaven, and ends with a call to submit. Along with Psalm 1, it forms the introduction to the Psalter. Psalm 1 is about the righteous person, and Psalm 2 is about the righteous king. Placed here, at the start of the books of Samuel, it points ahead to the king God will establish.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his anointed" (v. 2).
3. "Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us" (v. 3).
4. "He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision" (v. 4).
5. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
6. "You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
7. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
8. "Kiss the Son, lest he be angry… Blessed are all who take refuge in him" (vv. 12).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm opens with a question that exposes the folly of human rebellion: “Why do the nations rage?” The kings of the earth gather against the LORD and his anointed, saying, “Let us burst their bonds apart.” They see God’s rule as a prison. But their plotting is “in vain.” It is the oldest delusion: that we can throw off the rule of our Creator and be free.

God’s response is striking. He laughs. It is not the laughter of cruelty. It is the laughter of one who is secure. The nations’ rage cannot touch him. He sits in heaven, and then he speaks, and his word is terrifying: “I have set my King on Zion.” God’s answer to rebellion is a king.

In verse 7, the king speaks. “You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” In ancient Israel, the king was called God’s son at his enthronement, a way of saying that he ruled as God’s representative. The promise to David in 2 Samuel 7:14 is in view, and you will read it soon. But the words reach beyond any ordinary king. The ends of the earth are promised to this Son, and “you shall break them with a rod of iron.”

The psalm ends with an invitation. The kings are told to be wise, to serve the LORD with fear, to kiss the Son, to submit. The final line is a beatitude: “Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” It echoes the “blessed” of Psalm 1:1. The Psalter begins and ends the introduction with blessing.

For Israel, the king in Jerusalem was a sign. But as Israel’s kings failed one after another, the psalm began to be read as a promise of a king still to come, the Messiah, who would truly rule the nations.

STEP 5

## Connection

The New Testament quotes Psalm 2 more than any other psalm. At Jesus’ baptism and transfiguration, the Father says, “You are my beloved Son” (Mark 1:11; 9:7). Acts 4:25-28 applies verses 1 and 2 to the plot against Jesus. Paul quotes verse 7 about the resurrection (Acts 13:33). Hebrews 1:5 and 5:5 use it of Christ’s sonship and priesthood. Revelation 2:27, 12:5, and 19:15 apply the rod of iron to his final victory.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask whether you ever see God’s rule as a prison. Bring that to him honestly.

Take refuge in the Son. Name one fear, and place it in his hands.

Pray for leaders in your nation and for a spirit of humility among them.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God what you do when the nations rage and plots seem to prosper.
- Take refuge in the Son, and tell him so.
- Ask him to teach you to rejoice with trembling.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 240 · WEEK 35

# 1 Samuel 5:1-7:17

*The ark in Philistia; its return; Samuel judges Israel*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 61 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 5:1-7:17. The ark, captured in chapter 4, now travels through Philistine cities and comes home. Then Samuel leads Israel in repentance. Notice who is in control throughout.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The Philistines have captured the ark and taken it to the temple of Dagon in Ashdod. These chapters show what happens next. The ark is not a trophy. It is the throne of the LORD, and he defeats Dagon without an army. After seven months, the Philistines send it back with an offering. At Kiriath-jearim it rests for twenty years. Then Samuel calls Israel to turn from idols and leads them to a decisive victory at Mizpah.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. The Philistines set the ark beside Dagon, and the next morning Dagon has fallen on his face before the ark (5:1-3).
2. The next morning, Dagon is on the ground again, with head and hands cut off (5:4).
3. The LORD afflicts the people of Ashdod, Gath, and Ekron with tumors, and they say, “The hand of his is heavy against us” (5:6-12).
4. The Philistine priests advise sending the ark back with a guilt offering, to test whether the LORD is responsible (6:1-9).
5. Two cows pull the cart straight to Beth-shemesh, “lowing as they went” (6:10-12).
6. Some of the men of Beth-shemesh look into the ark, and God strikes them. They say, “Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God?” (6:19-20).

7. Samuel says, “If you are returning to the LORD with all your heart, then put away the foreign gods” (7:3).
8. Samuel sets up a stone and calls it Ebenezer, saying, “Till now the LORD has helped us” (7:12).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The story of the ark in Philistia is told with a touch of dark humor. The god Dagon bows to the ark of the LORD, falls, and breaks. The Philistines suffer plagues. And the cows, who have never pulled a cart, walk straight to Israel with their calves left behind. The point is that the LORD does not need anyone’s help. He was not defeated at Aphek. He allowed Israel to be defeated, and he is still the God above all gods. The loss of the ark was not his defeat, but his judgment.

The lesson for Israel is double. First, God cannot be used. The Philistines learn that the ark cannot be treated as a prize. The men of Beth-shemesh learn that the ark cannot be treated casually, either. God’s holiness cuts both ways. The cry of the men of Beth-shemesh, “Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God?” is the question that the whole law raises.

The turning point is chapter 7. After twenty years, the people lament after the LORD. Samuel’s answer is simple and direct: if you are returning with all your heart, put away the foreign gods. Repentance is not just sorrow. It is the removal of idols. Israel obeys, they fast and confess at Mizpah, and when the Philistines attack, the LORD thunders from heaven and routs them. The people do nothing but cry out. God fights for them.

The stone Ebenezer, “stone of help,” is a monument of memory. “Till now the LORD has helped us.” It is a statement of gratitude and also of confidence about the future. If he has helped us thus far, he will not stop. The hymn “Come, Thou Fount” echoes this verse.

Samuel judges Israel throughout his life, going on a circuit each year. This is the beginning of a leader who is not a warrior but a man of prayer.

STEP 5

## Connection

Paul says that “what agreement has the temple of God with idols?” (2 Corinthians 6:16). Jesus is greater than the ark; he is the true presence of God with us. John 1:14 says that the Word “dwelt” among us. Hebrews 12:28-29 calls God a consuming fire. 1 John 5:21 ends with, “Little children, keep yourselves from idols.”

STEP 6

## Application

Name one “Ebenezer” in your own story, a place where you can say, “Till now the LORD has helped me.”

Ask whether there is a foreign god you need to put away: something you trust more than God.

Remember that God is not defeated when things seem to go wrong. He is working.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Put away a foreign god in your own life, by naming it before God.
- Return to him with all your heart, and say what that means today.
- Thank him for helping you thus far.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

“But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head.”

PSALM 3:3

DAY 241 · WEEK 35

# 1 Samuel 8:1-10:27

*Israel demands a king; Saul anointed, God as true King*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 8:1-10:27. Israel asks for a king, and Saul is chosen. This is one of the most important turning points in the Old Testament. Read the elders' request, and listen for what it reveals about their hearts.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Samuel is old, and his sons are corrupt. The elders of Israel gather at Ramah and ask for a king "to judge us like all the nations." Samuel is displeased, and God tells him that the people have not rejected Samuel, but God. The following chapters describe how Saul, a young Benjaminite, is found, anointed in private by Samuel, and presented publicly at Mizpah. The monarchy begins, with a mixture of divine permission and human error.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. The elders say, "Behold, you are old and your sons do not walk in your ways. Now appoint for us a king to judge us like all the nations" (8:5).
2. The LORD says, "They have not rejected you, but they have rejected me from being king over them" (8:7).
3. Samuel warns them what a king will take: sons, daughters, fields, and servants (8:10-18).
4. The people refuse to listen: "No! But there shall be a king over us, that we also may be like all the nations" (8:19-20).
5. Saul is described as "a handsome young man… from his shoulders upward he was taller than any of the people" (9:2).

6. Saul is searching for lost donkeys and finds Samuel, who anoints him privately (9:3-10:1).
7. The Spirit of God rushes on Saul, and he prophesies (10:6-13).
8. At Mizpah, Saul is chosen by lot but is found hiding among the baggage (10:17-24).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The request for a king is not simply wrong. The law of Moses had anticipated it (Deuteronomy 17:14-20), and God had promised kings from Judah (Genesis 49:10). What is wrong is the reason. The elders want a king "like all the nations." Israel was supposed to be different. Their distinctiveness was that the LORD was their king. Wanting to be like the nations is a form of unbelief, a desire to trust in visible power instead of the invisible God.

Samuel's warning is a catalog of what human kings do: take. The word appears again and again. A king will take your sons for his army, your daughters for his kitchen, your best fields, your servants, and a tenth of your flocks. "And you shall be his slaves." It is a prophecy of Solomon's oppression and of every oppressive government. Yet the people say no, they will have a king. God gives them what they ask, and what they ask for will cost them.

Saul looks like a king. He is tall and handsome. But the narrative also shows his weaknesses. He is searching for lost donkeys, he is shy, and when he is chosen, he hides among the baggage. His humility is attractive, but it will turn into insecurity and fear of the people. At this stage, though, the Spirit of the LORD comes on him, and "God gave him another heart" (10:9). He begins well.

The chapters show a delicate balance. The monarchy is permitted, even blessed, and yet it is the fruit of a flawed motive. God works through human weakness. He will take Israel's misguided desire for a king and, in time, produce the king who is the Messiah. The people wanted a king like the nations. God will give them a king who is nothing like the nations.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the king who does not take but gives, who "came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45). Pilate asked him, "Are you the King of the Jews?" (John 18:33), and he answered, "My kingdom is not of this world." The people shouted, "We have no king but Caesar" (John 19:15), echoing the elders' rejection of God. Revelation 19:16 shows him as King of kings.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask where you are tempted to follow what everyone else does instead of trusting God.

Think about who or what you rely on in place of God, and what it costs you.

Thank God that Jesus is a king who gives himself for his people.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Confess where you have wanted to be like the nations.
- Ask him to keep you from trusting anything visible more than him.
- Thank Jesus, the king who serves.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 242 · WEEK 35

# 1 Samuel 11:1-13:23

*Saul's early success; his impatience; the kingdom taken*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 11:1-13:23. These chapters show the best and the worst of Saul. He wins a great victory, then he disobeys at Gilgal. Read chapter 13 slowly, and ask what Saul's real mistake was.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After Saul is chosen at Mizpah, he returns to farm in Gibeah. Then Nahash the Ammonite besieges Jabesh-gilead, and the Spirit of God comes powerfully on Saul. He leads Israel to victory, and the kingdom is renewed at Gilgal. In chapter 12, Samuel gives his farewell address. Then, in chapter 13, the Philistines gather a large army, and Saul faces a crisis that exposes his heart.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. Nahash offers terms: the men of Jabesh may surrender if he can gouge out their right eyes (11:1-2).
2. "The Spirit of God rushed upon Saul when he heard these words, and his anger was greatly kindled" (11:6).
3. After the victory, Saul says, "Not a man shall be put to death this day, for today the LORD has worked salvation in Israel" (11:13).
4. In his farewell, Samuel says, "Far be it from me that I should sin against the LORD by ceasing to pray for you" (12:23).
5. Samuel also says, "The LORD will not forsake his people, for his great name's sake" (12:22).

6. Saul is told to wait seven days at Gilgal for Samuel to come and offer sacrifices (13:8).
7. When the people begin to scatter, Saul offers the burnt offering himself (13:9-10).
8. Samuel says, “You have done foolishly. You have not kept the command of the LORD your God… But now your kingdom shall not continue. The LORD has sought out a man after his own heart” (13:13-14).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Saul’s first victory shows what a leader can be when the Spirit of God is upon him. He is angry at injustice, he acts decisively, and he is generous in victory. “Not a man shall be put to death this day, for today the LORD has worked salvation.” He gives God the credit. This is a king who understands that his power is on loan.

Samuel’s farewell speech is a model of pastoral integrity. He asks the people to testify against him if he has ever taken anything from them, and they say he has not. He then rebukes them for asking for a king, but with a promise: “Do not fear; you have done all this evil. Yet do not turn aside from following the LORD.” And he adds the lovely words, “I will not cease to pray for you.” A leader who loves his people prays for them even when they have wronged him.

Chapter 13 is the first sign of Saul’s downfall. The situation is grave: the Philistines have a huge army and Israel has no weapons. Saul waits seven days, as Samuel had told him. Then, as his men begin to leave, he offers the sacrifice himself, a task reserved for priests. It looks like a small thing. He was under pressure, and he meant well. But the narrative shows that it was a failure of trust. Saul was acting from fear of the people and the enemy, not from faith in God.

Samuel’s rebuke is severe. Saul’s kingdom will not continue. God has sought a man “after his own heart.” This phrase does not mean that David will be perfect, but that he will be a man whose heart is oriented toward God. The difference between Saul and David is not one of skill or sin, but of the posture of the heart.

The lesson is simple and searching: obedience is a matter of trust. Saul feared the people and tried to take control, and he lost the kingdom. Real leadership means waiting on God, even when everything seems to be falling apart.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus waited on the Father’s timing, as when he said, “My hour has not yet come” (John 2:4), and he trusted him in the garden: “Not my will, but yours, be done” (Luke 22:42). Paul quotes the phrase about David in Acts 13:22. The Hebrew phrase “a man after his own heart” finds

its fulfillment in the one who always did what pleased the Father (John 8:29). Peter says that the one who believes in him will not be put to shame (1 Peter 2:6).

STEP 6

## Application

Think of a time you took matters into your own hands instead of waiting on God. What drove you?

Pray for your leaders as Samuel did, even if they have wronged you.

Ask the Lord to give you a heart oriented toward him.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God for a heart after his own heart.
- Ask him to teach you to wait when everything says to act.
- Pray for those who lead you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 243 · WEEK 35

# Psalm 3

*O LORD, how many are my foes, David's morning psalm*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 3. This is the first psalm in the Bible with a title that gives its setting: "A Psalm of David, when he fled from Absalom his son." It is a morning prayer of trust in the face of danger.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

David wrote this psalm during the worst crisis of his reign, when his son Absalom led a rebellion and David had to flee Jerusalem. You will read that story in 2 Samuel 15 to 18. The psalm is placed here at the start of the stories about David. It shows what kind of man he was: when he was most afraid, he prayed. It is a prayer for a day that began in danger.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "O LORD, how many are my foes! Many are rising against me" (v. 1).
2. "Many are saying of me, There is no salvation for him in God" (v. 2).
3. "But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head" (v. 3).
4. "I cried aloud to the LORD, and he answered me from his holy hill" (v. 4).
5. "I lay down and slept; I woke again, for the LORD sustained me" (v. 5).
6. "I will not be afraid of many thousands of people who have set themselves against me all around" (v. 6).
7. "Arise, O LORD! Save me, O my God!" (v. 7).
8. "Salvation belongs to the LORD; your blessing be on your people!" (v. 8).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with a list of problems. David has many enemies, and they are saying he is finished. It is the voice of discouragement: "There is no salvation for him in God." The worst part of David's trouble is not the armies but the taunt that God has abandoned him. This is the hardest thing for believers in distress: not simply the pain, but the suspicion that God is not there.

Then comes the great "But you." David turns from the voices around him to the LORD. "But you, O LORD, are a shield about me." A shield protects on every side. He is also "my glory," meaning that even when David has lost his throne, his honor rests in God. And he is "the lifter of my head." A defeated man hangs his head. God lifts it.

The most surprising line is verse 5: "I lay down and slept." David is on the run from his own son, with an army in pursuit, and he sleeps. This is not carelessness. It is trust. He sleeps because "the LORD sustained me." The sleep is a sign that he has given his anxiety to God. It is one of the most practical pictures of faith in the Bible.

He is not naive about the danger. He asks God to arise and save, and he describes God striking his enemies' jaws. The psalm ends with a statement that is a creed in four words: "Salvation belongs to the LORD." David cannot save himself, and neither can anyone else.

Even in a bitter family conflict, with his own son against him, David prays, "Your blessing be on your people." He does not forget the nation. In his distress, he thinks of others.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus slept in a boat during a storm (Mark 4:38), showing the same trust. He too was betrayed by someone close, and he crossed the Kidron valley into a garden (John 18:1). Paul says, "We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed" (2 Corinthians 4:8). Hebrews 12:2 says that Jesus "for the joy that was set before him endured the cross." Revelation 7:10 declares, "Salvation belongs to our God."

STEP 6

## Application

Pray this psalm tonight before you go to sleep, and entrust your worries to God.

Think about the voices that say there is no help for you in God. Answer them with "But you, O LORD."

Pray a blessing over your church and your nation.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that he is a shield about you, and tell him about those who rise against you.

Ask him to let you sleep in his care.

Bless his people in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

DAY 244 · WEEK 35

# Psalm 4; Psalm 5

*Evening and morning prayer, trust amid enemies*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 4 and Psalm 5. These are an evening prayer and a morning prayer, and they belong together. Notice the way each begins and how each ends with peace and protection.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 4 is traditionally read as an evening prayer, and Psalm 5 as a morning prayer. Both are attributed to David and both appear in the early part of the Psalter. They come directly after Psalm 3, so the first five psalms of David form a rhythm of day and night: morning in Psalm 3, evening in Psalm 4, and morning in Psalm 5. David teaches us to pray at the edges of the day.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “Answer me when I call, O God of my righteousness! You have given me relief when I was in distress” (4:1).
2. “But know that the LORD has set apart the godly for himself; the LORD hears when I call to him” (4:3).
3. “Be angry, and do not sin; ponder in your own hearts on your beds, and be silent” (4:4).
4. “There are many who say, Who will show us some good? Lift up the light of your face upon us, O LORD!” (4:6).
5. “You have put more joy in my heart than they have when their grain and wine abound” (4:7).

6. “In peace I will both lie down and sleep; for you alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety” (4:8).

7. “O LORD, in the morning you hear my voice; in the morning I prepare a sacrifice for you and watch” (5:3).

8. “But I, through the abundance of your steadfast love, will enter your house. I will bow down toward your holy temple in the fear of you” (5:7).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Psalm 4 is a prayer to be said before going to sleep. David is troubled, but he does not simply complain. He recalls that God has given him relief before. He tells his opponents to “ponder in your own hearts on your beds, and be silent.” The advice is good for anyone: before sleep, let your anger settle, and do not let it turn into sin. “Be angry, and do not sin” is one of the best pieces of advice in the Bible.

The psalm sets two kinds of happiness side by side. Many people say, “Who will show us some good?” They look for happiness in grain and wine, in material abundance. David asks for something different: “Lift up the light of your face upon us.” It is the blessing of Numbers 6, which you read in the last unit. And he says that God has put more joy in his heart than their abundance gives them. Joy that comes from God’s face is deeper than joy that comes from prosperity.

The last verse is among the most restful in the Psalter. “In peace I will both lie down and sleep; for you alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety.” The “alone” is important. Safety is not from locks or armies, but from the LORD.

Psalm 5 turns to the morning. David begins his day with prayer: “In the morning you hear my voice; in the morning I prepare a sacrifice for you and watch.” The word “watch” suggests eager expectation. He lays out his prayer as a priest lays out the sacrifice, and then he looks to see how God will answer.

The psalm contrasts the wicked, whom God hates, with the righteous, who come into his house through his steadfast love. David enters by grace: “through the abundance of your steadfast love.” Our access to God does not rest on our goodness. He asks God to lead him in the way and make it straight. The psalm ends with the promise that God will bless the righteous and cover them “as with a shield.”

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus began his days in prayer (Mark 1:35), and he withdrew to pray at night (Luke 6:12). Paul quotes Psalm 4:4 in Ephesians 4:26: “Be angry and do not sin; do not let the sun go down on your anger.” Paul also says, “The peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts” (Philippians 4:7). Psalm 5:9 is quoted in Romans 3:13 as a description of human sinfulness.

STEP 6

## Application

Make a point of praying at the beginning and end of your day, even briefly.

Before bed tonight, let go of any anger you are holding. Do not let the sun go down on it.

Prepare your morning prayer as a sacrifice, and then watch to see how God answers.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Pray an evening prayer: give God today and what is unfinished.
- Ask him to put more joy in your heart than abundance can.
- Thank him that he alone makes you dwell in safety.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 35

“But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head.”

PSALM 3:3

DAY 245 · WEEK 35

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 3:3 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"But you, O LORD, are a shield about me, my glory, and the lifter of my head."

PSALM 3:3

REST

## Meditation

David wrote this verse while running from his own son. Everything he had was at risk, and yet he turned his eyes from the voices around him to the LORD.

"But you." These two words are the hinge of the verse. Around David were enemies, rumors, and a suspicion that God had left him. But he sets one word against them all. When your circumstances say one thing, you may answer with "But you."

"A shield about me." A shield is held up between the warrior and the arrow. David says the LORD is not only in front of him but all around him. There is no side on which he is exposed.

"My glory." David had lost his palace and his crown. If his honor depended on his position, he would have none. But his glory is God himself. No one can take that from him.

"The lifter of my head." The ashamed hang their heads, and the defeated look at the ground. God lifts the chin of his people and lets them look him in the face.

The Christian reads this verse through Christ. He is our shield (Ephesians 6:16), he is the glory of God (John 1:14), and he lifts us out of shame (Romans 10:11). Say it today whenever you feel surrounded.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you read of Israel's request for a king and the rise and first failure of Saul. You saw the ark in Philistia, where Dagon fell and the LORD showed that he needs no one's help, and you read of the stone Ebenezer, "Till now the LORD has helped us." You read Samuel's warning about what kings take, and how Saul lost his kingdom at Gilgal because he feared the people more than he trusted God. In the Psalms you read the royal Psalm 2, where God answers rebellion by setting his King on Zion, and the prayers of David in Psalms 3 to 5 for morning and for evening. The week taught that God rules even when his people ask for the wrong thing, and that his anointed king is the only safe refuge.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

Saul acted out of fear when he should have waited on God. Where are you tempted to act in your own strength this week instead of waiting?

Psalm 2 says, "Blessed are all who take refuge in him." How does Jesus, the Son and the anointed King, become a refuge for you in a specific worry?

Ebenezer means "Till now the LORD has helped us." Write down three ways he has helped you in the last year.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that he is a shield and the lifter of your head.

Thank him for the King he set on Zion.

Rest in the knowledge that he holds you.

DAY 246 · WEEK 36

# Psalm 6

*O LORD, rebuke me not in your anger, the first penitential psalm*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 6. This is the first of the seven traditional penitential psalms. Read it as the prayer of someone who is worn out by suffering and has nowhere else to turn.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 6 is a prayer of David, with the note "according to The Sheminith," probably a musical direction. Nothing in it tells us the exact crisis, and that is useful, because it lets many sufferers pray it. David is physically and emotionally exhausted, and he feels that God's anger is on him. The psalm moves from desperate pleading to a sudden confidence at the end.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "O LORD, rebuke me not in your anger, nor discipline me in your wrath" (v. 1).
2. "Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am languishing; heal me, O LORD, for my bones are troubled" (v. 2).
3. "My soul also is greatly troubled. But you, O LORD, how long?" (v. 3).
4. "Turn, O LORD, deliver my life; save me for the sake of your steadfast love" (v. 4).
5. "For in death there is no remembrance of you; in Sheol who will give you praise?" (v. 5).
6. "I am weary with my moaning; every night I flood my bed with tears; I drench my couch with my weeping" (v. 6).
7. "Depart from me, all you workers of evil, for the LORD has heard the sound of my weeping" (v. 8).
8. "The LORD has heard my plea; the LORD accepts my prayer" (v. 9).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

This psalm holds nothing back. David is weak, his bones are shaking, and his nights are given over to tears. He asks God not to rebuke him in anger. He does not claim to be innocent. He knows that suffering may be connected to sin, and he asks for mercy rather than strict justice. The ground of his appeal is not his own goodness but God's "steadfast love," the covenant word that appears again and again in the Psalms.

The question "How long?" is the cry of the sufferer in many psalms. It is not rebellion. It is an honest question brought to God. Believers in the Bible are allowed to ask it. The Bible does not require us to hide our exhaustion behind pious language.

Verse 5 is an argument. David says that the dead cannot praise God, so why let him die? At this point in the story of Scripture, the hope of resurrection is not yet fully revealed, and David's view of death is dark. The argument is that God's glory is served by keeping his servant alive to praise him. Later revelation will show that death is not the end for those in God's hands.

The turn comes without warning. In verse 8, the tone changes: "Depart from me, all you workers of evil, for the LORD has heard the sound of my weeping." Nothing in David's circumstances has changed. What changed is that he has prayed, and he is sure he has been heard. He says it three times: God has heard my weeping, my plea, my prayer.

The psalm teaches that tears are a form of prayer, and that God hears them. It also teaches that we may leave our suffering with God and trust him with the outcome, even before we see it.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus said, "My soul is very sorrowful, even to death" (Matthew 26:38), and "In the days of his flesh, Jesus offered up prayers and supplications, with loud cries and tears" (Hebrews 5:7). Jesus took on our weakness. John 12:27 echoes verse 3: "Now is my soul troubled." Revelation 21:4 promises that God will wipe away every tear.

STEP 6

## Application

Bring your exhaustion to God without dressing it up. Tell him how long it has been.

Ask for mercy based on his steadfast love, not on your record.

Thank him that he hears the sound of your weeping.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God honestly how weary you are.
- Ask him to be gracious to you for the sake of his steadfast love.
- Thank Jesus for weeping and praying in the same way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 247 · WEEK 36

# 1 Samuel 14:1-15:35

*Jonathan's faith; Saul's foolishness; Saul rejected*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 82 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 14:1-15:35. Chapter 14 shows Jonathan's faith and Saul's rash vow. Chapter 15 records Saul's final rejection. Pay close attention to Samuel's words in 15:22-23.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Israel is still under Philistine pressure. Jonathan, Saul's son, takes the initiative against a Philistine outpost, trusting that the LORD can save by many or by few. Later, God commands Saul through Samuel to destroy the Amalekites, who had attacked Israel in the wilderness. Saul's partial obedience is the failure that ends his dynasty. These chapters mark the turning of the kingdom from Saul toward David.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. Jonathan says to his armor-bearer, "It may be that the LORD will work for us, for nothing can hinder the LORD from saving by many or by few" (14:6).
2. Saul makes a rash oath that no one may eat before evening, and Jonathan, who did not hear it, eats honey (14:24-27).
3. The people ransom Jonathan, and he is not put to death (14:45).
4. The LORD tells Saul to strike Amalek and devote all that they have to destruction (15:1-3).
5. Saul spares King Agag and the best of the sheep and oxen (15:9).
6. Saul says, "I have performed the commandment of the LORD," and Samuel answers, "What then is this bleating of the sheep in my ears?" (15:13-14).
7. "To obey is better than sacrifice, and to listen than the fat of rams" (15:22).

8 “The LORD has rejected you from being king over Israel” (15:26). And “the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret” (15:29).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Jonathan is a bright figure in a dark story. He and his armor-bearer climb a cliff against a garrison, and his words show a faith that does not depend on numbers: “Nothing can hinder the LORD from saving by many or by few.” The LORD gives a great victory. Jonathan’s faith contrasts with his father’s, who stays under a pomegranate tree and then binds the army with a foolish oath. Saul’s religion is concerned with rules and ceremony, but his heart does not trust God. The oath nearly costs Jonathan his life.

Chapter 15 is the decisive moment. The command against Amalek is a hard one, part of the judgment on a people whose long violence had been judged by God. Saul obeys in part. He spares the king and the best animals, and he says it is to sacrifice them to the LORD. When Samuel confronts him, Saul first claims he obeyed, then blames the people, then offers religious reasons.

Samuel’s reply is one of the great sentences of the Bible: “Has the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice.” God is not looking for religious performance but for a surrendered heart. Rebellion is as the sin of divination, and presumption is as iniquity and idolatry.

Saul’s confession is shallow. He says, “I have sinned,” but he immediately asks Samuel to honor him before the elders. He is more worried about his reputation than about his sin. Repentance that seeks to keep the appearance of standing is not true repentance.

The chapter ends with Samuel mourning for Saul, and “the LORD regretted that he had made Saul king.” The word “regret” here speaks of sorrow and a change of course, not of God being surprised. Verse 29 insists that God does not change his mind like a man. His purposes stand.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus quotes Hosea 6:6 twice, “I desire mercy, and not sacrifice” (Matthew 9:13; 12:7), in the same spirit as Samuel. Hebrews 10:5-10 says that Christ came to do God’s will, where sacrifices could not satisfy. Jesus was “obedient to the point of death” (Philippians 2:8), succeeding where Saul failed. John 14:15: “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.”

STEP 6

## Application

Ask where you offer God religious activity instead of obedience.

Look at your last confession of sin. Was it about the sin, or about how you look?

Thank Jesus that he obeyed fully, and ask for a listening heart.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Confess where you have offered God less than your heart.
- Ask for the faith of Jonathan, who believed nothing can hinder God.
- Thank Christ for his perfect obedience.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 248 · WEEK 36

# 1 Samuel 16:1-17:58

*David anointed; Goliath, the shepherd-king*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 16:1-17:58. God chooses David, and David defeats Goliath. Read slowly, and notice what each side says about who will win and why.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After Saul's rejection, God sends Samuel to Bethlehem to anoint one of Jesse's sons as king. The chosen one is the youngest, a shepherd. David enters Saul's service as a musician, and then, in the valley of Elah, faces the Philistine champion Goliath when the whole army of Israel is paralyzed with fear. These chapters introduce the central human figure of the Old Testament narrative.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. God tells Samuel, "Fill your horn with oil, and go. I will send you to Jesse the Bethlehemite, for I have provided for myself a king among his sons" (16:1).
2. "Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart" (16:7).
3. David is brought in from the sheep, "ruddy, with beautiful eyes and handsome", and the LORD says, "Arise, anoint him, for this is he" (16:12).
4. "The Spirit of the LORD rushed upon David from that day forward" (16:13), while the Spirit departs from Saul (16:14).
5. Goliath, who stood about nine feet tall, taunts Israel for forty days (17:4, 16).
6. David says, "Who is this uncircumcised Philistine, that he should defy the armies of the living God?" (17:26).
7. David refuses Saul's armor and takes five smooth stones and his sling (17:38-40).

8 “You come to me with a sword and with a spear and with a javelin, but I come to you in the name of the LORD of hosts… that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel” (17:45-46).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The story of David’s anointing begins with a reversal of expectations. Samuel looks at Eliab, the tall oldest son, and thinks, “Surely the LORD’s anointed is before him.” But the LORD says, “Do not look on his appearance… For the LORD sees not as man sees.” This echoes the story of Saul, who looked the part and failed. God chooses the youngest, the one who was left with the sheep. It is a repeated pattern in the Bible: Isaac over Ishmael, Jacob over Esau, Joseph, Moses, and now David.

The Spirit’s movement is dramatic. He rushes on David and leaves Saul. Saul is now troubled by a harmful spirit, and David’s music soothes him. The king who has been rejected receives comfort from the one who will replace him.

The Goliath narrative is often read as a lesson in courage, but its real theme is who fights for Israel. The whole army, Saul included, sees Goliath’s size and trembles. David sees Goliath’s defiance of God. For David the question is not whether Goliath is big, but whether the living God is big enough. He has fought lions and bears, and he credits the LORD with those victories.

David’s declaration before the battle is the heart of the chapter. “The battle is the LORD’s.” He does not rely on Saul’s armor or on conventional weapons. He wants the world to know that God can save without sword or spear. The victory is not just David’s. It is for all Israel, a public sign that there is a God in Israel.

There is a deeper pattern. David stands alone as a representative for the people. If he wins, they win. If he loses, they are slaves. The people share in the victory of their champion without lifting a sword.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the greater David: born in Bethlehem, a shepherd, and the anointed King (Micah 5:2; John 10:11). He is the champion who fights in our place, defeating sin, death, and the devil (Colossians 2:15; Hebrews 2:14-15). The victory is ours without our having lifted a sword. Paul says, “God chose what is weak in the world to shame the strong” (1 Corinthians 1:27).

STEP 6

## Application

Ask what your “Goliath” is, the thing that has been mocking you for forty days.

Remember that Christ has already fought and won. Stand in his victory.

Ask the Lord to teach you to see people as he sees them, by the heart.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to teach you to see as he sees, and to trust him in the battle you face.
- Thank Jesus, your champion, who defeated sin and death.
- Name a giant in your life and give it to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 249 · WEEK 36

# 1 Samuel 18:1-20:42

*David and Jonathan; Saul's jealousy; covenant friendship*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 94 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 18:1-20:42. These chapters show David's rise, Saul's jealousy, and the friendship of Jonathan and David. Notice how David responds to being hunted.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After the victory over Goliath, David becomes a leading figure in Saul's army. The women sing, "Saul has struck down his thousands, and David his ten thousands," and jealousy takes root in the king's heart. Saul tries several times to kill David. Jonathan, Saul's son and heir, becomes David's closest friend and risks his own father's anger to protect him.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "The soul of Jonathan was knit to the soul of David, and Jonathan loved him as his own soul" (18:1).
2. Jonathan makes a covenant with David and gives him his robe, armor, sword, bow, and belt (18:3-4).
3. The women's song makes Saul angry, and "Saul eyed David from that day on" (18:7-9).
4. Saul twice hurls a spear at David, and "Saul was afraid of David, because the LORD was with him" (18:11-12).
5. Saul offers his daughters Merab and Michal, hoping the Philistines will kill David (18:17-27).
6. Michal helps David escape through a window (19:11-17).
7. Jonathan says to David, "Whatever you say, I will do for you" (20:4), and they renew their covenant (20:16-17).

8. Jonathan shoots arrows as a signal, and David and Jonathan weep together as they part (20:35-42).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Saul's jealousy is the central tragedy of these chapters. He had been a victorious king, and now he cannot bear to hear another man praised. The spirit that began with envy ends in murder. It illustrates how sin grows: a small resentment, left unchecked, becomes a consuming obsession. Saul even sees that the LORD is with David and that he himself has been abandoned, yet he fights against God's chosen.

David's behavior in the face of this is notable. He plays the harp, serves faithfully, and does not take revenge. "David behaved wisely in all his undertakings, for the LORD was with him." He does not defend himself with a plot to take the throne. He trusts the promise that God made through Samuel.

The friendship of Jonathan and David is among the most moving in Scripture. Jonathan is the king's heir, and David is the one who will take the throne from his house. A less godly man would have seen David as a rival. Jonathan sees him as the LORD's anointed. He hands over his robe and his armor, a symbolic transfer of his claim to the throne. He says later that he knows David will be king (23:17). He chooses loyalty to God's plan over personal ambition.

The covenant between the two friends is renewed in chapter 20, and the scene of their parting is full of grief. Each man is faithful to the other, and yet they must separate. Jonathan will remain with his father, and David will become a fugitive.

Faithful friendship, in this story, is a gift from God and a refuge in time of trouble. Jonathan protects David at risk to himself, and speaks the truth to his father even when it brings danger.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus said, "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends" (John 15:13). Jonathan gave up his claim to the throne for David, but Christ laid down his own life for his people. John 15:15 says, "I have called you friends." Like David, Jesus was hated without cause (John 15:25) and hunted by those who envied him (Mark 15:10).

STEP 6

## Application

Examine your heart for jealousy. Who do you resent because they are praised?

Give thanks for a friend who has been loyal to you, and tell them.

Ask God to make you a Jonathan, a person who puts his purposes above your own advancement.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to guard your heart against envy.
- Ask him to give you Jonathan's loyalty and David's patience.
- Thank Jesus for calling you his friend.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 250 · WEEK 36

# Psalm 7

*O LORD my God, in you do I take refuge*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 7. David prays when he has been falsely accused. Notice how he asks God to judge him, and how he trusts the Judge of all the earth.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title reads, "A Shiggaion of David, which he sang to the LORD concerning the words of Cush, a Benjaminite." We do not know who Cush was, but the setting is likely during the years when Saul, a Benjaminite, was pursuing David on false charges. The psalm is a cry for vindication from a man who has been slandered. It is placed here, right after the reading about Saul's pursuit.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "O LORD my God, in you do I take refuge; save me from all my pursuers and deliver me" (v. 1).
2. "O LORD my God, if I have done this, if there is wrong in my hands… then let the enemy pursue my soul and overtake it" (vv. 3-5).
3. "Arise, O LORD, in your anger… awake for me; you have appointed a judgment" (v. 6).
4. "God is a righteous judge, and a God who feels indignation every day" (v. 11).
5. "Behold, the wicked man conceives evil and is pregnant with mischief and gives birth to lies" (v. 14).
6. "He makes a pit, digging it out, and falls into the hole that he has made" (v. 15).
7. "His mischief returns upon his own head, and on his own skull his violence descends" (v. 16).

8 “I will give to the LORD the thanks due to his righteousness, and sing praise to the name of the LORD, the Most High” (v. 17).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David’s prayer here is bold. He asks God to examine him, and says that if he has done what his enemies say, then they may overtake him. This is not pride. It is a clear conscience before God on this particular charge. He is not claiming to be sinless, but he is saying that on this issue, he is innocent.

His great appeal is to God as judge. “God is a righteous judge.” When we are slandered, we are often tempted to take revenge or to defend ourselves at all costs. David takes the better way. He brings the case to the highest court and asks the Judge to rule. It is an act of trust, and it frees him from the need to retaliate. We will see this in his own behavior when he spares Saul’s life in the next chapters.

The image in verses 14 to 16 is memorable. The wicked person conceives, is pregnant with evil, and gives birth to lies. Evil has a life cycle. The person digs a pit for others, and falls into it himself. The universe has a moral structure, and sin often brings its own consequences. It is a warning to the wicked and a comfort to the wronged.

The psalm begins with refuge and ends with praise. The pattern is typical: David brings his case, rests it with God, and moves to thanksgiving before he has seen the verdict. The title of “Most High” for God reminds him that no earthly power can stand against the one who rules over everything.

The psalm is not an invitation to vindictiveness. It places justice in God’s hands. Paul would later say, “Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God” (Romans 12:19).

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus was falsely accused and “entrusted himself to him who judges justly” (1 Peter 2:23). He is the Righteous One, and he will return to judge the living and the dead (Acts 17:31). On the cross he committed his spirit to the Father (Luke 23:46). The wicked fall into their own pits, but the cross shows that God can turn even the pit into salvation (Acts 2:23-24).

STEP 6

## Application

If you have been falsely accused or treated unjustly, bring the case to God rather than defending yourself in anger.

Search your own heart honestly, as David did. Is there anything you need to confess?

Give thanks that God is a righteous judge.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to search your heart and show you where you have sinned.
- Leave in his hands a wrong done to you.
- Thank Jesus for trusting the Father with his cause.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

“Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart.”

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 251 · WEEK 36

# Psalm 11; Psalm 12

*In the LORD I take refuge; save, O LORD*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 11 and Psalm 12. Both psalms respond to a world where the foundations seem to be crumbling. Notice what David says about the LORD in each.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 11 was written when David's friends were advising him to flee like a bird to the mountains. Psalm 12 laments the decline of honest speech in the community. Both are attributed to David and fit the period of Saul's persecution, when the order of the kingdom was breaking down. They are paired here because together they address the question of what to do when righteousness seems to be losing.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "In the LORD I take refuge; how can you say to my soul, Flee like a bird to your mountain" (11:1).
2. "If the foundations are destroyed, what can the righteous do?" (11:3).
3. "The LORD is in his holy temple; the LORD's throne is in heaven; his eyes see, his eyelids test the children of man" (11:4).
4. "For the LORD is righteous; he loves righteous deeds; the upright shall behold his face" (11:7).
5. "Save, O LORD, for the godly one is gone; for the faithful have vanished from among the children of man" (12:1).
6. "Everyone utters lies to his neighbor; with flattering lips and a double heart they speak" (12:2).

7. “Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise, says the LORD; I will place him in the safety for which he longs” (12:5).

8. “The words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace on the ground, purified seven times” (12:6).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Psalm 11 begins with a tempting suggestion from friends: run. “The wicked bend the bow; they have fitted their arrow to the string to shoot in the dark at the upright in heart.” Things look dangerous, and the foundations of order are shaking. The question, “What can the righteous do?” is an honest one. David’s answer is not to deny the danger but to look past it: “The LORD is in his holy temple; the LORD’s throne is in heaven.” The foundations may shake, but the throne does not.

The point is that God sees. His eyes “test the children of man.” He is not absent, and he is not passive. He loves righteous deeds, and he will deal with the wicked. For those who trust him, the final promise is the best: “The upright shall behold his face.” To see God’s face is the greatest reward of the faithful.

Psalm 12 turns to a different danger: the corruption of speech. Lies, flattery, and the boasting of the proud have taken over. The godly seem to have vanished. Anyone who feels isolated in their commitment to truth will recognize the mood. David does not hide the situation, and he brings it to God.

God answers in the middle of the psalm, in his own voice. “Because the poor are plundered, because the needy groan, I will now arise.” He hears the groaning of the poor, and he acts. It is one of the most comforting words in the Psalter.

The contrast with human words is stark. The speech of men is double-hearted, but “the words of the LORD are pure words, like silver refined in a furnace.” When all speech around us is unreliable, the word of God is the one thing we can trust completely. He will keep us and guard us from this generation forever.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the truth (John 14:6), the Word who is himself pure and without deceit (1 Peter 2:22). Hebrews 12:27-28 speaks of receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken. He is in heaven now, at the right hand of the throne (Hebrews 8:1). Matthew 5:8 says, “Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God,” echoing Psalm 11:7. Revelation 22:4 says, “They will see his face.”

STEP 6

## Application

When you feel the urge to flee, remember that the LORD is on his throne.

Examine your own speech this week. Where is there flattery or exaggeration in it?

Open your Bible with trust that these words are pure and reliable.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God what feels shaken in your life right now.
- Ask him to keep your lips from flattery and your heart undivided.
- Thank him that his words are pure and trustworthy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 36

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 SAMUEL 16:7

DAY 252 · WEEK 36

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 1 Samuel 16:7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart."

1 SAMUEL 16:7

REST

## Meditation

God says this to Samuel as he stands before Jesse's oldest son, tall and impressive. It is a correction to every human way of judging.

"Man looks on the outward appearance." We evaluate people by how they look, speak, and perform. We do it to others, and we do it to ourselves. Entire industries run on this habit, and so do many of our fears. We worry about how we appear.

"But the LORD looks on the heart." God sees what is hidden. He sees motives, desires, loves, and fears. This can be frightening, because nothing is concealed from him. But it is also freeing. If he sees the heart, then the person who is overlooked, the one who is left with the sheep, may be the one he has chosen. And the one who looks impressive may be empty.

David was not chosen for his strength or his looks. The next passage says he was handsome, but that was not why. God saw a heart that was oriented toward him. Even so, David's heart was not perfect, as the coming chapters will show. The verse does not say that David's heart

was without sin, only that it was what God was looking for.

For the Christian, there is both warning and comfort. Warning, because religious appearances do not impress him. Comfort, because he sees our sincere faith even when we feel weak, and because the righteousness we stand in is not our own but Christ's. Pray the words of Psalm 139: "Search me, O God, and know my heart."

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you read of Saul's rejection and the choosing of David. You saw Jonathan's bold faith, and Saul's partial obedience in the war with Amalek, with Samuel's verdict that to obey is better than sacrifice. You read how God looked past Jesse's older sons to anoint the shepherd boy, and how David met Goliath in the name of the LORD of hosts. You saw Saul's jealousy grow, and the covenant friendship of David and Jonathan. In the Psalms you prayed with David in his weeping, and in a time of false accusation, and in a world where the foundations were shaking. The week taught that God judges by the heart, that the battle belongs to the LORD, and that he is a refuge for the oppressed.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

God looks at the heart and not at appearances. What part of your heart do you most need to bring into the light?

David was a shepherd who became a champion for his people. How does Jesus, the greater Shepherd and Champion, give you hope in a battle you cannot win?

Jonathan gave up his claim to the throne out of loyalty. Where is God asking you to put his purposes ahead of your own advancement?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Ask God to search your heart and lead you in the way everlasting.

Thank Jesus for fighting for you and winning.

Rest in his care today.

DAY 253 · WEEK 37

# Psalm 13; Psalm 14

*How long?, and: the LORD looks down from heaven*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 13 and Psalm 14. Psalm 13 is a short lament that ends in trust, and Psalm 14 describes the state of humanity without God. Read the two together.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Both psalms are attributed to David. Psalm 13 is the shortest of the great laments, with only six verses, and many readers have found that it expresses the experience of waiting on God better than any other. Psalm 14 is a sober assessment of human sin, which Paul quotes in Romans 3. They are paired in the Psalter, and here they sit during David's years on the run, when answers were slow to come.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "How long, O LORD? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?" (13:1).
2. "How long must I take counsel in my soul and have sorrow in my heart all the day?" (13:2).
3. "Light up my eyes, lest I sleep the sleep of death" (13:3).
4. "But I have trusted in your steadfast love; my heart shall rejoice in your salvation" (13:5).
5. "I will sing to the LORD, because he has dealt bountifully with me" (13:6).
6. "The fool says in his heart, There is no God" (14:1).
7. "The LORD looks down from heaven on the children of man, to see if there are any who understand, who seek after God" (14:2).

8 “They have all turned aside; together they have become corrupt; there is none who does good, not even one” (14:3).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The structure of Psalm 13 is a model for lament. First comes the complaint, four times repeated: “How long?” David feels forgotten, hidden from, and abandoned in his own thoughts. Second comes the request: “Consider and answer me, O LORD my God.” Third comes the turn: “But I have trusted in your steadfast love.” The final line is a vow of praise.

The turn is the key. Nothing has changed in David’s situation. There is no explanation of how the enemy will be defeated. What changes is that David decides to trust. The word “trusted” is in the past tense, as though he were holding on to what he already knows. He recalls the covenant love of God and remembers that he has been dealt with bountifully before. Lament leads to trust not by getting answers, but by returning to what God has already revealed about himself.

Psalm 14 is darker. The fool, in the Bible, is not someone of low intelligence but a person who lives as though there were no God. The fool says it “in his heart,” meaning that it is a practical atheism more than a formal argument. The result is corruption. The psalm describes God looking down over the whole human race and finding no one who seeks him.

This is a hard truth, and it is the basis of the gospel. “There is none who does good, not even one.” Human beings cannot find their own way to God. Paul uses these lines in Romans 3 to prove that all, Jew and Gentile, are under sin.

Yet the psalm ends with hope: “Oh, that salvation for Israel would come out of Zion!” If humans cannot save themselves, then salvation must come from God. And the psalm says that God is “the refuge” of the poor and that he is with the generation of the righteous.

STEP 5

## Connection

Paul quotes Psalm 14:1-3 in Romans 3:10-12 to show that all are under sin, and then shows that God’s righteousness comes by faith in Christ (Romans 3:21-26). Salvation did come out of Zion in Jesus (Romans 11:26). Jesus cried, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” (Matthew 27:46) so that we might never be forsaken. Ephesians 2:4-5 says that God, being rich in mercy, made us alive.

STEP 6

## Application

If you are in a long season of waiting, pray Psalm 13 aloud as your own.

Notice where you live as a practical atheist, making plans without God.

Thank God that salvation did come out of Zion.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God how long you have been waiting, and what for.

Confess where you have lived as though there were no God.

Thank him for sending salvation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 254 · WEEK 37

# 1 Samuel 21:1-23:29

*David flees; Ahimelech; David at Adullam*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 21:1-23:29. David is now a fugitive. Notice the mix of fear, faith, and God's guidance in these chapters, and read the horror of chapter 22 carefully.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

David has escaped from Saul's court and has nothing: no weapons, no army, and no safe place. He flees first to Nob, where the priest Ahimelech helps him, and then to Gath, to the cave of Adullam, and elsewhere. A band of distressed men gathers around him. Saul's pursuit becomes more violent, and the priests of Nob pay a terrible price. Through it all, David inquires of the LORD and is guided.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. David lies to Ahimelech and receives the bread of the Presence and Goliath's sword (21:1-9).
2. In Gath, David feigns madness before King Achish to escape (21:10-15).
3. At the cave of Adullam, "everyone who was in distress, and everyone who was in debt, and everyone who was bitter in soul, gathered to him" (22:2).
4. Doeg the Edomite reports David's visit to Nob, and at Saul's order he strikes down eighty-five priests (22:9-19).
5. Abiathar, one son of Ahimelech, escapes and joins David (22:20-23).
6. David asks the LORD, "Shall I go and attack these Philistines?" and the LORD says, "Go" (23:2).

7. Jonathan visits David and says, “You shall be king over Israel, and I shall be next to you” (23:16-17).
8. Saul almost captures David at the wilderness of Maon, but is called away by a Philistine raid (23:26-29).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David’s flight shows that being chosen by God is not the same as being comfortable. He has been anointed king, and he is in a cave. The pattern is clear in many Bible stories: before glory comes hardship, and God uses the wilderness to shape his servants. David was formed as a king in the same years that he was hunted as an outlaw.

His behavior in these chapters is mixed. His lie to Ahimelech has terrible consequences, and David later admits his responsibility: “I have occasioned the death of all the persons of your father’s house” (22:22). Scripture does not hide the flaws of its heroes. David is not the model king because he never fails. He is the model because he repents, inquires of the LORD, and clings to God’s promises.

The band that gathers at Adullam is striking. The distressed, the indebted, and the bitter come to him. This is a company of misfits, and David becomes their captain. It is an image of what a faithful king does: he receives those who have nowhere else to go.

The massacre at Nob is one of the darkest scenes in the book. Saul’s own officers refuse to touch the priests, and the Edomite Doeg does it. A king who began with the Spirit of God is now killing the LORD’s priests. The anger that began as envy ends in sacrilege.

Against the darkness, the LORD guides David. Again and again, David inquires through the ephod, and God answers. In chapter 23, the people of Keilah would betray him, but God warns him, and he escapes. Jonathan comes to him “and strengthened his hand in God.” The chapter ends with a narrow escape, which the place name records as “the Rock of Escape.”

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus, the Son of David, was also rejected by his own, and in his ministry those in distress, in debt, and bitter of soul gathered to him (Luke 15:1; Matthew 11:28). Jesus cited David’s eating of the bread of the Presence to show that mercy outranks ritual (Matthew 12:3-4). Hebrews 11:38 says of the faithful that they “wandered about in deserts and mountains and in dens and caves of the earth.”

STEP 6

## Application

If you are in a wilderness season, remember that God may be forming you.

Ask God for guidance in a decision, as David did, before you act.

Think about who the “distressed, indebted, and bitter” are around you, and how you might welcome them.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God about a wilderness where you feel he is forming you.
- Thank Jesus for welcoming those who have nowhere else to go.
- Ask him to strengthen you in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

“The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold.”

PSALM 18:2

DAY 255 · WEEK 37

# 1 Samuel 24:1-26:25

*David spares Saul twice; Abigail's wisdom*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 24:1-26:25. David has two chances to kill Saul, and he refuses both. Notice his reasoning each time, and how he deals with the foolish Nabal in chapter 25.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Saul pursues David with three thousand men. In a cave at En-gedi, Saul unknowingly enters the very cave where David and his men are hiding. In chapter 26, David finds Saul asleep in his camp. Between these two scenes comes the story of Nabal, a rich, foolish man who insults David, and Abigail, his wise wife, who prevents David from taking revenge. The three stories together form a lesson on restraint.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. David's men say, "Here is the day of which the LORD said to you, Behold, I will give your enemy into your hand" (24:4).
2. David cuts off a corner of Saul's robe, and his heart strikes him (24:5).
3. "I will not put out my hand against my lord, for he is the LORD's anointed" (24:10).
4. Saul weeps and says, "You are more righteous than I, for you have repaid me good, whereas I have repaid you evil" (24:17).
5. Nabal's name means "fool," and he insults David's men and refuses them bread (25:3-11).
6. Abigail brings food and says, "Let this be no cause of grief to my lord… that you have avenged yourself with your own hand" (25:31).
7. David says, "Blessed be the LORD… who has sent you this day to meet me! Blessed be your discretion" (25:32-33).

8. In chapter 26, David again spares Saul, and says, “The LORD rewards every man for his righteousness and his faithfulness” (26:23).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

These three chapters ask what we do when we have the power to repay a wrong. David is not a weak man. He has a company of warriors. He is fleeing for his life. Saul has tried to kill him many times. When he has the chance, his men tell him that God has given his enemy into his hand. They might even say it with scriptural confidence. But David will not touch the LORD’s anointed.

His reason is not weakness. It is faith. If God has promised him the throne, God will give it in his own time. David does not need to seize it. To kill Saul would be to take for himself what God has promised to give. Instead of grasping, he waits. This is the opposite of Saul’s attitude in 1 Samuel 13.

Nabal provides a test of a different kind. David’s anger is provoked by an ordinary insult, and he sets out to wipe out Nabal’s household. Abigail, wise and quick, intervenes. She brings gifts and speaks gracefully, and she reminds David of his calling. “Let it not be a cause of grief or pangs of conscience to my lord that you have shed blood without cause.” David hears her, and he praises God. It is a healthy sign that the king can be corrected, even by a woman he has never met.

Not every enemy is a Saul. Some are just fools. And the response is different. David is stopped by Abigail’s wisdom, and later Nabal dies when the LORD strikes him.

The refrain of the section is that vengeance belongs to the LORD. “The LORD will judge between me and you,” David says to Saul. When David leaves vengeance to God, he is free from guilt. And the lesson is not passivity, but trust that God will do justice.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus said, “Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you” (Matthew 5:44), and on the cross he prayed, “Father, forgive them” (Luke 23:34). Paul says, “Repay no one evil for evil… leave it to the wrath of God” (Romans 12:17-19). Peter holds up Christ as the one who “when he was reviled, did not revile in return” (1 Peter 2:23). Abigail is a peacemaker, like those Jesus called blessed (Matthew 5:9).

STEP 6

## Application

Name someone who has wronged you. Pray for them today, and entrust them to God.

Ask whether you are trying to take by your own hand something that God has promised to give.

Thank God for the people who have corrected you with wisdom.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Give God the desire to repay a wrong done to you.
- Ask him for David's restraint and Abigail's wisdom.
- Thank Jesus for praying for his enemies.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 256 · WEEK 37

# Psalm 18:1-30

*The LORD is my rock and my fortress*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 30 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 18:1-30. This is David's great song of deliverance. Today read the first half, with its images of rescue and its confession of who God is.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title says David spoke this song "to the LORD on the day when the LORD rescued him from the hand of all his enemies, and from the hand of Saul." It is also found, with small changes, in 2 Samuel 22, which you will read soon. Psalm 18 looks back on all of David's flight and sums up what he learned. It stands here at the end of the years of fleeing, as David's own testimony.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "I love you, O LORD, my strength" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold" (v. 2).
3. "The cords of death encompassed me; the torrents of destruction assailed me" (v. 4).
4. "In my distress I called upon the LORD; to my God I cried for help. From his temple he heard my voice" (v. 6).
5. "Then the earth reeled and rocked; the foundations also of the mountains trembled" (v. 7).
6. "He rode on a cherub and flew; he came swiftly on the wings of the wind" (v. 10).
7. "He sent from on high, he took me; he drew me out of many waters" (v. 16).

8. “He brought me out into a broad place; he rescued me, because he delighted in me” (v. 19).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm opens with love: “I love you, O LORD.” It is not an argument or a doctrine. It is an expression of the heart. And then David piles up images, seven of them in one verse: rock, fortress, deliverer, refuge, shield, horn of salvation, stronghold. He has been in caves and on cliffs, and he knows what a rock is. But he says that God is the true rock.

Then he describes the danger. The cords of death were around him. The torrents of destruction rushed at him. He was close to dying. And in that place, “I called upon the LORD.” This is the pattern of the whole Psalter: crying out, and being heard.

The description of God’s response is a spectacular poem. The earth shakes, smoke rises from his nostrils, he parts the heavens and comes down. The language is that of a storm and an earthquake, the imagery of the exodus and of Sinai. God comes to rescue one man in a cave. David is saying that the God of Sinai is the God who hears one frightened servant. His power is not remote but personal.

The rescue is described tenderly: “He drew me out of many waters.” The word for “drew” is the same as the one used for Moses (Exodus 2:10). “He brought me out into a broad place.” After years in narrow caves, David is brought to a spacious place. Why? “Because he delighted in me.” Behind the whole rescue is God’s delight in his servant. It is grace.

In verses 20 to 30, David speaks of his own righteousness. This must be read in context. He is not claiming sinlessness before God, but declaring that in the matter of his conflict with Saul, he has kept faith. And he rests on the principle that “with the merciful you show yourself merciful.” The final line of today’s reading is a famous one: “This God, his way is perfect; the word of the LORD proves true; he is a shield for all those who take refuge in him.”

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the ultimate rescued one. He was in the “cords of death,” and God raised him (Acts 2:24). Paul quotes verse 49 in Romans 15:9. Zechariah calls Christ “a horn of salvation” in Luke 1:69. Colossians 1:13 says that God “has delivered us from the domain of darkness.” And Psalm 18:2’s rock is Christ himself (1 Corinthians 10:4).

STEP 6

## Application

Begin your prayer today with “I love you, O LORD.” Mean it.

Write down a time God brought you into a “broad place” after a narrow one.

Read verse 30 slowly: “His way is perfect.” Where do you struggle to believe it?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God you love him, and say why.

Thank him for drawing you out of many waters.

Ask him to teach you to take refuge in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

“The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold.”

PSALM 18:2

DAY 257 · WEEK 37

# Psalm 18:31-50

*He trains my hands for war*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 18:31-50. The second half of David's song moves from God's character to David's victories, and ends in praise among the nations.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The first half of the psalm praised God as rescuer. The second half describes how God equips David for battle, gives him victory, and establishes his kingdom. It ends with a promise to praise God among the nations and a reference to "his anointed" and his offspring forever. This looks forward to the covenant you will read in 2 Samuel 7.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "For who is God, but the LORD? And who is a rock, except our God?" (v. 31).
2. "The God who equipped me with strength and made my way blameless" (v. 32).
3. "He makes my feet like the feet of a deer and sets me secure on the heights" (v. 33).
4. "You have given me the shield of your salvation, and your right hand supported me, and your gentleness made me great" (v. 35).
5. "You made me the head of the nations; people whom I had not known served me" (v. 43).
6. "The LORD lives, and blessed be my rock, and exalted be the God of my salvation" (v. 46).
7. "For this I will praise you, O LORD, among the nations, and sing to your name" (v. 49).
8. "Great salvation he brings to his king, and shows steadfast love to his anointed, to David and his offspring forever" (v. 50).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The second half of the psalm gives God credit for everything David has achieved. “The God who equipped me with strength.” “He trains my hands for war.” “You have given me the shield of your salvation.” David was a skilled warrior, but he does not say it. He says that God made him able. It is a model of how a believer should speak of any success.

One phrase stands out: “Your gentleness made me great.” The word is often translated “condescension” or “humility.” It is the picture of the great God bending down to raise a shepherd boy. David’s greatness is the result of God’s stooping. It is perhaps the most beautiful line in the psalm. God does not merely give power; he gives it with gentleness.

In verses 37 to 42, David describes his victories, in the strong language of ancient warfare. The point is not violence for its own sake, but the defeat of the enemies of God’s anointed. The nations that were hostile come to serve. David’s kingdom is established, and the psalm hints that it extends to people he had not known.

The ending is the most important part. David vows to praise God among the nations, a surprising foreshadowing of the mission of Israel to the world. And the last verse points beyond David: “Great salvation he brings to his king, and shows steadfast love to his anointed, to David and his offspring forever.” The promise is for David’s descendants. This is what God will say in the covenant of 2 Samuel 7.

The psalm is a model of how to remember. It begins with love and ends with a promise. Everything in between is thanksgiving for what God has done.

STEP 5

## Connection

Paul quotes verse 49 in Romans 15:9 to show that the Messiah praises God among the Gentiles. Jesus is “David’s offspring forever,” the anointed who brings great salvation (Luke 1:32-33). Matthew 11:29 says that Jesus is “gentle and lowly in heart.” Philippians 2:5-11 shows him humbling himself and being exalted. Hebrews 2:13 puts words of Psalm 18 on Christ’s lips.

STEP 6

## Application

When you succeed at something, practice saying, “God equipped me.”

Think about a time when God’s gentleness, not force, brought you through.

Pray for the nations to come to praise him.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for equipping and supporting you.

Thank him for his gentleness that makes you great.

Pray that his salvation would reach the nations.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 258 · WEEK 37

# Psalm 54; Psalm 59

*O God, save me by your name; deliver me from my enemies*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 16 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 54 and Psalm 59. Both come from the years when David was hunted by Saul, and both are brief prayers of someone surrounded by enemies. Notice how each ends.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 54 has the title "when the Ziphites went and told Saul, Is not David hiding among us?" (see 1 Samuel 23:19). Psalm 59 was written "when Saul sent men to watch his house in order to kill him" (see 1 Samuel 19:11). They are two snapshots from the same terrifying period, in which David was betrayed by neighbors and cornered in his own home.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "O God, save me by your name, and vindicate me by your might" (54:1).
2. "For strangers have risen against me; ruthless men seek my life; they do not set God before themselves" (54:3).
3. "Behold, God is my helper; the Lord is the upholder of my life" (54:4).
4. "With a freewill offering I will sacrifice to you; I will give thanks to your name, O LORD, for it is good" (54:6).
5. "Deliver me from my enemies, O my God; protect me from those who rise up against me" (59:1).
6. "They come back at evening, howling like dogs and prowling about the city" (59:6).
7. "O my Strength, I will watch for you, for you, O God, are my fortress" (59:9).
8. "But I will sing of your strength; I will sing aloud of your steadfast love in the morning. For you have been to me a fortress and a refuge in the day of my distress" (59:16).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Psalm 54 is among the shortest prayers in the Psalter, and it is a model of how to pray when under pressure. There are three movements. First, a cry for help. Second, a statement of trust: “Behold, God is my helper.” Third, a vow of thanksgiving. The “Behold” invites us to look. David is surrounded by enemies, but he asks us to look at the one who is on his side.

The Ziphites were from David’s own tribe of Judah. He was betrayed by his own people. This hurts. In the psalm, he describes them as “strangers,” and says they do not set God before them. The people we expect to defend us sometimes fail.

Psalm 59 comes from a house under siege. Saul’s men wait outside to kill David in the morning, and Michal helps him escape through a window. The psalm uses the image of dogs prowling at night, hungry, circling the city. It is a picture of terror. And yet the psalm repeatedly describes God as a fortress and a strength. David does not try to defeat the dogs. He turns to the one who is higher.

An important feature is the contrast between night and morning. The enemies prowl at evening. David sings in the morning. The long night of fear gives way to the dawn of praise. He says he will “watch” for God, like a watchman waiting for the sun.

What makes these psalms Christian prayers is the closing note. David promises to sing about the steadfast love of God, even before he has been rescued. This is faith that praises in advance. The believer does not wait for a perfect outcome before giving thanks.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus was betrayed by one of his own (John 13:18), and those who came to arrest him came at night with swords and clubs (Luke 22:52-53). Psalm 59:4-5 and 54:3 describe the hostility Jesus faced. Paul says, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31). Hebrews 13:6 quotes Psalm 118 but echoes the same confidence: “The Lord is my helper; I will not fear.”

STEP 6

## Application

Memorize Psalm 54:4, “Behold, God is my helper.” Repeat it when you feel alone.

If you have been betrayed by someone close, bring it to God. He knows.

Practice morning praise: begin tomorrow by singing of his steadfast love.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God about those who surround or trouble you.
- Ask him to be your fortress and refuge.
- Sing of his strength and love in your own words.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 37

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

DAY 259 · WEEK 37

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 18:2 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold."

PSALM 18:2

REST

## Meditation

This verse comes from a man who has lived in caves and on cliffs, and who knows what shelter is worth. David loads one sentence with seven images of God.

A rock is solid ground. When everything else is shifting, it holds. A fortress is a strong place that an enemy cannot enter. A deliverer pulls out of danger. A refuge is a place to hide, and a shield is a defense held up between you and an arrow. A horn of salvation is a symbol of strength and victory, like the horn of a wild ox. A stronghold is a high place that cannot be reached.

Each image answers a different fear. When you feel unstable, God is a rock. When you feel attacked, he is a fortress and a shield. When you are trapped, he is a deliverer. When you are exposed, he is a refuge. When you feel weak, he is a horn of salvation. When you feel

overwhelmed, he is a stronghold. David does not say that God gives these things. He says that God is these things.

Notice the repeated "my." David is not describing a general idea of divine power. He is speaking of the LORD as his own. It is personal faith.

Christians have always read this verse in the light of Christ. He is the rock (1 Corinthians 10:4), the cornerstone (1 Peter 2:6), the shield of faith's defender (Ephesians 6:16), and the horn of salvation raised up for us (Luke 1:69). Each time you read this verse, you may fill in the name of Jesus.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you followed David as a fugitive. You read how the priests at Nob were slaughtered, how the distressed and the indebted gathered to David at Adullam, and how God guided him through the wilderness. You saw David spare Saul twice, and you saw Abigail turn aside his anger against Nabal. In the Psalms, you heard David's love for the LORD in Psalm 18, his testimony of rescue and the God who equips with gentleness, and prayers in Psalms 54 and 59 from the hardest nights. The week taught that vengeance belongs to the LORD, that waiting is an act of faith, and that the God who delivers is both a rock and a gentle helper.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

David refused to seize the throne by force and waited on God's timing. What is God asking you to wait for rather than grab?

David praised God as rock, fortress, and deliverer. Which of those images do you most need this week, and how does Jesus fulfill it?

Abigail's wisdom turned David from a sin. Who has God used to correct you, and how might you thank them?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that he is your rock, fortress, and deliverer.

Thank him for the gentleness that makes you great.

Rest in his protection today.

DAY 260 · WEEK 38

# Psalm 64; Psalm 70

*Hide me from the wicked; make haste, O God, to deliver me*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 64 and Psalm 70. One is a prayer against slander and secret plots, and the other is a short cry for speedy help. Notice how each ends with confidence.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

These two psalms are attributed to David and belong to the years of his persecution. Psalm 64 speaks of hidden enemies who sharpen their tongues like swords, and Psalm 70 is a five-verse petition, repeated almost word for word in Psalm 40:13-17. Both are brief, urgent, and honest.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “Hear my voice, O God, in my complaint; preserve my life from dread of the enemy” (64:1).
2. “Who whet their tongues like swords, who aim bitter words like arrows” (64:3).
3. “They hold fast to their evil purpose; they talk of laying snares secretly, thinking, Who can see them?” (64:5).
4. “But God shoots his arrow at them; they are wounded suddenly” (64:7).
5. “Then all mankind fears; they tell what God has brought about and ponder what he has done” (64:9).
6. “Let the righteous one rejoice in the LORD and take refuge in him!” (64:10).
7. “Make haste, O God, to deliver me! O LORD, make haste to help me!” (70:1).
8. “But I am poor and needy; hasten to me, O God! You are my help and my deliverer; O LORD, do not delay!” (70:5).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Psalm 64 is about the weapon of the tongue. David's enemies do not use swords. They use words, and they use them in secret. "They talk of laying snares secretly, thinking, Who can see them?" It is the voice of a conspiracy, of whispering and plotting. Slander is among the oldest weapons, and it is hard to defend against because it works in the dark.

David's answer is to bring the matter to God, who sees what is hidden. The whole psalm turns on the reversal of verse 7. The enemies shoot arrows from ambush, but God shoots an arrow at them. The ones who thought no one could see them are seen. "They are wounded suddenly." The tongues they used against others are turned back on themselves.

The result is awe. All mankind fears, and tells what God has done. The justice of God, when it falls, is a lesson to the world. And the righteous rejoice and take refuge. The psalm ends not with revenge, but with refuge.

Psalm 70 is shorter and more urgent. "Make haste" appears twice. David is in an emergency, and he does not pretend otherwise. His request is simple: help me, now. He describes himself as "poor and needy." It is the best position from which to pray. The person who knows they have nothing to offer can only receive.

Even in this hurried prayer, there is room for the praise of others: "May all who seek you rejoice and be glad in you! May those who love your salvation say evermore, God is great!" David cannot help thinking of others.

Together these prayers teach us two things. First, God sees what is done in secret. Second, we may pray urgently and simply, and we do not need elaborate words.

STEP 5

## Connection

James 3:5-8 calls the tongue a fire and a restless evil, and Jesus warned that we will give an account for every careless word (Matthew 12:36). He was himself the target of plots made in secret (Mark 14:1). Psalm 64:3 is echoed in Revelation, and the "arrow" language has a New Testament counterpart in Romans 12:19. The poor and needy have a special place with Christ (Matthew 5:3; 2 Corinthians 8:9).

STEP 6

## Application

If you have been the target of gossip, bring it to God. He sees what is hidden.

Examine your own tongue. Is there a whisper you should stop?

When you need help urgently, pray Psalm 70:5 as a short prayer.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to protect you from slander and to keep your tongue from harming others.
- Tell him you are poor and needy.
- Ask him to hasten to help you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 261 · WEEK 38

# 1 Samuel 27:1–31:13

*David among the Philistines; the witch of Endor; Saul's death*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 78 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Samuel 27:1-31:13. These chapters show David in Philistine territory, Saul's last night, and the end of Saul's reign. Read chapter 28 and chapter 31 with care.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Weary of running, David says in his heart, "I shall be swept away one day by the hand of Saul," and he takes refuge among the Philistines at Ziklag. Saul, meanwhile, faces the Philistine army at Gilboa with no word from God. He goes to a medium at Endor. The book ends with Saul's defeat and death on Mount Gilboa. It is a sober ending to the story of Israel's first king.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. David lives among the Philistines for a year and four months and raids the Geshurites and Amalekites (27:1-12).
2. Saul, afraid, inquires of the LORD, "but the LORD did not answer him, either by dreams, or by Urim, or by prophets" (28:6).
3. Saul disguises himself and visits the medium at Endor, though he himself had expelled mediums (28:3, 7-8).
4. The spirit says, "Tomorrow you and your sons shall be with me" (28:19).
5. David returns to Ziklag to find it burned and the families taken, and "David strengthened himself in the LORD his God" (30:6).
6. David pursues and recovers everything, and divides the spoil fairly (30:7-25).

7. The Philistines defeat Israel at Gilboa; Jonathan and his brothers are killed, and Saul falls on his sword (31:1-6).
8. The men of Jabesh-gilead remember Saul's rescue of their city, and recover his body (31:11-13).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David's choice to live among the Philistines is a low point for him. He is tired, and his faith slips. "David said in his heart, Now I shall perish." He does not ask the LORD. The man who has inquired of God so faithfully now decides on his own. He lies to the king of Gath and raids Israel's enemies while pretending to raid Judah. It is a messy period, and the narrative does not hide it. Even a man after God's own heart can have seasons of fear.

Saul's last night is among the saddest in the Bible. God is silent. And Saul, who had banished mediums, seeks out a medium. When the spirit appears, it announces the end of his kingdom and his life. Saul falls to the ground in terror and has no strength left. He had refused to obey God when he was able, and now God does not answer. It is a picture of the cost of persistent rebellion.

Chapter 30 is the counterweight. David returns to find Ziklag burned and his wives and children captured. His own men talk of stoning him. This is his lowest moment. And here is the most important sentence: "David strengthened himself in the LORD his God." He turns to God. He asks through the ephod, and God says, "Pursue, for you shall surely overtake and shall surely rescue." And so it happens.

The contrast with Saul is deliberate. Saul, in distress, consults a medium. David, in distress, strengthens himself in the LORD. Their endings differ accordingly.

Chapter 31 closes the story of Saul with a death that is tragic rather than triumphant. He dies in battle with his sons. Yet the men of Jabesh-gilead show loyalty and honor him. The book ends not with David's triumph but with a funeral. The way to the throne is open, but it is paved with grief.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus was tempted to take shortcuts but trusted the Father (Matthew 4). Hebrews 3:12-13 warns against hardening our hearts in unbelief. When Jesus was alone in the garden he found his strength in prayer (Luke 22:43-44). Paul says, "Be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might" (Ephesians 6:10), and, "I can do all things through him who strengthens me" (Philippians 4:13).

STEP 6

## Application

When you are discouraged, practice “strengthening yourself in the LORD.” What does that look like for you?

Think about where you turn first when you are afraid. Is it God, or something else?

Pray for someone who has hardened their heart to listen again.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what makes you afraid, and ask him to strengthen you.

Ask him to keep you from seeking answers in the dark.

Thank Jesus, who turned to the Father and never failed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

“Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.”

PSALM 20:7

DAY 262 · WEEK 38

# 2 Samuel 1:1-3:39

*David mourns Saul; anointed over Judah; Ish-bosheth*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 1:1-3:39. David grieves for Saul and Jonathan, and becomes king, first over Judah and then over a divided kingdom. Read his lament in chapter 1 carefully.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The second book of Samuel opens with a messenger bringing news of Saul's death. David's response is grief, not triumph. After the lament, God directs David to Hebron, where he is anointed king over Judah. For seven and a half years, there is civil war between David's house and the house of Saul. Abner, Saul's commander, eventually switches sides, and is murdered by Joab.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. A man claims to have killed Saul and brings his crown to David. David has him executed because he "stretched out your hand to destroy the LORD's anointed" (1:14-16).
2. David's lament: "How the mighty have fallen!" (1:19, 25, 27).
3. "Saul and Jonathan, beloved and lovely! In life and in death they were not divided" (1:23).
4. "I am distressed for you, my brother Jonathan; very pleasant have you been to me; your love to me was extraordinary, surpassing the love of women" (1:26).
5. David inquires of the LORD, goes up to Hebron, and is anointed king over Judah (2:1-4).
6. "There was a long war between the house of Saul and the house of David. And David grew stronger and stronger" (3:1).

7. Abner makes a covenant with David, and Joab kills Abner in revenge for his brother (3:12-27).
8. David mourns Abner and says, “Do you not know that a prince and a great man has fallen this day in Israel?” (3:31-38).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David’s first act as the next king is to weep. The man who brings Saul’s crown expects a reward, but David has him killed. David has consistently honored Saul as the LORD’s anointed, and he will not profit from his death, even by a messenger’s lie. There is no gloating in his heart.

The lament in chapter 1 is a work of poetry and of real love. David praises Saul, who had pursued him for years, and Jonathan, his friend. He does not mention Saul’s failures. He mourns a king who fell, and he honors the good. The refrain “How the mighty have fallen!” echoes through the poem like a bell. It teaches that grief for the fallen is compatible with God’s judgment, and that we should be slow to speak ill of the dead.

When David is anointed in Hebron, he is told to go there by the LORD. He inquires. He has learned the lesson of dependence. But notice that he does not rush to take the whole kingdom. The war between the houses lasts seven years. He waits, and “David grew stronger and stronger, while the house of Saul grew weaker and weaker.”

The story of Abner and Joab shows the dangers of power. Abner brings the northern tribes over to David, a great peace. But Joab, for personal revenge, murders Abner. It is a stain on David’s reign. David declares his innocence, curses Joab’s house, and mourns publicly. He composes another lament for Abner. The people are pleased, “for all the people took note of it.” Yet David admits, “I am this day weak, though anointed king” (3:39). He is aware of the limits of his power.

The chapters teach that God’s promise is fulfilled slowly. David is king, but he must still grieve, wait, and deal with violence in his own camp.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41) and at the tomb of Lazarus (John 11:35). He too was anointed king and had to wait for his kingdom. Hebrews 2:8-9 says, “At present, we do not yet see everything in subjection to him. But we see him… crowned with glory and honor.” Paul says, “Rejoice with those who rejoice, weep with those who weep” (Romans 12:15).

STEP 6

## Application

Think of someone who has hurt you and has since died or fallen. Can you honor what was good in them?

Wait on God for what he has promised. Do not force the timing.

Grieve honestly over the losses in your life, and bring them to him.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Ask God to teach you to grieve well and honor the fallen.

Ask him to make you patient as you wait for his promises.

Thank Jesus, the King who wept and will reign.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 263 · WEEK 38

# Psalm 20

*May the LORD answer you in the day of trouble*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 20. It is a prayer for the king before he goes into battle. Read it as a congregation praying for its leader.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 20 is a royal psalm "of David," in which the people pray for the king as he goes out to war. The speakers shift between "we" and "I," as the congregation prays and the king, or a priest, answers. David is now king, and the psalms of his kingship begin. After the long years of flight, the nation has a king whose success depends on God.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "The LORD answer you in the day of trouble! The name of the God of Jacob protect you!" (v. 1).
2. "May he send you help from the sanctuary and give you support from Zion" (v. 2).
3. "May he remember all your offerings and regard with favor your burnt sacrifices" (v. 3).
4. "May he grant you your heart's desire and fulfill all your plans!" (v. 4).
5. "May we shout for joy over your salvation, and in the name of our God set up our banners!" (v. 5).
6. "Now I know that the LORD saves his anointed; he will answer him from his holy heaven" (v. 6).
7. "Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God" (v. 7).
8. "O LORD, save the king! May he answer us when we call" (v. 9).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

This psalm shows how a community prays for its leader. The people do not simply hope that the king will win. They ask the LORD to answer him, protect him, support him, and fulfill his plans. It is a model of intercessory prayer. A nation is stronger when its people pray for those who lead.

The psalm assumes that the king is a servant of God. His offerings are remembered. His plans are the plans God grants. Success is not the king's alone. The people shout for joy over "your salvation," but they raise their banners in "the name of our God." The glory goes to God.

The turning point is verse 6. A voice declares, "Now I know that the LORD saves his anointed." It is a statement of settled confidence. The prayer has been answered in the heart of the one who prays. This is common in the Psalms: prayer ends with certainty before the outcome is seen.

Verse 7 is the center of the psalm, and one of the most quoted lines in the Psalter. "Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God." Chariots and horses were the superweapons of the ancient world. Israel was told never to multiply horses (Deuteronomy 17:16). The psalm declares that real security is found in God's name, not in military power. In our time the chariots and horses may be money, technology, connections, or intelligence.

The closing line is a prayer that has become a national anthem for Israel: "O LORD, save the king!" In time, Israel's kings would fail, and this prayer would point to the King who does not.

STEP 5

## Connection

The "anointed" of this psalm is the Messiah. Jesus was the king who went to battle against sin and death, and the Father heard him (Hebrews 5:7). "In the day of trouble" echoes his Gethsemane prayer. 1 Timothy 2:1-2 calls us to pray for kings and all in authority. Paul says that we trust "not in ourselves but in God who raises the dead" (2 Corinthians 1:9).

STEP 6

## Application

Pray this psalm for a leader you know: a pastor, a boss, a government official.

Name your "chariots and horses," the things you trust in apart from God.

Pray "O LORD, save the king" with Jesus in mind, who reigns now.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what you trust in when trouble comes, and what you want to trust instead.

Ask him to answer those who lead you in the day of trouble.

Raise your banner in his name by telling him why you trust him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 264 · WEEK 38

# Psalm 21

*The king rejoices in your strength*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 13 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 21. It is the companion to Psalm 20. There the people prayed for the king before battle, and here they give thanks for his victory.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 21 is a royal psalm of thanksgiving, likely used at a celebration of the king's accession or a victory. Psalms 20 and 21 should be read together, as a prayer followed by a praise. The king is a figure of joy in God's strength, and the psalm points beyond David to a king whose reign has no end.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "O LORD, in your strength the king rejoices, and in your salvation how greatly he exults!" (v. 1).
2. "You have given him his heart's desire and have not withheld the request of his lips" (v. 2).
3. "For you meet him with rich blessings; you set a crown of fine gold upon his head" (v. 3).
4. "He asked life of you; you gave it to him, length of days forever and ever" (v. 4).
5. "His glory is great through your salvation; splendor and majesty you bestow on him" (v. 5).
6. "For you make him most blessed forever; you make him glad with the joy of your presence" (v. 6).
7. "For the king trusts in the LORD, and through the steadfast love of the Most High he shall not be moved" (v. 7).

8 “Be exalted, O LORD, in your strength! We will sing and praise your power” (v. 13).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Where Psalm 20 asked, Psalm 21 gives thanks. The pattern is a reminder that prayer is not only petition. Many of us ask and forget to thank. The people here return to God to say that he has answered. The king’s heart’s desire has been given. The language is of overflowing generosity: rich blessings, a crown of gold, glory, splendor, majesty.

A phrase in verse 4 is striking: “He asked life of you; you gave it to him, length of days forever and ever.” In terms of the historical David, “forever” might be read as a long life, or as the length of his dynasty. But “forever and ever” reaches further. It points to a king who will live and reign eternally. Psalm 21 asks us to read it with more than David in mind.

The root of the king’s blessing is stated at the end: “For the king trusts in the LORD.” His strength is not his own. The word “trusts” is the key to his success. He will not be moved, “through the steadfast love of the Most High.” The king’s security rests on God’s covenant love.

Verses 8 to 12 describe judgment on the king’s enemies. The imagery is strong: a fiery furnace, a consuming fire. These lines are not an invitation to violence, but a recognition that the reign of the LORD’s anointed brings the end of all who oppose him. It is a theme that runs from Psalm 2 to Revelation.

The psalm closes with a collective song. The people return their gaze from the king to the LORD: “Be exalted, O LORD, in your strength!” The king is blessed, but the center is always God.

STEP 5

## Connection

Hebrews 5:7-9 speaks of Christ who asked for deliverance from death and was heard. “Length of days forever and ever” is fulfilled in his resurrection (Acts 2:24-28; Revelation 1:18). “The joy of your presence” echoes Acts 2:28 and Hebrews 12:2. The crown of gold points to Revelation 14:14, where the Son of Man wears a golden crown. Philippians 2:9-11 says God has highly exalted him.

STEP 6

## Application

Make a list of ways God has answered prayer in the last month, and thank him for each.

Ask what it means to rejoice in his strength rather than your own.

Give thanks for the King who lives forever.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank God for answered prayer and good gifts.
- Thank Jesus, who asked for life and was given it forever.
- Ask him to be exalted in his strength in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

“Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.”

PSALM 20:7

DAY 265 · WEEK 38

# 2 Samuel 4:1-6:23

*David king over all Israel; Jerusalem captured; the ark*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 4:1-6:23. David is made king over all Israel, takes Jerusalem, and brings the ark to the city. Notice the contrast between the two attempts to move the ark.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After Abner's death, Ish-bosheth, Saul's son, is murdered by two of his own captains, and the northern tribes come to David at Hebron. He is anointed king over all Israel. He then captures the Jebusite city of Jerusalem and makes it his capital. The ark of the covenant, which had been in obscurity since 1 Samuel 7, is brought to the city, but not without tragedy.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. David has Ish-bosheth's murderers executed, saying, "How much more, when wicked men have killed a righteous man in his own house" (4:11).
2. All the tribes come to Hebron and say, "You shall be shepherd of my people Israel, and you shall be prince over Israel" (5:2-3).
3. David takes the stronghold of Zion, "that is, the city of David" (5:7).
4. "And David became greater and greater, for the LORD, the God of hosts, was with him" (5:10).
5. David defeats the Philistines twice, inquiring of the LORD each time (5:17-25).
6. The ark is carried on a new cart, and Uzzah reaches out to steady it and dies (6:1-8).
7. David fears the LORD that day and leaves the ark with Obed-edom, whom God blesses (6:9-11).

8. David dances “before the LORD with all his might” and Michal despises him in her heart (6:14-16).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David’s rise to the throne over all Israel is the fulfillment of what God promised through Samuel. It is not the result of his own plotting. He has waited. When the tribes come to him, they acknowledge what God had said: “You shall be shepherd of my people Israel.” The term “shepherd” is a reminder of where David came from and what a king is for.

The capture of Jerusalem makes the city “the city of David.” It will become the center of Israel’s worship and, ultimately, of the story of salvation. The narrator says plainly why David succeeded: “The LORD, the God of hosts, was with him.” His greatness is a gift.

The story of the ark in chapter 6 is a lesson on how to approach a holy God. The first attempt copies the Philistines’ method, with a new cart. The ark was to be carried by the Levites on poles. When the cart is shaken, Uzzah reaches out and is struck down. It seems harsh, and David is angry and afraid. But the lesson is that God’s holiness is not to be handled casually, even with good intentions. Good motives do not override God’s instructions.

The second attempt, three months later, is done correctly, with sacrifices and with joy. David dances before the LORD, wearing a linen ephod. He is not too proud to be undignified before God. Michal looks down on him from a window. Her scorn is the scorn of those who prefer propriety to passion. David’s answer is that he will be “even more contemptible than this” for the LORD’s sake.

The chapters show a king who inquires of God, who is awed by his holiness, and who rejoices in his presence. This is the heart of true worship: reverence and joy together.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the true presence of God in the midst of his people (John 1:14). He rode into Jerusalem while the crowds rejoiced (Matthew 21:8-9), and some wanted the disciples to be silenced (Luke 19:39-40). Hebrews 12:28 says, “Let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe.” Acts 5 shows a similar fear of God’s holiness in the early church.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask if your worship is a mix of reverence and joy, or leans heavily in one direction.

Look at where you are doing a good thing in a way God did not instruct.

Think about whether you are afraid of looking foolish in worship, and ask God to free you.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to teach you to worship with both reverence and joy.
- Confess where you have handled his word lightly.
- Thank him that in Jesus he is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 38

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

DAY 266 · WEEK 38

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 20:7 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God."

PSALM 20:7

REST

## Meditation

This verse sets two kinds of trust side by side. It is a simple contrast, but it asks a searching question: where does your confidence rest?

Chariots and horses were the strongest military technology of the ancient Near East. An army with them was thought to be unbeatable. Israel was told not to depend on them (Deuteronomy 17:16; Isaiah 31:1). The psalm does not say that chariots are useless. It says that the people of God have a different foundation.

What are our chariots and horses? They are whatever we lean on for security instead of God. For some it is a bank account. For others, it is a résumé, a network of influential friends, good health, a clever plan, or a disciplined routine. These things are not evil. They are gifts. But when we trust in them, they become idols, and they fail.

“We trust in the name of the LORD our God.” In the Bible, a name stands for the whole person. To trust in God’s name is to trust in who he is: faithful, powerful, merciful, covenant-keeping. And notice the “we.” This is a community statement. We say it together, as a church.

The contrast in the next verse is vivid: “They collapse and fall, but we rise and stand upright.” Those who trust in horses fall. Those who trust in God stand.

For the Christian, the name of the LORD has been revealed in Jesus. “There is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved” (Acts 4:12). Hold this verse when you are tempted to feel safe because of something other than him.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you followed the end of Saul and the rise of David. You read Saul’s last night, when God was silent and he turned to a medium, and David’s response in his own low moment: he strengthened himself in the LORD his God. You read David’s lament over Saul and Jonathan, and how he became king first over Judah and then over all Israel. You saw him take Jerusalem and bring the ark to the city, after the sobering lesson of Uzzah. In the Psalms, you prayed for the king in Psalm 20 and gave thanks for him in Psalm 21. The week taught that God’s anointed trusts in the name of the LORD, that God’s holiness must be honored, and that true worship joins reverence with joy.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

David strengthened himself in the LORD when everything was taken from him. What does that look like for you in a hard season?

Psalm 21 says the king trusts in the LORD and will not be moved. How does Jesus, the King who trusted perfectly, give you security when you feel shaken?

What are the “chariots and horses” you are most tempted to trust? What would it look like to trust in the name of the LORD instead?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that you trust in his name and not in chariots.

Thank him for the King who trusts him perfectly.

Rest in his strength today.

DAY 267 · WEEK 39

# 2 Samuel 7:1-29

*The Davidic Covenant, the throne, the son, the kingdom forever*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 7:1-29. This is the pivotal chapter of the books of Samuel and one of the most important in the whole Bible. Read it slowly, twice if you can. It is the anchor of this unit.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

David is settled in his palace in Jerusalem, and the LORD has given him rest from his enemies. He feels it is wrong that he lives in a house of cedar while the ark dwells in a tent. He tells the prophet Nathan that he wants to build a house for God. God responds, through Nathan, with a promise that turns David's plan inside out. This is the Davidic covenant.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. David says, "See now, I dwell in a house of cedar, but the ark of God dwells in a tent" (7:2).
2. The LORD says, "Would you build me a house to dwell in?... I took you from the pasture, from following the sheep, that you should be prince over my people Israel" (7:5-8).
3. "I will make for you a great name, like the name of the great ones of the earth" (7:9).
4. "The LORD declares to you that the LORD will make you a house" (7:11).
5. "I will raise up your offspring after you... and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever" (7:12-13).
6. "I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son. When he commits iniquity, I will discipline him with the rod of men" (7:14).
7. "But my steadfast love will not depart from him" (7:15).

8 “And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever” (7:16).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David’s desire is good. He wants to honor God. But God’s reply reverses the direction. David wants to build a house for God, and God says that he will build a house for David. The word “house” is used in two senses: a building and a dynasty. God will give David a lasting line of kings. The initiative belongs to God, and the covenant is one of pure promise. David has done nothing to earn it. He was a shepherd, and God made him a king.

The promises are staggering. A great name. A place for Israel, secure from enemies. A son who will build the temple. And above all, a throne established forever. Verse 13 says that God will establish the throne of the kingdom “forever,” and verse 16 repeats it. This is a promise that no human king can fulfill by himself, for every king dies. Even Solomon, the immediate son, will fall. The promise points to a royal line that does not end, and ultimately to a king who lives forever.

Verse 14 is also important. The king is called God’s son: “I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son.” This echoes Psalm 2. It is a statement about the closeness between God and the Davidic king. If the king sins, he will be disciplined, but the covenant will not be cancelled. This differs from Saul. God’s steadfast love is the basis. The promise is unconditional in its ultimate outcome and personal in its fatherly discipline.

David’s prayer in response is one of the most beautiful in Scripture. He goes in and sits before the LORD, and says, “Who am I, O Lord GOD, and what is my house, that you have brought me thus far?” He is overwhelmed. He praises God’s greatness and his choosing of Israel. And he ends with a humble request: “Do as you have promised.” He rests on the word of God.

In the larger story, this chapter is the pivot. All the earlier covenants, with Abraham, with Israel at Sinai, narrow now to a king from David’s line. All the later prophecy points to this son of David. The Bible becomes the story of the search for the promised King.

STEP 5

## Connection

The New Testament opens with “the book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David” (Matthew 1:1). Gabriel tells Mary that “the Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever” (Luke 1:32-33). Peter says that David “being a prophet… foretold the resurrection of the Christ” (Acts 2:30-31). Hebrews 1:5 quotes 2 Samuel 7:14 of Jesus. Revelation 22:16: “I am the root and the descendant of David.”

STEP 6

## Application

Read David's prayer in verses 18 to 29 aloud as your own prayer of thanksgiving.

Ask where you are trying to do something for God when he is asking you to receive something from him.

Thank God that the throne of David is held forever by Jesus.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what it means that he has brought you this far.

Thank him for the promise to David and its fulfillment in Jesus.

Ask him to establish what he has begun in you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 268 · WEEK 39

# Psalm 22:1-21

*My God, my God, why have you forsaken me, the suffering king*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 22:1-21. This is the psalm Jesus quoted from the cross. Read it in its own setting first, as David's cry. Then read it again with Good Friday in mind.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is a psalm of David, titled "According to The Doe of the Dawn." We do not know the event that prompted it, and it uses language that goes beyond anything recorded in David's life. It begins in the deepest abandonment and ends in universal praise. Placed after the covenant of 2 Samuel 7, it shows that the promised King will suffer before he reigns. Today's reading covers the first twenty-one verses, the lament.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from saving me?" (v. 1).
2. "O my God, I cry by day, but you do not answer, and by night, but I find no rest" (v. 2).
3. "But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people" (v. 6).
4. "All who see me mock me; they make mouths at me; they wag their heads" (v. 7).
5. "He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him; let him rescue him, for he delights in him!" (v. 8).
6. "I am poured out like water, and all my bones are out of joint; my heart is like wax" (v. 14).

7. “For dogs encompass me; a company of evildoers encircles me; they have pierced my hands and feet” (v. 16).

8. “They divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots” (v. 18).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Read as David’s own cry, this psalm describes the experience of feeling abandoned by God while surrounded by enemies. The opening words are shocking. “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” David does not say, “Why have you stopped helping?” He says, “You have forsaken me.” The Bible permits us to pray the language of felt abandonment. It does not hide it.

But even in the question, there is faith. He still says “My God.” The psalm contains a long review of what God has done in the past: “In you our fathers trusted; they trusted, and you delivered them.” David cannot square the past with the present. This tension is the heart of a lament. He does not resolve it with a quick answer. He keeps praying.

The imagery is graphic. “A worm and not a man.” Mockers wag their heads. “I am poured out like water.” Bones out of joint. A tongue stuck to the jaws. A pack of dogs. Hands and feet pierced. Garments divided by lot. David describes his suffering in terms that go far beyond what history records of him. These details were fulfilled in the death of Jesus, almost word for word.

At the end of the section the tone shifts. Verses 19 to 21 are a cry for help: “But you, O LORD, do not be far off! O you my help, come quickly to my aid!” He finishes with “You have rescued me from the horns of the wild oxen.” Even in the pit, he knows who to call.

This psalm shows us that the suffering of the righteous is not a sign of God’s absence. It is part of the pattern of how God’s anointed enters into glory. It prepares us for the cross.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus cried the first line of this psalm from the cross (Matthew 27:46; Mark 15:34). The mockery of verses 7 and 8 is repeated by the passersby and chief priests (Matthew 27:39-43). The dividing of garments is quoted in John 19:24. The thirst of verse 15 is in John 19:28. The piercing of hands and feet is seen in the crucifixion itself. Jesus entered the darkness of abandonment so that we would never be truly forsaken (2 Corinthians 5:21; Hebrews 13:5).

STEP 6

## Application

If you are in a season of feeling far from God, pray this psalm. Do not hide.

Read the crucifixion account in John 19 alongside this psalm, and notice the details.

Thank Jesus that he was forsaken so you would not be.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank Jesus for being forsaken so that you would not be.

Tell God where you feel far from him.

Praise him that he is near and has not hidden his face.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 269 · WEEK 39

# Psalm 24

*Lift up your heads, O gates, the King of glory enters*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 24. Read it as a processional song, with questions and answers. Picture the ark being carried up to the city, and the gates opening to receive the King.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

You read Psalm 24 earlier, in Unit 6, as part of the story of the temple and God's presence. Here it appears again, in its natural setting after the ark's arrival in Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6). It is likely the very song sung when David brought the ark up to Zion. Today, read it with that scene in mind, and notice how it moves from the whole earth to a single hill, and from the hill to the King who enters.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein" (v. 1).
2. "For he has founded it upon the seas and established it upon the rivers" (v. 2).
3. "Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD? And who shall stand in his holy place?" (v. 3).
4. "He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who does not lift up his soul to what is false" (v. 4).
5. "He will receive blessing from the LORD and righteousness from the God of his salvation" (v. 5).
6. "Lift up your heads, O gates! And be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in!" (v. 7).

7. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD, strong and mighty, the LORD, mighty in battle!” (v. 8).

8. “Who is this King of glory? The LORD of hosts, he is the King of glory!” (v. 10).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm has three movements, and the second reading adds a layer to each. First, a declaration: the whole earth belongs to the LORD. He made it and holds it together. The God who has come to Zion is not a local deity. He is the Creator of all. When David brought the ark to Jerusalem, he was bringing the throne of the God of the whole earth.

Second, a question: “Who shall ascend the hill of the LORD?” Having just read of Uzzah, the question is sharp. Not everyone can approach God in any way they like. The answer is a person of clean hands and a pure heart, whose actions and desires are right. But no one fits that description perfectly. The question hangs over the reader, and it prepares for the good news that someone has fulfilled it.

Third, a procession. The company reaches the gates of the city and calls on them to open. The call-and-response is dramatic: “Who is this King of glory?” The answer comes: “The LORD, strong and mighty.” Then the call is made again, and the answer is expanded: “The LORD of hosts.” The king who comes is the commander of the heavenly armies.

Having read the account of the ark’s arrival, we see how the psalm fits. The ark, a symbol of God’s throne, is brought into the city. But no gate in Jerusalem could finally contain him. The psalm points beyond the ark to the day when the King of glory would truly enter the city.

The key move is from the heights to the humble. The one who owns the whole earth comes to a particular hill. The one who is infinitely holy invites sinners to come near, if they are clean. The gospel is that he makes us clean.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the one with clean hands and a pure heart, the only one who can ascend the hill of the LORD. He entered Jerusalem as King (Matthew 21:9), and he ascended into heaven, where the gates are lifted for him (Hebrews 4:14; Ephesians 4:8-10). We ascend with him by faith, clothed in his righteousness (2 Corinthians 5:21; Hebrews 10:19-22). Paul quotes verse 1 in 1 Corinthians 10:26.

STEP 6

## Application

Thank God that your access to him does not depend on your clean hands, but on Christ’s.

Look at how you treat what you have. If the earth is the LORD's, so are your possessions.

Open the gates of your heart to the King of glory today.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Open a gate in your life for the King of glory, and name it.
- Thank Jesus, who ascended with clean hands and clothes you in his righteousness.
- Praise God that the earth and everything in it is his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 270 · WEEK 39

# 2 Samuel 8:1-10:19

*David's victories; Mephibosheth, covenant kindness*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 58 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 8:1-10:19. David's kingdom reaches its height, and he shows kindness to Mephibosheth. Notice what David does with the covenant love he has received.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After the covenant of chapter 7, the narrative shows the LORD giving David victory on every side. Chapter 8 summarizes his conquests and his administration. Chapter 9 turns from war to mercy, as David seeks out any survivor of Saul's house to show kindness for Jonathan's sake. Chapter 10 returns to war with the Ammonites and Arameans. This is the high point of David's reign.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "And the LORD gave victory to David wherever he went" (8:6, 14).
2. "So David reigned over all Israel. And David administered justice and equity to all his people" (8:15).
3. David asks, "Is there still anyone left of the house of Saul, that I may show him the kindness of God?" (9:3).
4. Mephibosheth, Jonathan's son, is crippled in both feet and living in Lo-debar (9:3-5).
5. "Do not fear, for I will show you kindness for the sake of your father Jonathan, and I will restore to you all the land of Saul your father, and you shall eat at my table always" (9:7).
6. Mephibosheth bows and says, "What is your servant, that you should show regard for a dead dog such as I am?" (9:8).

7. “So Mephibosheth lived in Jerusalem, for he ate always at the king’s table. Now he was lame in both his feet” (9:13).

8. Joab says, “Be of good courage, and let us be courageous for the sake of our people, and for the cities of our God, and may the LORD do what seems good to him” (10:12).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Chapter 8 is a record of success, and it is framed by the repeated phrase, “The LORD gave victory to David wherever he went.” David’s reign is blessed because God is with him. He also dedicates the plunder to the LORD (8:11). The chapter closes with a summary of his administration, and with the key statement that he “administered justice and equity to all his people.” A king’s greatness is measured by his justice.

Chapter 9 is the gem of the section. It is a story of grace. Saul’s family was David’s enemy. Under the customs of the time, a new king would eliminate the old dynasty’s heirs. Instead, David asks, “Is there anyone left that I may show the kindness of God?” The phrase “kindness of God” means covenant faithfulness (the Hebrew word is the one translated “steadfast love”). He is acting out of a promise he made to Jonathan (1 Samuel 20:14-17).

Mephibosheth is a picture of every sinner. He was lame in both feet, hiding in a place called Lo-debar (“no pasture”), thinking of himself as a dead dog. He expected death. Instead, he is called, brought to the king’s table, given land, and treated as one of the king’s sons. “You shall eat at my table always.” He did nothing to earn it. He was invited because of what the king promised to another.

The scene ends with a line that is easy to miss: “Now he was lame in both his feet.” His condition did not change. He was seated at the king’s table with his disability intact. Grace does not require us to be healed before we are welcomed.

Chapter 10 returns to war and shows the other side of the king. But David is no longer the man who fears. He trusts the LORD for the result.

STEP 5

## Connection

The story of Mephibosheth is a picture of the gospel. We were far from the King, crippled by sin, and expecting judgment. But for the sake of the Son, we are brought near and seated at the table (Ephesians 2:13; Luke 22:29-30). Jesus invited the lame and the poor to his banquet (Luke 14:13-23). Revelation 19:9 speaks of the marriage supper of the Lamb. Titus 3:4-5 speaks of the kindness of God our Savior.

STEP 6

## Application

Think of yourself as Mephibosheth. Let the picture of being brought to the table sink in.

Ask who in your life needs "the kindness of God" from you, someone who expects nothing.

Remember that you do not have to be fixed before you come to Jesus.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank God for his kindness to you, shown for the sake of his Son.
- Ask him to teach you to show that kindness to someone who cannot repay it.
- Thank him for a seat at his table.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 271 · WEEK 39

# 2 Samuel 11:1-12:31

*David and Bathsheba; Nathan's rebuke*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 11:1-12:31. This is the darkest chapter of David's life. Read it slowly and honestly. Notice how sin grows, how Nathan confronts it, and what God says in response to David's repentance.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

It is spring, when kings go out to war, but David stays in Jerusalem. From his roof he sees a woman bathing. What follows is adultery, deception, and murder. After months of silence, the prophet Nathan is sent to confront him. The chapters record the cost of David's sin and the shape of true repentance.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "In the spring of the year, the time when kings go out to battle, David sent Joab... But David remained at Jerusalem" (11:1).
2. David sees Bathsheba, sends for her, and sleeps with her. She becomes pregnant (11:2-5).
3. David tries to cover it up by recalling Uriah from battle, and when that fails, has Joab put Uriah in the front line to be killed (11:6-25).
4. "But the thing that David had done displeased the LORD" (11:27).
5. Nathan tells a parable about a rich man who takes a poor man's only lamb, and says, "You are the man!" (12:1-7).
6. "I anointed you king over Israel... Why have you despised the word of the LORD, to do what is evil in his sight?" (12:7-9).

7. David says, “I have sinned against the LORD.” Nathan replies, “The LORD has put away your sin; you shall not die” (12:13).

8. “Nevertheless… the child who is born to you shall die” (12:14). David worships, and later Solomon is born, “and the LORD loved him” (12:15-25).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The sin begins with an idle moment. David was not where he should have been. He sees, wants, takes. He moves from lust to adultery, to the abuse of power, to deception, to murder. At each step he tries to cover the previous sin with a worse one. It is a picture of how sin multiplies. The narrator does not excuse him. The king who should have been guarding justice becomes its violator. The phrase “But David remained at Jerusalem” is where the story starts to unravel.

For a year, he seems to have gotten away with it. But “the thing that David had done displeased the LORD.” God sends Nathan, who tells a story. David’s anger is aroused against the rich man in the parable, and he pronounces judgment. Then Nathan says, “You are the man.” It is the moment of truth. The king who judged others is judged himself.

God’s words through Nathan are heartbreaking. He recounts what he has given David and says, “If this were too little, I would add to you as much more.” David despised God’s word and did evil. It is an act of ingratitude as well as of lust.

David’s response is brief and real. “I have sinned against the LORD.” There is no excuse, no blaming. And Nathan answers with some of the most precious words in the Old Testament: “The LORD has put away your sin; you shall not die.” Forgiveness is immediate and complete. But consequences remain. The child dies, and the sword will not depart from David’s house. Grace does not cancel the effects of sin in this world.

The scene shows both the severity and the mercy of God. He does not ignore sin, even in his favorite. And he does not refuse forgiveness to the one who confesses. At the end, God gives the couple a son, Solomon, whom he loves.

STEP 5

## Connection

Paul says, “Where sin increased, grace abounded all the more” (Romans 5:20). Paul quotes Psalm 32, which David wrote after this episode, in Romans 4:6-8 as a description of justification by faith. Matthew’s genealogy mentions “Uriah’s wife” (Matthew 1:6), reminding us that Jesus came through this broken line. Christ is the greater David who, unlike David, never abused his power, and who laid down his life instead of taking another’s.

STEP 6

## Application

Look for places where you are “staying home” when you should be at your post. What is the first step you could take away from temptation?

If you are hiding something, bring it to God now. Do not wait for a Nathan.

Remember that forgiveness is real and complete, even when consequences remain.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Confess honestly where you have sinned, and do not cover it.
- Ask him to keep you from the “roof” where temptation finds you.
- Thank Jesus for bearing the sin you confess.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

“And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever.”

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 272 · WEEK 39

# Psalm 32

*Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 32. David wrote this after the events of the last reading. It is a song of forgiveness, and one of the great teaching psalms in the Bible.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title calls it "A Maskil of David," meaning a song of instruction. It seems to reflect on the period after his sin with Bathsheba, the silence of the months when he hid it, and the relief that came when he confessed. It is one of the seven traditional penitential psalms, but it is characterized more by joy than by sorrow. Placed right after Day 271, it tells the other side of the story.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Blessed is the one whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered" (v. 1).
2. "Blessed is the man against whom the LORD counts no iniquity, and in whose spirit there is no deceit" (v. 2).
3. "For when I kept silent, my bones wasted away through my groaning all day long" (v. 3).
4. "For day and night your hand was heavy upon me; my strength was dried up as by the heat of summer" (v. 4).
5. "I acknowledged my sin to you, and I did not cover my iniquity; I said, I will confess my transgressions to the LORD, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin" (v. 5).
6. "You are a hiding place for me; you preserve me from trouble; you surround me with shouts of deliverance" (v. 7).

7. “I will instruct you and teach you in the way you should go; I will counsel you with my eye upon you” (v. 8).

8. “Many are the sorrows of the wicked, but steadfast love surrounds the one who trusts in the LORD” (v. 10).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with a double blessing, and uses three words for sin: transgression, sin, and iniquity. Each is matched with a word for forgiveness: forgiven, covered, and not counted. The piling up of terms shows how thoroughly God deals with every type of wrong. He lifts it away, covers it, and does not count it against us.

David then describes the misery of hiding his sin. His body suffered. His bones wasted away. God’s hand was heavy on him. The groaning went on all day. The guilt of unconfessed sin is not just a spiritual problem. It touches the whole person. David knew by experience that silence and concealment do not work. They drain strength like summer heat.

Then comes the turn, in verse 5: “I acknowledged my sin to you.” Notice the three verbs: acknowledged, did not cover, confessed. And the result: “You forgave.” The speed of it is striking. David says he will confess, and God forgives. This is the same forgiveness Nathan announced. God is not reluctant. He is eager to forgive.

The rest of the psalm shows what follows from forgiveness. God becomes a hiding place. The man who ran from God now runs to him. God also becomes a teacher: “I will instruct you.” The forgiven person is ready to learn. And God’s counsel is personal, “with my eye upon you.” The forgiven are guided, not like a mule that needs a bit and bridle, but like a person who follows willingly.

The final verses are an invitation to the whole community: “Be glad in the LORD, and rejoice, O righteous, and shout for joy, all you upright in heart!” Forgiveness leads to joy.

STEP 5

## Connection

Paul uses verses 1 and 2 in Romans 4:6-8 as proof that God justifies the ungodly by faith, and not by works. “Blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.” This is the heart of justification: the imputing of righteousness and the non-imputing of sin. Christ became sin for us, so that we might become the righteousness of God (2 Corinthians 5:21). 1 John 1:9 says, “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us.”

STEP 6

## Application

If there is any sin you are hiding, confess it today. Do not wait.

Read verses 1 and 2 as a description of your status in Christ.

Ask God to counsel you with his eye upon you. Then listen.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Acknowledge your sin to God without covering it.
- Thank him for the forgiveness that makes you blessed.
- Ask him to be your hiding place.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 39

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 273 · WEEK 39

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read 2 Samuel 7:16 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. This is the anchor verse for the whole unit. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

REST

## Meditation

This verse is the center of the unit. It is God's promise to David, spoken through Nathan, and it is one of the most important sentences in the Old Testament.

"Your house." David wanted to build God a house, and God promises to build his. This is a dynasty, a line of descendants who will sit on the throne. Every promise in the Bible after this moment hangs on this one thread: a son of David.

"And your kingdom." It is not just a family that is promised, but a realm. The kingdom of David is the kingdom of God's rule on earth, carried out through a human king.

"Shall be made sure forever before me." The word "sure" means firm and established. The promise rests on God's own faithfulness. David's later sin would not cancel it. His descendants' failures would not cancel it. God said it, and it stands.

“Your throne shall be established forever.” The repetition of “forever” is key. Every king in the line of David died. Solomon, in all his glory, fell into idolatry. The kingdom was divided, and the last king of Judah was taken to Babylon in chains. Yet the promise was never withdrawn. The prophets kept saying that a son of David would come, who would reign forever. Isaiah called him “the Prince of Peace.”

For the Christian, this verse is fulfilled in Jesus. “He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High. And the Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end” (Luke 1:32-33). When you say this verse, you are saying that Jesus reigns. Memorize it. It is a promise that cannot fail.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week brought David to the throne and to the center of God’s plan. You read the end of Saul at Gilboa and the lament of David over Saul and Jonathan. You saw David anointed over all Israel, take Jerusalem, and bring the ark up with dancing. You read the heart of the unit, the covenant of 2 Samuel 7, in which God promised David a house, a kingdom, and a throne forever. You saw David’s grace to Mephibosheth, and then the dark chapters of his sin with Bathsheba and his repentance. In the Psalms you prayed for the king in Psalm 20, gave thanks in Psalm 21, and heard the cry of Psalm 22, which Jesus prayed on the cross. Psalm 24 welcomed the King of glory, and Psalm 32 celebrated forgiveness. The week taught that God keeps his promises to David in spite of David’s sin, and that the true King would suffer and reign.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

God took David from the pasture and made him king, without any merit on David’s part. What has God done for you that you did not earn?

The covenant promised a son of David whose throne would last forever. How does Jesus fulfill this promise, and what does his reign mean for your life this week?

David hid his sin until Nathan confronted him, and then he confessed and was forgiven. Is there something you have been hiding? What would it look like to bring it into the light?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for the promise to David and for Jesus, whose throne lasts forever.

Thank him for forgiveness that covers every sin.

Ask him to make you tender to his word.

DAY 274 · WEEK 40

# Psalm 51

*Create in me a clean heart, David's penitential psalm*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 19 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 51. You read this psalm earlier in Unit 6. Today read it in its original setting, as David's prayer right after Nathan confronted him. Read it slowly, as his own words.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title says, "A Psalm of David, when Nathan the prophet went to him, after he had gone in to Bathsheba." You met this psalm in Unit 6 as a general prayer of repentance. Having now read 2 Samuel 11 and 12, you can hear it as a particular man's prayer after a particular fall. Notice how little he says about the circumstances, and how much he says about God and his own heart.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions" (v. 1).
2. "Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin!" (v. 2).
3. "Against you, you only, have I sinned and done what is evil in your sight" (v. 4).
4. "Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me" (v. 5).
5. "Purge me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow" (v. 7).
6. "Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me" (v. 10).
7. "Cast me not away from your presence, and take not your Holy Spirit from me" (v. 11).
8. "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise" (v. 17).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David begins with God's character, not his own record. "According to your steadfast love... according to your abundant mercy." He has no defense and no excuse, so he asks for mercy. Three words for sin appear again, as in Psalm 32: transgression, iniquity, and sin. And three requests: blot out, wash, cleanse. He knows the problem is deep.

Verse 4 is surprising. "Against you, you only, have I sinned." David had sinned against Bathsheba and Uriah and the nation. Yet he says that the offense is against God. This does not deny the harm to others, but recognizes that every sin is first of all a rebellion against the Creator, whose law has been broken. When we see sin at that level, we understand why it requires forgiveness, not just repair.

Verse 5 is not an excuse but a confession of depth. David realizes that his sin did not come out of nowhere. It flows from a nature that has been bent since birth. The problem is not only what he did, but what he is. He needs more than a new start. He needs a new heart, and so he prays, "Create in me a clean heart." The verb "create" is the one used in Genesis 1. Only God can make a new heart from nothing.

He also asks, "Take not your Holy Spirit from me." He had seen what happened to Saul. His fear is of losing God's presence, not of losing the throne. Then he asks for the joy of salvation and for a willing spirit.

The psalm ends with the great principle: "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit." God does not need religious performance as a substitute for repentance. A broken and contrite heart he will not despise. He receives the one who comes with nothing.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the answer to David's prayer. By his blood we are washed (1 John 1:7; Revelation 1:5), and in him we are a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17). Ezekiel 36:26 promises a new heart and the gift of the Spirit, fulfilled in the new covenant. Jesus said, "Blessed are the poor in spirit" (Matthew 5:3), and told the story of the tax collector who cried, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner!" (Luke 18:13).

STEP 6

## Application

Use this psalm as a pattern for confession. Pray through it slowly, line by line.

Ask for more than forgiveness. Ask for a clean heart and a right spirit.

Thank God that he does not despise a broken and contrite heart.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Pray Psalm 51 in your own words, naming what needs cleansing.
- Ask him to create a clean heart and a right spirit in you.
- Ask him not to take his Spirit from you, and thank him for Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

“Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me.”

PSALM 51:10

DAY 275 · WEEK 40

# 2 Samuel 13:1-14:33

*Amnon and Tamar; Absalom's revenge*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 13:1-14:33. These chapters show the first consequences of David's sin: violence and division within his own house. Read them with sorrow. They are painful.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Nathan told David that "the sword shall never depart from your house" (12:10). Chapters 13 and 14 show that word beginning to come true. David's son Amnon rapes his half-sister Tamar. Her brother Absalom murders Amnon, and flees. After three years, Joab arranges for Absalom's return. The family that David has built is breaking apart.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. Amnon desires Tamar, and on the advice of Jonadab, pretends to be ill and asks that Tamar bring him food (13:1-9).
2. Tamar says, "No, my brother, do not violate me, for such a thing is not done in Israel" (13:12).
3. Amnon rapes her and then hates her "with very great hatred" and throws her out (13:14-17).
4. "When King David heard of all these things, he was very angry" (13:21). He does nothing.
5. Absalom says nothing to Amnon, "either good or bad," for he hated him (13:22).
6. After two years, Absalom has Amnon killed at a sheep-shearing feast, and flees to Geshur (13:23-38).

7. A wise woman of Tekoa, sent by Joab, tells David a story about two sons, so that he will bring Absalom back (14:1-20).
8. Absalom returns, but David will not see him for two years, and when they finally meet, "the king kissed Absalom" (14:28-33).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

These chapters are among the saddest in the Bible. The violence in David's house echoes his own sin. A son takes what he wants from a woman. A father fails to act. Another son murders in revenge. The pattern of David's sins, desire, deception, and bloodshed, is repeated by his children. Children often imitate what their parents have done, and they usually take it further.

Tamar is the innocent victim. Her words to Amnon are wise and clear, and she even tells him to ask the king to give her to him in marriage. He will not hear. After the assault, she tears her robe and puts ashes on her head and lives "a desolate woman" in Absalom's house. The Bible does not minimize her pain. Her story reminds readers that the effects of abuse are real, and that God sees. Her cry, "Where could I carry my shame?" is heard.

David's failure is the lack of action. "He was very angry," says the text, but he does nothing. The Greek and Dead Sea texts add that he did not rebuke Amnon "because he was his firstborn and he loved him." David's own guilt may have left him unable to discipline his sons. A leader who has lost moral authority through unrepented sin cannot easily correct others.

Absalom's two years of silence is a picture of bitterness that is growing. Then the murder. His flight and the ensuing exile set the stage for the rebellion in chapters 15 to 18. David's half-hearted attempt to deal with the matter, bringing Absalom home but keeping him from his presence, solves nothing. Reconciliation without truth does not heal.

The tragedy is that David's confession and God's forgiveness did not remove the consequences. Forgiveness restores our relationship with God. It does not undo what we have set in motion. This is why sin is so serious, and why the cross is so necessary.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the opposite of David as a father and king. He defends the vulnerable and rebukes oppressors (Matthew 23:14; Mark 9:42). He is the one who "binds up the brokenhearted" (Isaiah 61:1; Luke 4:18). Hebrews 12:15 warns against a "root of bitterness" that causes

trouble. Ephesians 4:26-27 warns against letting anger give the devil a foothold. Galatians 6:7 says, “Whatever one sows, that will he also reap.”

STEP 6

## Application

If you are a parent or leader, ask where you have failed to act when you should have.

Pray for those who have suffered abuse. Ask God to help you listen and believe.

Examine any bitterness you are nursing, and bring it to God before it grows.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Pray for those who have been wronged, and for comfort for the desolate.
- Ask him to keep you from nursing bitterness.
- Ask him to give leaders courage to act justly.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

“Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me.”

PSALM 51:10

DAY 276 · WEEK 40

# 2 Samuel 15:1-17:29

*Absalom's rebellion; David flees Jerusalem*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 15:1-17:29. Absalom leads a rebellion, and David flees Jerusalem. Notice how David responds, and how God works behind the scenes through Hushai and Ahithophel.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Absalom has spent years winning the hearts of the people at the city gate. At last he declares himself king at Hebron, and David, hearing that "the hearts of the men of Israel have gone after Absalom," flees Jerusalem on foot. This is the setting for Psalm 3. These chapters are a long account of betrayal, loyalty, and the hidden hand of God.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Absalom stole the hearts of the men of Israel" (15:6).
2. David leaves the city, weeping, barefoot, with his head covered, and says, "If I find favor in the eyes of the LORD, he will bring me back" (15:25-30).
3. Ittai the Gittite swears loyalty: "As the LORD lives, and as my lord the king lives, wherever my lord the king shall be, whether for death or for life, there also will your servant be" (15:21).
4. David prays, "O LORD, please turn the counsel of Ahithophel into foolishness" (15:31).
5. Hushai pretends loyalty to Absalom, to counter Ahithophel's advice (15:32-37; 17:5-14).
6. Shimei curses David, and David says, "Let him alone, and let him curse, for the LORD has told him to" (16:5-14).

7. “For the LORD had ordained to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel, so that the LORD might bring harm upon Absalom” (17:14).
8. Ahithophel sets his house in order and hangs himself (17:23).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Absalom’s rebellion is the working out of Nathan’s prophecy. His method is subtle. He wins people by flattery, by promising justice, and by acting like a friend of the common man. It is a pattern of political manipulation as old as humanity: a man who “steals hearts” by appearing to offer what the king does not. He is charming, handsome, and ruthless.

David’s response is remarkable for its humility. He could fight. But he leaves the city, weeping, barefoot. He does not cling to the throne. Even the ark, which Zadok brings out, he sends back: “If I find favor in the eyes of the LORD, he will bring me back… But if he says, I have no pleasure in you, behold, here I am, let him do to me what seems good to him.” David has learned that he cannot manipulate God. He accepts whatever God decides.

His humility is tested by Shimei, who throws stones and curses him. David’s men want to kill Shimei. David says to leave him. Perhaps God has told him to curse. This is not weakness but a grasp that God may be using even insult to discipline him.

The contest between Ahithophel and Hushai shows God’s hidden providence. Ahithophel’s counsel was said to be like the word of God. David prays that it will be turned into foolishness. Hushai gives Absalom worse advice, and Absalom accepts it. The narrator tells us plainly: “The LORD had ordained to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel.” God was at work behind the scenes, though no miracle was seen. Ahithophel, seeing that his advice was rejected, hangs himself.

The lesson is that God’s purposes are not defeated by human betrayal. He works through ordinary decisions, conversations, and even through bad advice.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus, too, left the city, crossed the Kidron, and went up the Mount of Olives weeping, and he was betrayed by one of his own counselors (2 Samuel 15:23, 30; John 18:1; Luke 22:47-48; Luke 19:41). Judas, like Ahithophel, hanged himself (Matthew 27:5). Jesus declared that the Father’s will would be done. And Romans 8:28 says that God works all things together for good.

STEP 6

## Application

Practice David's humility: in a conflict, ask, "What if God is using this to teach me?"

Think about a time when God's hidden hand turned something for good, and thank him.

Pray, as David did, for wisdom and for confusion of plans that oppose his purposes.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to give you David's humility when you are wronged.
- Thank Jesus for being betrayed by his own for you.
- Trust him with what is happening behind the scenes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 277 · WEEK 40

# Psalm 63

*O God, you are my God; earnestly I seek you*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 63. David prays in the wilderness of Judah. Read it as a song of longing and satisfaction. Notice how much it says about desire for God.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title reads, “A Psalm of David, when he was in the wilderness of Judah.” This may refer to the days when he fled from Saul, or when he fled from Absalom and crossed the wilderness near the Jordan (2 Samuel 15:23; 16:2, 14). Today it fits well with the last reading. A king in exile, with nothing, finds that he still has what matters most.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “O God, you are my God; earnestly I seek you; my soul thirsts for you; my flesh faints for you, as in a dry and weary land where there is no water” (v. 1).
2. “So I have looked upon you in the sanctuary, beholding your power and glory” (v. 2).
3. “Because your steadfast love is better than life, my lips will praise you” (v. 3).
4. “So I will bless you as long as I live; in your name I will lift up my hands” (v. 4).
5. “My soul will be satisfied as with fat and rich food, and my mouth will praise you with joyful lips” (v. 5).
6. “When I remember you upon my bed, and meditate on you in the watches of the night” (v. 6).
7. “For you have been my help, and in the shadow of your wings I sing for joy” (v. 7).
8. “My soul clings to you; your right hand upholds me” (v. 8).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The setting is a desert, and the images are thirst and hunger. David has lost his palace, his bed, and his table. Yet in the wilderness he finds that what he truly wants is God himself. “My soul thirsts for you; my flesh faints for you.” It is the language of deep desire. This is not a lukewarm interest in religion. It is the longing of someone who knows he cannot live without God.

He remembers the sanctuary. He has seen God’s glory there. The memory of worship sustains him in a place where there is no sanctuary. Past experiences of God, stored in the heart, can carry us through dry seasons. This is why corporate worship and memory matter.

The central statement is verse 3: “Your steadfast love is better than life.” This is an extraordinary claim. David loves life. Yet he declares that God’s love is better. It is the confession of a man who has been stripped of everything except God and has found it to be enough. In the Bible, the greatest good is not life, comfort, or safety, but God’s steadfast love.

The satisfaction he describes in verse 5 is the answer to the thirst in verse 1. In the desert he is feasting. The paradox is that those who thirst for God are satisfied by him. He meditates on God in the night, lifting his hands in the darkness. He senses the shelter of God’s wings, a picture of a parent bird.

Verse 8 balances the whole psalm: “My soul clings to you; your right hand upholds me.” There is a double movement. David clings, and God holds. Faith is a grasping, and also a being held. Both are true.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus said, “Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be satisfied” (Matthew 5:6), and “If anyone thirsts, let him come to me and drink” (John 7:37). Philippians 3:8 shows Paul counting everything as loss for the sake of knowing Christ. Jesus also went into the wilderness and drew near to the Father (Luke 5:16). Revelation 7:16-17 promises that the redeemed will no more hunger or thirst.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask if your desire for God is a thirst, or only a habit. Ask him to increase it.

In the next dry or lonely time, recall a moment when you knew God’s presence.

Say aloud, “Your steadfast love is better than life.” Where do you struggle to believe it?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God what your soul thirsts for.
- Tell him that his love is better than life, and why.
- Ask him to uphold you as you cling to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 278 · WEEK 40

# Psalm 61

*Hear my cry, O God; lead me to the rock*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 61. It is a short prayer from the ends of the earth. Notice the images of rock, tent, and wings.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 61 is attributed to David and is traditionally linked to his exile east of the Jordan, during Absalom's rebellion, when he felt "from the end of the earth." It follows Psalm 63 in this reading as a second prayer from the wilderness. It is only eight verses, but it reaches from the farthest place to the king's throne.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Hear my cry, O God, listen to my prayer" (v. 1).
2. "From the end of the earth I call to you when my heart is faint" (v. 2).
3. "Lead me to the rock that is higher than I" (v. 2).
4. "For you have been my refuge, a strong tower against the enemy" (v. 3).
5. "Let me dwell in your tent forever! Let me take refuge under the shelter of your wings!" (v. 4).
6. "For you, O God, have heard my vows; you have given me the heritage of those who fear your name" (v. 5).
7. "Prolong the life of the king; may his years endure to all generations!" (v. 6).
8. "May he be enthroned forever before God; appoint steadfast love and faithfulness to watch over him!" (v. 7).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with an honest statement of distance and weakness. David is far from home, and his heart is faint. The phrase “the end of the earth” conveys that he is as far from help as he can imagine. Yet he calls. Prayer does not depend on proximity. We can pray from anywhere, to a God who hears.

His request is vivid: “Lead me to the rock that is higher than I.” The prayer recognizes that he cannot reach safety on his own. The rock is higher than he is. He needs to be led. It is an admission of dependence. We cannot climb to safety by our own strength, and God must bring us there.

The language of refuge builds: a rock, a strong tower, a tent, the shelter of wings. David has seen all kinds of shelters, and he knows what he needs. In the middle of the psalm, he declares a desire to “dwell in your tent forever.” It is a longing for permanent communion, not just a rescue.

Then, surprisingly, he prays for the king. “Prolong the life of the king.” David is speaking of himself in the third person, or speaking of the king as an office. In either case, his prayer extends beyond his own survival to the continuance of the royal line. He asks that steadfast love and faithfulness would “watch over him.” It connects with 2 Samuel 7, the covenant that David has received.

The psalm ends in vow-keeping: “So will I ever sing praises to your name, as I perform my vows day after day.” Prayer and praise are daily acts.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus, the true king whose years “endure to all generations,” is the Rock that is higher than we are (1 Corinthians 10:4). He is the tent where God dwells with man (John 1:14; Revelation 21:3), and he spoke of gathering Jerusalem “as a hen gathers her brood under her wings” (Matthew 23:37). Hebrews 7:25 says that he “always lives to make intercession” for those who draw near to God through him.

STEP 6

## Application

When you feel far away, pray this prayer: “From the end of the earth I call to you.”

Pick a metaphor from verses 2 to 4 (rock, tower, tent, wings) and spend time with it.

Pray for the leaders of your church and nation, as David prayed for the king.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Cry to God from wherever you are today.
- Ask him to lead you to the rock higher than you.
- Thank him for the King who reigns forever.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 279 · WEEK 40

# 2 Samuel 18:1-19:43

*Absalom defeated; David restored, grief and kingship*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 18:1-19:43. Absalom is defeated and killed, and David mourns. Notice David's grief and Joab's rebuke, and how David is restored to Jerusalem.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

David's forces, led by Joab, Abishai, and Ittai, meet Absalom's army in the forest of Ephraim. David has told his commanders to deal gently with Absalom. The battle goes to David, but Absalom is caught by his hair in a tree and killed by Joab. David's grief is so great that it threatens the victory. Slowly, he is brought back across the Jordan and restored.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. David commands, "Deal gently for my sake with the young man Absalom" (18:5).
2. Absalom's mule runs under an oak, and his head catches in the branches. Joab thrusts three javelins into his heart (18:9-15).
3. A Cushite brings the news, and David asks, "Is it well with the young man Absalom?" (18:29-32).
4. "O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom! Would I had died instead of you, O Absalom, my son, my son!" (18:33).
5. "So the victory that day was turned into mourning for all the people" (19:2).
6. Joab says, "You have today covered with shame the faces of all your servants… because you love those who hate you and hate those who love you" (19:5-6).
7. David sits in the gate, and the people come before him (19:8).

8. The tribes of Israel argue over who has the greater claim to bring the king back. David shows mercy to Shimei, and Mephibosheth appears with a loyal heart (19:9-40).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The battle itself is told briefly. What matters is its aftermath. A father has lost a son who tried to kill him, and he weeps. David's love for Absalom is deep and painful. It is also a love marked by failure. He had not corrected Absalom, he had not reconciled with him properly, and now he has no chance to do so. His cry, "Would I had died instead of you," is among the most poignant words in the Old Testament. It shows a father's heart, and it is also impossible. A man cannot die in place of another. But another Son would.

Joab's rebuke is harsh, but not without truth. The people are being demoralized by the king's grief. A leader must carry both his own sorrow and his responsibility. David listens, rises, and sits in the gate. He lets his duty override his mourning for the moment. Grief is real, but it does not excuse neglect.

Chapter 19 shows David's ability to forgive. He pardons Shimei, who had cursed him. He is gracious to Mephibosheth, who had been slandered by his servant Ziba. He tries to repair division between the tribes. David is not perfect, and there are signs of favoritism and quarrel, but the broad picture is of a king who restores rather than avenges.

The Jordan crossing is symbolic. David returns to the land, to the city, and to the throne, passing through the water, as Israel did under Joshua. After the exile of Absalom's rebellion, David is restored. It is a small picture of the great restoration that the prophets would later promise: God's king returning to Zion.

The lasting image is of the grieving father. The story of Absalom is the story of a son who would not be reconciled, and a father who would have given anything to save him.

STEP 5

## Connection

The cry "Would I had died instead of you" finds its answer in Christ, who did die in our place (Romans 5:8). God the Father gave up his own Son for rebels (Romans 8:32). Unlike David's grief, the cross is not an unproductive tragedy but a victory. Jesus, like David, wept over his enemies (Luke 19:41). And as David showed mercy to Shimei, Jesus said, "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

## Application

Think about a relationship where reconciliation was delayed. Is there something you could say today?

If you are grieving, be honest about it. And also ask how grief and duty can live together.

Show mercy to someone who has cursed you, as David did to Shimei.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for giving his Son for rebels like you.

Pray for those who grieve and for divided families.

Ask him to teach you to love those who have wronged you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 40

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

DAY 280 · WEEK 40

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 51:10 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me."

PSALM 51:10

REST

## Meditation

This is a prayer for those who have discovered that their problem is deeper than their behavior. David asks God not simply to forgive what he has done but to change who he is.

"Create." The Hebrew verb is bara, used in Genesis 1:1 for God's making of the heavens and earth. Only God creates. David is saying that he cannot produce a clean heart on his own. No amount of effort, resolution, or discipline will do it. It must be a gift, a work of God's creative power.

"A clean heart." In the Bible, the heart is the center of the person: thoughts, desires, will, and affections. A clean heart is a heart purified of whatever defiles. David knows that the root of his sin was not an isolated action but the condition of his heart.

"Renew a right spirit." The word "renew" implies that something steadfast once existed and has been lost. He asks for a spirit that is firm and fixed in the right direction, one that will not waver.

"Within me." The work must be inward. Religion that changes only the surface is not enough. This is what the prophets promised in the new covenant: "I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you" (Ezekiel 36:26).

For the Christian, this prayer is answered at conversion and continues through sanctification. We are born again (John 3:3-6), and the Spirit is at work making us new. Yet we keep praying this prayer, because we are still being made clean. Pray it daily.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week took David from the heights to the depths. You read the early Psalm 51 in its setting, David's prayer after Nathan's confrontation. You saw the family consequences of his sin: the assault on Tamar, Absalom's murder of Amnon, and Absalom's rebellion. You followed David out of Jerusalem, weeping, with his head covered, and saw how God worked behind the scenes through Hushai. You read the psalms of the wilderness, with Psalm 63's thirst and Psalm 61's cry from the end of the earth. You saw Absalom die and David grieve, and his gracious restoration. The week taught that forgiveness does not erase consequences, that God works through human frailty, and that the human heart needs to be re-created by God.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

David prayed for a clean heart because he saw that his problem went deeper than behavior. What do you see about your heart that behavior changes alone cannot fix?

David wished he could have died in place of his son, but could not. How does Jesus, who did die in our place, answer the grief behind that cry?

Psalm 63 says God's steadfast love is better than life. In what areas of life do you find it hardest to believe that?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Ask God to create in you a clean heart.

Thank him for the Son who died in your place.

Rest in him, asking him to satisfy your soul.

DAY 281 · WEEK 41

# 2 Samuel 20:1-22:51

*Sheba's revolt; famine; David's song, the LORD is my rock*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 20:1-22:51. Sheba's rebellion is put down, and the narrative moves to an appendix that begins with David's long song of thanksgiving. Notice how the chapters end with praise.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After David's return, a worthless man named Sheba leads a revolt of the northern tribes, and Joab murders Amasa and puts it down. Chapters 21 to 24 form an appendix to the book, rather than a chronological narrative, and begin with a famine that David deals with, a list of warriors, and finally the song of chapter 22, which is the same as Psalm 18, which you read earlier.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. Sheba says, "We have no portion in David, and we have no inheritance in the son of Jesse" (20:1).
2. Joab murders Amasa with a sword, and a wise woman of Abel saves her city by persuading the people to throw out Sheba's head (20:8-22).
3. A three-year famine comes because of Saul's bloodguilt against the Gibeonites, and David deals with it (21:1-14).
4. David's mighty men kill Philistine giants (21:15-22).
5. "The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge" (22:2-3).
6. "He reached down from on high, he took me; he drew me out of many waters" (22:17).

7. “This God, his way is perfect; the word of the LORD proves true” (22:31).
8. “Great salvation he brings to his king, and shows steadfast love to his anointed, to David and his offspring forever” (22:51).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The rebellion of Sheba is a short echo of Absalom’s. It shows that the unity of the kingdom is fragile. The cry, “We have no portion in David,” foreshadows the division that will follow Solomon (1 Kings 12:16). Even in David’s restoration, the seeds of the split are visible.

Chapter 21 is hard for modern readers. Saul had violated an ancient oath to the Gibeonites by trying to wipe them out. A famine follows, and David asks God. The solution involves the execution of seven of Saul’s descendants. The chapter shows that sins have long consequences, and that oaths made in God’s name are serious. It also shows David’s care for Jonathan’s son Mephibosheth, whom he spares for the sake of his oath, and his honor for the bones of Saul and Jonathan.

The list of David’s mighty men, and the stories of giants slain, remind us that the kingdom was won by the courage of many. David does not stand alone. He leads a band of faithful warriors. Yet when David grows weary, his men insist that he no longer go out to battle, “lest you quench the lamp of Israel” (21:17). The king’s life is precious because the nation depends on him.

Then comes the song. It is Psalm 18, placed here as a summary of David’s life. The editor of the book wanted readers to look back on everything that had happened and hear David’s own testimony: God rescued me. The song ends with the promise of an everlasting kingdom. The appendix begins with the rock and ends with the offspring of David forever.

The structure is intentional. Between the wars and the failures, the book wants us to see God’s faithfulness. The final word is steadfast love.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the “lamp” that does not go out (John 8:12), and the greater king who did not stay home from battle but went to the cross. Paul quotes 2 Samuel 22:50 in Romans 15:9 and applies it to Christ among the Gentiles. The theme of the one who is “rescued out of many waters” finds its fulfillment in the resurrection. Hebrews 11:32-34 recalls David among those who conquered through faith.

STEP 6

## Application

Look back over your life and write your own short song of thanks, modeled on 2 Samuel 22.

Ask whether any promise or oath you have made needs to be kept.

Thank God for the people who fight alongside you.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what he has been to you: rock, fortress, deliverer.

Thank him for rescuing you.

Thank him for steadfast love that has not left.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 282 · WEEK 41

# Psalm 34

*I will bless the LORD at all times, taste and see*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 34. This is an acrostic psalm, each verse beginning with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet. Read it as a testimony and a teaching.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title says it was written "when he changed his behavior before Abimelech, so that he drove him out, and he went away." This refers to the time David feigned madness before King Achish of Gath (1 Samuel 21:10-15). Abimelech seems to be a title or alternate name. Having read that story, notice that David writes a psalm of praise about one of his most embarrassing moments. He saw the hand of God even in that.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "I will bless the LORD at all times; his praise shall continually be in my mouth" (v. 1).
2. "Oh, magnify the LORD with me, and let us exalt his name together!" (v. 3).
3. "I sought the LORD, and he answered me and delivered me from all my fears" (v. 4).
4. "This poor man cried, and the LORD heard him and saved him out of all his troubles" (v. 6).
5. "The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them" (v. 7).
6. "Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!" (v. 8).
7. "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed in spirit" (v. 18).
8. "Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him out of them all" (v. 19).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David turns an embarrassing escape into a hymn. He had acted like a madman, drooling on his beard, to avoid being killed. Yet he does not boast of his cleverness. He credits God: “This poor man cried, and the LORD heard him.” He calls himself poor. He knows he was saved by grace, not by his own wits.

The psalm moves from personal testimony to public invitation. “Magnify the LORD with me.” David wants others to share his joy. A good testimony is not just a story about what God did for me. It is an invitation to see God for who he is.

The famous line, “Taste and see that the LORD is good,” invites experience rather than argument. God is not only to be believed in but tasted. The psalm does not ask for blind faith. It points to the evidence of a life lived under God’s care, and it invites us to test it.

Verse 10 offers a striking contrast: “The young lions suffer want and hunger; but those who seek the LORD lack no good thing.” Lions are the strongest of predators, and yet they go hungry. Those who trust God, though weak, lack nothing that is truly good.

The center of the psalm’s teaching is verse 18: “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted.” It is one of the most comforting promises in the Bible. God is not distant from those who suffer. He is near. And verse 19 is honest: “Many are the afflictions of the righteous.” The psalm does not promise a life without trouble. It promises deliverance from it all.

The final verse offers a guarantee: “The LORD redeems the life of his servants; none of those who take refuge in him will be condemned.”

STEP 5

## Connection

John 19:36 applies verse 20 to Jesus: “Not one of his bones will be broken.” Peter quotes verses 12 to 16 in 1 Peter 3:10-12 to teach Christians how to live. 1 Peter 2:3 echoes “taste and see” (“if indeed you have tasted that the Lord is good”). Jesus is the “angel of the LORD” fulfilled in the sense that he is near to those who are crushed (Matthew 11:28-30). Romans 8:1 says there is no condemnation for those in Christ Jesus.

STEP 6

## Application

Turn an embarrassing or painful memory into a testimony of God’s help.

Today, “taste and see.” Look for a specific way that God shows his goodness.

Reach out to someone who is brokenhearted and be near to them.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Bless the LORD at this moment, in your own words.
- Thank him for answering you in the past.
- Pray for someone brokenhearted, and thank him that he is near.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 283 · WEEK 41

# Psalm 56; Psalm 57

*When I am afraid I trust in you*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 56 and Psalm 57. Both come from David's fugitive years. Notice the repeated refrains and the confidence they reflect.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 56 is set "when the Philistines seized him in Gath," and Psalm 57 "when he fled from Saul, in the cave." Both carry the title Miktam, and both use the tune "Do Not Destroy." They are written in the narrowest places: a foreign city and a cave. Both end in a refrain of praise, which shows that faith can speak boldly even when circumstances are small and frightening.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "When I am afraid, I put my trust in you" (56:3).
2. "In God, whose word I praise, in God I trust; I shall not be afraid. What can flesh do to me?" (56:4).
3. "You have kept count of my tossings; put my tears in your bottle. Are they not in your book?" (56:8).
4. "This I know, that God is for me" (56:9).
5. "Be merciful to me, O God, be merciful to me, for in you my soul takes refuge; in the shadow of your wings I will take refuge, till the storms of destruction pass by" (57:1).
6. "I cry out to God Most High, to God who fulfills his purpose for me" (57:2).
7. "My heart is steadfast, O God, my heart is steadfast! I will sing and make melody!" (57:7).
8. "Be exalted, O God, above the heavens! Let your glory be over all the earth!" (57:5, 11).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Psalm 56 gives a very honest account of fear. “When I am afraid.” It does not say “if.” David is afraid. He is in Gath, the home of Goliath, with the sword of Goliath in his hand. The psalm says that fear is a normal part of life, and the answer is not to deny it, but to bring it to God. “When I am afraid, I put my trust in you.” Courage in the Bible is not the absence of fear. It is trust in the midst of it.

The image of God collecting tears in a bottle has been loved for centuries. God does not just see our sorrow. He keeps count of our tossings and records our tears. Nothing is wasted. No tear falls unnoticed. It is among the most tender images in the Psalms.

And verse 9: “This I know, that God is for me.” It is a statement of settled conviction. It is the truth David holds to when he cannot see anything else. Paul would later write, “If God is for us, who can be against us?” (Romans 8:31).

Psalm 57 is set in a cave, but the cave becomes a place of high praise. “In the shadow of your wings I will take refuge, till the storms of destruction pass by.” It is a refuge for a season. David knows that the storm will pass. His confidence rests on God, “who fulfills his purpose for me.” God has a plan, and the cave cannot stop it.

The two refrains are lovely. Psalm 56 says, “In God I trust; I shall not be afraid.” Psalm 57 says, “Be exalted, O God, above the heavens!” In the first, trust is the response to fear. In the second, praise is the response to danger. Both turn the heart from circumstances to God.

Verse 8 of Psalm 57 is a morning song: “Awake, my glory! Awake, O harp and lyre! I will awake the dawn!” David wakes the dawn, rather than waiting for it.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus found refuge not in a cave but in his Father, who “collects” his tears (Hebrews 5:7). Paul quotes Psalm 56:4 in spirit in Romans 8:31 and Hebrews 13:6. Psalm 57:10 (“your steadfast love is great to the heavens”) echoes in Ephesians 3:18-19. Jesus said, “In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world” (John 16:33).

STEP 6

## Application

Pray, “When I am afraid, I put my trust in you,” the next time you feel fear rising.

Remember that God keeps your tears in a bottle. None of them is wasted.

Wake the dawn with praise tomorrow morning, even if it is hard.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what makes you afraid, and say, “I trust you.”

Thank him that he keeps count of your tears.

Ask him to be exalted above your fears.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

“Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!”

PSALM 34:8

DAY 284 · WEEK 41

# Psalm 30

*I will extol you, O LORD, for you have drawn me up*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 30. It is a psalm of thanksgiving for being brought back from the edge of death. Notice how it moves from mourning to dancing.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title reads, “A Psalm of David. A Song at the dedication of the temple.” The “house” may refer to David’s own palace, or to the temple site. In 2 Samuel 24 David numbers the people and faces a plague, which ended at the site where the temple would be built. Whatever the occasion, it is a psalm of a man who has come near to death and been raised.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “I will extol you, O LORD, for you have drawn me up and have not let my foes rejoice over me” (v. 1).
2. “O LORD my God, I cried to you for help, and you have healed me” (v. 2).
3. “O LORD, you have brought up my soul from Sheol; you restored me to life from among those who go down to the pit” (v. 3).
4. “For his anger is but for a moment, and his favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may tarry for the night, but joy comes with the morning” (v. 5).
5. “As for me, I said in my prosperity, I shall never be moved” (v. 6).
6. “You hid your face; I was dismayed” (v. 7).
7. “You have turned for me my mourning into dancing; you have loosed my sackcloth and clothed me with gladness” (v. 11).

8 “That my glory may sing your praise and not be silent. O LORD my God, I will give thanks to you forever!” (v. 12).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm is a story of three stages: security, crisis, and rescue. In the first, David was prosperous and said, “I shall never be moved.” He felt safe. But the security was in his prosperity rather than in God. Then God hid his face, and David was dismayed. The sudden loss of the sense of God’s presence showed him how much he depended on God. Third, he cried out, and God healed him.

The lesson is that comfort can breed complacency. When all is well, we can forget that we depend on God. Crises remind us. This is not a sentimental thought. David learned it by a frightening experience.

Verse 5 is one of the best-loved lines in the Psalter: “His anger is but for a moment, and his favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may tarry for the night, but joy comes with the morning.” It does not deny that the night is real. It says that the night will end. In the Bible, God’s discipline is brief compared to his kindness. The pain of this world is not the last word.

The reversal in verse 11 is a beautiful image. “You have turned for me my mourning into dancing.” It is God who does the turning. The sackcloth is loosed, and gladness is the new clothing. This is the pattern of the gospel: death becomes life, mourning becomes dancing.

The psalm ends with a purpose. God has done all this “that my glory may sing your praise and not be silent.” Our deliverance is meant to lead to worship. Silence is not an option for the one who has been rescued. David resolves to give thanks “forever.”

STEP 5

## Connection

The movement from night to morning is the pattern of Easter. Jesus’ mourning disciples saw him alive on the third day (John 16:20-22; Luke 24). “Joy comes with the morning” echoes Mary at the tomb at dawn (John 20:1). Paul says, “For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory” (2 Corinthians 4:17). Revelation 21:4 promises that mourning will pass away.

STEP 6

## Application

Reflect on whether prosperity has made you too comfortable. Ask God to keep you dependent.

If you are in a night of weeping, hold on to verse 5 as a promise.

Think about how God has turned mourning into dancing in your own story, and share it with someone.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that his anger is for a moment and his favor for a lifetime.

Tell him what mourning you want turned into dancing.

Give him praise for healing you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 285 · WEEK 41

# Psalm 35

*Contend, O LORD, with those who contend with me*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 35. David asks God to defend him against false accusers. Read it as a prayer of someone who has been repaid evil for good.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 35 is a psalm of David, and it is one of the longest of his cries against enemies. It uses the language of the courtroom and the battlefield. It likely comes from the years of persecution under Saul, when David was accused unjustly and hunted. In the Bible, such prayers are not about private revenge but about asking God to act as judge and defender.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Contend, O LORD, with those who contend with me; fight against those who fight against me!" (v. 1).
2. "Say to my soul, I am your salvation!" (v. 3).
3. "For without cause they hid their net for me; without cause they dug a pit for my life" (v. 7).
4. "Then my soul will rejoice in the LORD, exulting in his salvation" (v. 9).
5. "All my bones shall say, O LORD, who is like you, delivering the poor from him who is too strong for him?" (v. 10).
6. "They repay me evil for good; my soul is bereft" (v. 12).
7. "But I, when they were sick, wore sackcloth; I afflicted myself with fasting; I prayed with head bowed on my chest" (vv. 13).

8 “Then my tongue shall tell of your righteousness and of your praise all the day long” (v. 28).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm opens with the call for God to fight. The language is of a defense attorney and of a soldier. David is asking the Lord to take his side. It is not private vengeance but an appeal to divine justice. He does not take up the sword himself. Instead, he asks God to act. We see this restraint in David’s behavior toward Saul.

At the heart of the request is verse 3: “Say to my soul, I am your salvation!” More than victory over enemies, David wants assurance that God is his. The deepest need in times of attack is to know that God is for us.

The center of the psalm is the contrast between how David treated his enemies and how they treated him. When they were sick, he wore sackcloth and fasted and prayed for them. Now they gather against him and mock. This is the hardest part: being repaid evil for good. “They repay me evil for good; my soul is bereft.” David feels deep grief at the unfairness, and he brings it to God.

This is the kind of pain that Jesus experienced. The psalm’s lines “without cause” and “they hated me without a cause” are quoted by Jesus in John 15:25 as fulfilled in him. He healed, taught, and served, and was repaid with hatred.

The psalm has three cycles, each ending with a vow of praise (verses 9 to 10, 18, and 27 to 28). In each, David moves from lament to anticipated thanksgiving. He ends by saying that his tongue will tell of God’s righteousness all day long. The pattern is a model for prayer in the face of injustice: tell God the truth, ask for his help, and promise to praise.

The imprecatory parts of the psalm, in which David asks for the shame of his enemies, should be read as a request that God’s justice would be done, and not as a license for personal hatred.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus quoted verse 19 in John 15:25: “They hated me without a cause.” He was falsely accused, mocked, and betrayed (Matthew 26:59-61). He answered with love and forgiveness (Luke 23:34). Paul teaches, “Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse” (Romans 12:14). 1 Peter 3:9 says, “Do not repay evil for evil… but on the contrary, bless.”

STEP 6

## Application

If someone has repaid your kindness with cruelty, bring it to God in prayer rather than responding in kind.

Ask God to “say to your soul, I am your salvation.” Pause and listen.

Consider how you can pray for an enemy as David did when they were sick.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Bring God your hurt about being repaid evil for good.

Ask him to help you bless and not curse.

Thank Jesus for being hated without cause.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

“Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!”

PSALM 34:8

DAY 286 · WEEK 41

# Psalm 38; Psalm 39

*Rebuke me not in your anger; show me, O LORD, my end*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 26 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 38 and Psalm 39. These are two of David's most honest prayers, about the suffering that comes with sin and with the brevity of life. Read them slowly.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 38 is a penitential psalm, "for the memorial offering," and describes suffering in body and soul because of sin. Psalm 39 is a meditation on the shortness of life, written by a man who tried to hold his tongue and could not. They are placed together here after David's long reign and the sins and sorrows of the last chapters. Together they describe the weariness of a man who knows his frailty.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "O LORD, rebuke me not in your anger, nor discipline me in your wrath!" (38:1).
2. "For my iniquities have gone over my head; like a heavy burden, they are too heavy for me" (38:4).
3. "I am utterly bowed down and prostrate; all the day I go about mourning" (38:6).
4. "O Lord, all my longing is before you; my sighing is not hidden from you" (38:9).
5. "For I hope in you, O LORD; it is you, O Lord my God, who will answer" (38:15).
6. "Make haste to help me, O Lord, my salvation!" (38:22).
7. "O LORD, make me know my end and what is the measure of my days; let me know how fleeting I am!" (39:4).
8. "And now, O Lord, for what do I wait? My hope is in you" (39:7).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Psalm 38 is a portrait of sin's weight. David feels it as a heavy burden, a pain in his body, and a mourning of his soul. His friends and neighbors stand aloof. He is aware of his guilt. And yet he does not despair. In the middle of the psalm, he says, "For I hope in you, O LORD." This is the same turn we have seen elsewhere: from the weight of the problem to the strength of the one who can solve it.

A significant line is verse 9: "All my longing is before you; my sighing is not hidden from you." God knows what we cannot put into words. A sigh is a prayer. There are times when we cannot form sentences, and the psalm assures us that God hears even our groans.

Psalm 39 begins with an attempt at silence. David determined to guard his mouth, so as not to sin with his tongue in the presence of the wicked. But the silence burned inside him, and finally he spoke. What he said was a prayer about the brevity of life.

"Make me know my end… let me know how fleeting I am!" It is a startling request. Most of us avoid thinking about death. David asks for awareness. "Behold, you have made my days a few handbreadths, and my lifetime is as nothing before you." Every person, even at his best, is a mere breath. This is not morbid. It is the beginning of wisdom. Moses prays the same in Psalm 90:12: "Teach us to number our days that we may get a heart of wisdom."

The turning point is verse 7: "And now, O Lord, for what do I wait? My hope is in you." If life is a breath, then everything depends on God. The question is where to place hope. David finds the answer in God alone.

The psalm ends in a plea for relief, with the confession that he is a sojourner with God, a guest on earth. Our time here is short. Our home is with him.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus carried our burden of sin: "He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree" (1 Peter 2:24). James 4:14 says, "You are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes." Psalm 39:12 is echoed in Hebrews 11:13 and 1 Peter 2:11, where believers are "sojourners and exiles." Paul says, "We look not to the things that are seen but to the things that are unseen" (2 Corinthians 4:18).

STEP 6

## Application

Spend a few minutes asking God to "number your days." What would you do differently if you took your mortality seriously?

Bring a sigh to God today, something you cannot put into words.

Recall that you are a sojourner. Where have you been settling in too deeply?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to teach you to number your days.
- Tell him how heavy your iniquities feel and where your hope lies.
- Thank Jesus for carrying them.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 41

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

DAY 287 · WEEK 41

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 34:8 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Oh, taste and see that the LORD is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him!"

PSALM 34:8

REST

## Meditation

This verse is an invitation, not a command to believe on faith alone. David says, in effect, "Try it for yourself."

"Taste." You cannot know the flavor of food by reading about it. Tasting is personal and immediate. David is saying that the goodness of God is not only a doctrine. It is something we can experience. He had tasted it in the cave, in Gath, and in the wilderness. He asks us to do the same.

"And see." The tasting leads to seeing. What the Lord does is visible in the lives of those who trust him. This is the evidence David offers: not a philosophical argument, but a life.

"That the LORD is good." The goodness of God is the foundation of everything. He is not only powerful, or just, or wise, but good. When we are tempted to doubt, this is the claim we need most. God's goodness is not diminished by suffering. David wrote this psalm in a time of fear

and embarrassment.

“Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him.” The result of tasting is taking shelter. A person who knows that God is good will run to him. The word “blessed” echoes Psalm 1:1 and shows how David’s psalms continue the same theme.

Peter echoes this verse in 1 Peter 2:3: “If indeed you have tasted that the Lord is good.” The Lord is Jesus, and the tasting is personal. At the table of communion, we taste and see in a special way. Throughout the week, ask where you can taste his goodness: in answered prayer, in a kindness, in a beautiful day, in forgiveness.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you followed David in the aftermath of his sin. You prayed Psalm 51 with him and saw the pain in his family: Tamar’s suffering, Absalom’s revenge, and the rebellion that drove David from Jerusalem. You saw his humility as he walked out weeping, and how God worked through Hushai. You read the psalms of the wilderness, praising God’s steadfast love as better than life. You saw Absalom’s death and David’s grief, and the king’s restoration. In the appendix of 2 Samuel, David’s song looked back on God’s rescue. In Psalms 34, 56, 57, 30, 35, 38, and 39 you prayed with a man who knew fear, injustice, joy, and mortality. The week taught that God is near to the brokenhearted, that tears are never wasted, and that life is short but his goodness is not.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

David told his story of being rescued from a humiliating situation as a song of praise. What embarrassing or hard moment in your life could become a testimony of God’s help?

Psalm 34:18 says the LORD is near to the brokenhearted. How did Jesus, the Man of Sorrows, demonstrate that nearness, and how can you lean on it this week?

Psalm 39 asks God to teach us how brief life is. What would change in how you spend this week if you lived it with that awareness?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Taste and see: name one way you have seen God to be good this week.

Thank him for being near to the brokenhearted.

Thank Jesus, who knows your sorrows.

DAY 288 · WEEK 42

# 2 Samuel 23:1-24:25

*David's last words; the mighty men; the census and plague*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 47 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 2 Samuel 23:1-24:25. These are David's last words, the roll of his mighty men, and the story of the census and the plague. Notice how the book ends: with a sin, a sacrifice, and an altar.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The last chapters of 2 Samuel are an appendix, standing outside the main story. David speaks his final oracle, and the narrator lists his mighty men. Then comes an account of David numbering the people, a sin that brings a plague on Israel. The plague stops at the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite, where David builds an altar. This is the place where the temple will rise.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "The oracle of David, the son of Jesse… the sweet psalmist of Israel" (23:1).
2. "The Spirit of the LORD speaks by me; his word is on my tongue" (23:2).
3. "When one rules justly over men, ruling in the fear of God, he dawns on them like the morning light, like the sun shining forth on a cloudless morning" (23:3-4).
4. "For does not my house stand so with God? For he has made with me an everlasting covenant, ordered in all things and secure" (23:5).
5. Three mighty men break through the Philistine camp to bring David water from Bethlehem, and he pours it out to the LORD (23:13-17).
6. David orders Joab to number the people, and afterward his heart strikes him: "I have sinned greatly in what I have done" (24:1-10).

7. David says, “Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is great; but let me not fall into the hand of man” (24:14).

8. “I will not offer to the LORD my God burnt offerings that cost me nothing” (24:24).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David’s last words are a reflection on kingship, and they sketch the portrait of the ideal king: one who rules justly in the fear of God. Such a king is like the morning light, like the sun after rain. The poem describes what David was meant to be and often was not. It is also an unwitting description of the coming Messiah. David says that God “has made with me an everlasting covenant, ordered in all things and secure.” At the end of his life, his hope is in the covenant, not in his own record.

The story of the three mighty men and the water from Bethlehem is a small gem. David longs for a drink from the well of his hometown. Three of his warriors risk their lives to get it. When they bring it, David will not drink. He pours it out to the LORD, saying that it is the blood of men who risked their lives. He sees their devotion as too holy to be consumed. It is a gesture of honor, and a sign that David understood the worth of sacrifice.

The census in chapter 24 is puzzling at first. Why was it a sin? The text does not say, but the likely issue is pride and self-reliance: counting the nation’s military strength as if the king’s power came from numbers. Even Joab sees the problem. David is struck in conscience and confesses. The prophet Gad offers three punishments, and David’s choice is a mark of his character: “Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for his mercy is great.” Seventy thousand die. When the angel stretches out his hand over Jerusalem, “the LORD relented.”

David’s response is to buy the threshing floor and build an altar. “I will not offer burnt offerings that cost me nothing.” True worship involves cost. The plague stops, and the site becomes the temple mount (2 Chronicles 3:1). The book that began with a barren woman at a sanctuary ends with a king at an altar. A kingdom built on sacrifice and mercy.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the “sun shining forth on a cloudless morning” of righteous rule (Malachi 4:2; Luke 1:78-79). He is the king who does not count his strength in numbers but gives himself. The place where the plague stopped became the place of sacrifice, and the greater sacrifice at Jerusalem turned away God’s wrath for good (Romans 3:25; Hebrews 9:11-14). David’s refusal to offer what costs nothing is fulfilled in Christ, who gave everything.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask if you are tempted to measure your security by numbers: income, followers, savings, or influence.

Think about what worship costs you. Is there anything you offer God that costs you nothing?

Pour out something precious to the LORD today, in gratitude.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to keep you from trusting in numbers or success.
- Thank him for an everlasting covenant secure in all things.
- Thank him for the altar where wrath was turned away.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 289 · WEEK 42

# 1 Kings 1:1-2:46

*Solomon established on the throne; David's final charge*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 85 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 1:1-2:46. David is old, and the question of who will succeed him comes to a head. Read David's charge to Solomon in chapter 2 with care.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The first book of Kings opens with an elderly, cold David and a succession crisis. His son Adonijah declares himself king, but Nathan and Bathsheba persuade David to keep his promise that Solomon will reign. Solomon is anointed at Gihon. Before he dies, David gives Solomon a final charge. Then Solomon deals with those who threaten his throne.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. Adonijah, "a very handsome man," says, "I will be king" (1:5-6).
2. Nathan and Bathsheba remind David of his oath that Solomon would reign (1:11-31).
3. Zadok the priest anoints Solomon with oil from the tent, and the people shout, "Long live King Solomon!" (1:38-40).
4. David's charge: "Be strong, and show yourself a man, and keep the charge of the LORD your God, walking in his ways" (2:2-3).
5. "That the LORD may establish his word that he spoke concerning me, saying, If your sons pay close attention to their way… you shall not lack a man on the throne of Israel" (2:4).
6. David dies: "Then David slept with his fathers and was buried in the city of David" (2:10).
7. Solomon has Adonijah, Joab, and Shimei dealt with (2:13-46).

8 “So the kingdom was established in the hand of Solomon” (2:46).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The first chapters of Kings show the covenant of 2 Samuel 7 being worked out in real life. Adonijah’s bid for the throne follows the pattern of Absalom: a handsome prince, an entourage, and a claim made while the father is weak. But God has chosen Solomon, and God’s choice stands. Nathan, who spoke the covenant, and Bathsheba, who knows the promise, ensure that David’s oath is honored. The promise of God is kept through the quiet work of faithful people.

David’s last words to Solomon are the passage to read most carefully. They are a charge: “Keep the charge of the LORD your God, walking in his ways, and keeping his statutes… that you may prosper in all that you do.” The promise of the dynasty is tied to the obedience of the king. This is the pattern of the Davidic covenant as it unfolds: the promise of God is certain, but the individual kings who enjoy it must walk in faithfulness. It sets up the question the rest of Kings will answer: will the sons of David obey?

David also leaves Solomon some hard instructions about Joab and Shimei. These can read as vengeful, but David is passing on matters of justice that he had left unresolved. Joab had murdered Abner and Amasa. Shimei had cursed the king. Solomon, in his early reign, removes these threats. The narrative presents it as the establishment of the kingdom.

Notice the quiet line: “David slept with his fathers.” The man who was a shepherd, a fugitive, a king, an adulterer, a poet, and a penitent dies in peace. His reign lasted forty years. The kingdom now passes to his son.

The last line of the chapter is a hinge: “So the kingdom was established in the hand of Solomon.” It is a statement of fulfillment, and also a question about what will happen next.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the true Son of David who was anointed at the Jordan and cried, “It is finished.” Unlike Solomon, he needed no one to clear away his rivals. He conquered death by his own death. The charge to “be strong and keep the charge of the LORD” was kept perfectly only by him (Hebrews 3:6). Luke 22:29: “I assign to you, as my Father assigned to me, a kingdom.”

STEP 6

## Application

If you are a parent or mentor, think about what charge you would leave to those who come after you.

Ask where you need to keep your word, as David did.

Thank God that the promised kingdom is established by Christ and not dependent on human obedience.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for keeping his promises through quiet and faithful people.

Ask him to help you walk in his ways.

Thank him for the true Son of David.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 290 · WEEK 42

# Psalm 45

*My heart overflows, the royal wedding*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 17 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 45. This is a royal wedding song. Read it as a song for a king and his bride, and then read it again with the Messiah in mind.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title calls it "A Maskil of the Sons of Korah, a love song," set to the tune "Lilies." It was probably composed for a royal wedding in Israel, perhaps even Solomon's. After the story of Solomon's accession, it is a fitting psalm to hear. But the language is so lofty that it was early read as pointing to the Messiah, and the New Testament quotes it that way.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "My heart overflows with a pleasing theme; I address my verses to the king; my tongue is like the pen of a ready scribe" (v. 1).
2. "You are the most handsome of the sons of men; grace is poured upon your lips; therefore God has blessed you forever" (v. 2).
3. "In your majesty ride out victoriously for the cause of truth and meekness and righteousness" (v. 4).
4. "Your throne, O God, is forever and ever. The scepter of your kingdom is a scepter of uprightness" (v. 6).
5. "You love righteousness and hate wickedness. Therefore God, your God, has anointed you with the oil of gladness beyond your companions" (v. 7).
6. "At your right hand stands the queen in gold of Ophir" (v. 9).

7. “Hear, O daughter, consider, and incline your ear: forget your people and your father’s house, and the king will desire your beauty” (vv. 10-11).

8. “I will cause your name to be remembered in all generations; therefore nations will praise you forever and ever” (v. 17).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm is a love song, and it shows that the Bible is not embarrassed by joy at a wedding. The poet describes the king in glowing terms: handsome, gracious in speech, a warrior who rides out “for the cause of truth and meekness and righteousness.” The three words are unexpected for a king. A king who fights for truth, for meekness (humility), and righteousness is no ordinary monarch.

Then comes the surprise. The poet turns and addresses the king: “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” In the Hebrew, the king is addressed as “God.” Some readers have understood it as a figure of speech for the king’s godlike authority, but the line goes beyond the limits of any mere human king. The psalm raises a question that only the New Testament answers: who is this king whose throne is eternal and who is addressed as God?

The king is anointed “with the oil of gladness beyond your companions.” It is an echo of the Messiah’s anointing. And the king has a bride. In the second half of the psalm, the queen is told to forget her father’s house and to honor the king. She is given beautiful garments and brought in with joy. The picture of a royal marriage became, for the prophets and then the apostles, a picture of God’s covenant with his people.

The psalm ends with a promise that the king’s name will be remembered forever and that the nations will praise him. It is a promise that no human wedding could fulfill, but one that looks beyond to a king whose reign has no end.

Read in its original setting, it celebrates the royal house of David. Read in light of the whole Bible, it points to the wedding of the Lamb.

STEP 5

## Connection

Hebrews 1:8-9 quotes verses 6 and 7 and applies them directly to the Son: “But of the Son he says, Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” The psalm is a witness to Christ’s deity. Paul describes the church as Christ’s bride (Ephesians 5:25-32), and Revelation 19:7-9 and 21:2 describe the marriage supper of the Lamb. John 3:29 says, “The one who has the bride is the bridegroom.”

STEP 6

## Application

Read verses 6 and 7 aloud as praise to Jesus, whom Hebrews says is addressed here.

Think about how your relationship with Christ is like that of a bride with her husband.

Pray for the church, that she would be ready for the wedding.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what fills your heart when you think of Christ, the King.

Thank him that the King loves his bride, the church.

Ask him to make you faithful to the King.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 291 · WEEK 42

# Psalm 72

*Give the king your justice, the ideal reign*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 20 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 72. It is a prayer for the king, and the only psalm attributed to Solomon in this section. Notice how much it says about justice for the poor, and how widely the king's rule extends.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The title says, "Of Solomon," and the last line says, "The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended." It may be a prayer by David for his son, or a prayer for Solomon at his accession. It closes Book II of the Psalter. The psalm describes what a king should be, and in doing so, reaches far beyond anything Solomon could achieve. It describes the Messiah.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Give the king your justice, O God, and your righteousness to the royal son!" (v. 1).
2. "May he judge your people with righteousness, and your poor with justice!" (v. 2).
3. "May he defend the cause of the poor of the people, give deliverance to the children of the needy, and crush the oppressor!" (v. 4).
4. "May they fear you while the sun endures, and as long as the moon, throughout all generations!" (v. 5).
5. "May he be like rain that falls on the mown grass, like showers that water the earth!" (v. 6).
6. "May he have dominion from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth!" (v. 8).
7. "For he delivers the needy when he calls, the poor and him who has no helper" (v. 12).

8 “May his name endure forever, his fame continue as long as the sun! May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!” (v. 17).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The prayer begins with a request that the king would have God’s own justice. The king does not make justice. He receives it from God. A good ruler is one who reflects the character of the LORD. And the first test of justice, in this psalm, is how the poor are treated. The king is called to defend the poor, deliver the needy, and crush the oppressor. The word “poor” appears again and again. In the Bible, a ruler’s quality is measured by what happens to the weakest.

The next image is a beautiful one: the king’s rule as rain on mown grass. After the harvest, the field is cut short and dry, and rain brings new growth. A righteous king revives the land. Justice brings flourishing.

The psalm’s scope is large. “From sea to sea.” “To the ends of the earth.” “Kings bow down to him.” This is a vision of universal rule, and it reflects the promise to Abraham that all nations would be blessed (Genesis 12:3). In the last verses, we hear the promise echoed: “May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!”

Solomon’s reign did not match this ideal. It began with promise, but it ended in oppression, taxation, and idolatry. The psalm remained a prayer waiting for an answer. The people kept praying for the king who would fulfill it.

The final doxology, “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who alone does wondrous things,” closes the second book of the Psalms. It leaves the reader with the sense that this prayer is not finished. “May the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!”

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the king who defends the poor (Luke 4:18; 6:20), who delivers the needy who cry to him, and whose rule will reach “from sea to sea.” The wise men from the East brought gifts and bowed down (Matthew 2:11). Philippians 2:10-11 says every knee will bow. Galatians 3:8 shows the blessing of Abraham reaching the nations. Revelation 21:24-26 pictures the kings of the earth bringing glory into the city.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask how you treat the poor, the needy, and those without influence. What does the psalm ask of you?

Pray this psalm for the leaders of your nation, and for the reign of Christ.

Pray “May the whole earth be filled with his glory” for a specific place or people.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Pray for justice for the poor and needy.
- Thank Jesus, who defends them.
- Pray that all nations would come to know him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

“Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!”

PSALM 72:19

DAY 292 · WEEK 42

# 1 Kings 3:1-5:18

*Solomon's wisdom; the golden age begins*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 3:1-5:18. Solomon asks for wisdom, shows it in the case of the two women, and builds a flourishing kingdom. Notice both the glory and the small warnings.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Solomon's reign begins with a political marriage to Pharaoh's daughter and with worship at the high places, which are small signs that things are not perfect. At Gibeon, God appears to him in a dream and offers him whatever he asks. These chapters show the fulfillment of the promise to Abraham: a peaceful, prosperous Israel with influence over the nations. Solomon prepares to build the temple.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. Solomon marries Pharaoh's daughter, and "only, the people were sacrificing at the high places" (3:1-3).
2. God says, "Ask what I shall give you" (3:5).
3. Solomon answers, "I am but a little child. I do not know how to go out or come in… Give your servant therefore an understanding mind to govern your people, that I may discern between good and evil" (3:7-9).
4. "It pleased the Lord that Solomon had asked this" (3:10). God gives wisdom, riches, and honor (3:11-14).
5. Two women claim the same baby, and Solomon proposes to divide it. The true mother says, "Give her the living child" (3:16-28).

6. “Judah and Israel were as many as the sand by the sea. They ate and drank and were happy” (4:20).
7. “God gave Solomon wisdom and understanding beyond measure, like the sand on the seashore” (4:29).
8. Solomon writes 3,000 proverbs and 1,005 songs, and people come from all nations to hear his wisdom (4:32-34).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Solomon’s prayer at Gibeon is a model of humility. He calls himself a little child, aware of his inadequacy. He asks not for wealth, or long life, or the death of enemies, but for an understanding heart. God is pleased, and gives him what he asked and what he did not. The principle is stated elsewhere in the Bible: “Seek first the kingdom of God… and all these things will be added to you” (Matthew 6:33).

The story of the two women shows what the wisdom looks like in practice. It is not abstract. It is the ability to see through a deadlock and reveal the truth. “All Israel heard of the judgment that the king had rendered, and they stood in awe of the king, because they perceived that the wisdom of God was in him.” Wisdom from God allows a ruler to administer justice.

Chapter 4 describes the kingdom at its height. The people are as many as the sand by the sea, and “each man under his vine and under his fig tree.” It is the fulfillment of the promise to Abraham and a taste of the peace that God wants for his people. The description of Solomon’s wisdom is stunning: greater than that of all the people of the East. Nations send ambassadors.

But there are quiet warnings, if you read carefully. The marriage alliance with Egypt, the lingering practice of high places, and the long lists of provisions all hint at a king who is gathering what Deuteronomy 17 told kings not to gather: wives, horses, and wealth. The text does not tell us this yet, but it plants the question.

The treaty with Hiram of Tyre in chapter 5 prepares for the temple. It also shows the cost: forced labor. “King Solomon drafted forced labor out of all Israel.” The shadow of oppression begins.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is “greater than Solomon” (Matthew 12:42). He is the wisdom of God (1 Corinthians 1:24, 30), and in him are “hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge” (Colossians 2:3). James 1:5 says, “If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask God, who gives generously to all without reproach.” The peace of Solomon’s reign points to the peace that Christ brings (Ephesians 2:14).

STEP 6

## Application

Pray Solomon’s prayer today. Ask for an understanding mind to do what God has given you to do.

Notice what you ask God for most often. What does that reveal?

Look for the quiet warnings in your own life, small compromises that seem harmless now.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God for an understanding mind and a discerning heart.
- Thank him for Jesus, the wisdom of God, greater than Solomon.
- Ask him to keep you from small compromises.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

“Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!”

PSALM 72:19

DAY 293 · WEEK 42

# 1 Kings 6:1-7:51

*The Temple built, the permanent dwelling of God*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 101 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 6:1-7:51. The temple is built. Read the details as a description of a house for God's presence, and watch for the note in 6:11-13, where God speaks.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Solomon begins to build the temple in the fourth year of his reign, 480 years after the exodus. The temple is on Mount Moriah, the threshing floor David had purchased. The design follows that of the tabernacle but is larger and more permanent. The chapters also describe Solomon's palace and the bronze work of Hiram. It was a seven-year project.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "In the four hundred and eightieth year after the people of Israel came out of the land of Egypt… he began to build the house of the LORD" (6:1).
2. The stones were prepared at the quarry, "so that neither hammer nor axe nor any tool of iron was heard in the house while it was being built" (6:7).
3. God's word comes to Solomon: "Concerning this house that you are building, if you will walk in my statutes… then I will establish my word with you, which I spoke to David your father" (6:11-13).
4. "And I will dwell among the children of Israel and will not forsake my people Israel" (6:13).
5. The inner sanctuary, the Most Holy Place, is a cube, overlaid with gold, with two cherubim of olive wood (6:19-28).
6. The walls are carved with cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers (6:29-35).

7. “He was seven years in building it” (6:38).
8. Solomon spent thirteen years building his own house (7:1).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The temple is a work of extraordinary care. Even its construction was done in reverence: stones cut at the quarry, so that no hammering was heard at the site. It reflects the holiness of the place. The temple’s carvings of cherubim, palm trees, and open flowers recall the garden of Eden. The temple is a miniature Eden: a place where God dwells with his people. The Most Holy Place, a perfect cube covered in gold, is later echoed in the New Jerusalem (Revelation 21:16).

In the middle of the building account, God speaks. It is a short but important interruption. The temple is not enough. The building is secondary to obedience. “If you will walk in my statutes… then I will establish my word with you.” The promise of dwelling among them is tied to faithfulness. The temple could not save Israel if they were not obedient. This is the theme the prophets would later echo (Jeremiah 7:4).

The detail that it took seven years to build the temple and thirteen to build his own house is probably a quiet comment. The narrator does not accuse. But the contrast gives the reader pause. Where do a king’s priorities lie? Over time, the palace would grow while devotion declined.

The bronze work of Hiram, with the two pillars Jachin and Boaz, the sea, and the ten basins, shows the grandeur. The pillars’ names mean “he establishes” and “in him is strength.” They stood at the entrance as a statement about where Israel’s security lay.

The temple is a beautiful thing. But the people of God needed to learn that God does not live in houses made with hands. He chose to dwell there, but he cannot be contained by it.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the true temple (John 2:19-21), the place where God dwells with man (John 1:14). Believers are now God’s temple, built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit (1 Corinthians 3:16; Ephesians 2:21-22). Stephen reminded his hearers that “the Most High does not dwell in houses made by hands” (Acts 7:48). Revelation 21:22 says of the New Jerusalem, “I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb.”

STEP 6

## Application

Reflect on the proportion between how much you invest in your own house and in God’s.

Remember that you are now a temple of the Holy Spirit. How does that shape how you live?

Thank God for the Eden-like promise of dwelling with his people.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for making his dwelling with his people.

Thank him that you are a dwelling place for his Spirit.

Ask him to keep you from building your own house before his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 42

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

DAY 294 · WEEK 42

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Psalm 72:19 slowly, several times, and then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PSALM 72:19

REST

## Meditation

This verse ends the second book of the Psalms with a burst of praise. It follows the long prayer for the king and carries the hope of the whole psalm into a doxology.

"Blessed be his glorious name forever." To bless the name of God is to speak well of him, to honor him as he deserves. His name is his character and reputation, everything about him that has been revealed. The word "forever" is the language of eternity: not for a moment, not for a lifetime, but without end.

"May the whole earth be filled with his glory!" This is one of the Bible's great prayers. It echoes Numbers 14:21, where God says, "All the earth shall be filled with the glory of the LORD." It anticipates Habakkuk 2:14. It is the purpose of creation and redemption: that the glory of God would cover the earth as the waters cover the sea.

“Amen and Amen!” The double Amen is an emphatic “Let it be so.” It is the people’s agreement. They are not spectators but participants.

The context matters. This psalm is a prayer for a king, and the verse puts the king’s reign in its place. The king’s task is not to build his own name but to serve a purpose bigger than himself: the glory of God in all the earth. Solomon did not achieve this. His kingdom faded, and his temple fell. But the prayer remained, and it points to a king who will.

For the Christian, this is a prayer for the coming of Christ’s kingdom. When we pray “Hallowed be your name, your kingdom come,” we pray the same thing. And we live for it: that the earth would be filled with his glory. Let this be the prayer of your heart.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week the Davidic story reached its end and the Solomonic age began. You read David’s last words and his oracle of the just king, and the sobering account of the census and the plague, which ended at the threshing floor that would become the temple mount. You saw Solomon anointed and David’s charge to him, and you watched Solomon ask for wisdom and show it. You read of the building of the temple, a miniature Eden where God would dwell. In the Psalms, you read the royal wedding song of Psalm 45, which Hebrews applies to the Son, and Psalm 72, the prayer for the king that no human king could answer. The week taught that David’s hope rested on an everlasting covenant, that wisdom is a gift from God, and that the temple, though glorious, pointed to a greater dwelling.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

David refused to offer God what cost him nothing. What does faithful worship cost you, and what are you tempted to hold back?

Hebrews says Psalm 45 is addressed to the Son: “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” How does it change your view of Jesus to hear him addressed this way?

Solomon asked for wisdom, and God gave him more. Where do you need wisdom this week, and how will you ask for it?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Bless God’s glorious name and pray for the earth to be filled with his glory.

Thank him for the King who judges with righteousness.

Rest in him today.

DAY 295 · WEEK 43

# 1 Kings 8:1-66

*The Temple dedicated; Solomon's great prayer*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 8:1-66. This is the dedication of the temple, and Solomon's great prayer. Read the prayer slowly, and notice how often he asks God to hear and forgive.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The temple is complete, and the ark is brought in. The glory of the LORD fills the house in a cloud, as it filled the tabernacle in Exodus 40. Solomon blesses the people and offers a long prayer of dedication. He asks God to hear the prayers offered toward the temple, whatever the circumstances, and to forgive. The feast ends with enormous sacrifices and joy.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. The priests bring the ark into the Most Holy Place, "and when the priests came out of the Holy Place, a cloud filled the house of the LORD" (8:6-10).
2. "For the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD" (8:11).
3. "The LORD has said that he would dwell in thick darkness. I have built you an exalted house, a place for you to dwell in forever" (8:12-13).
4. "O LORD, God of Israel, there is no God like you, in heaven above or on earth beneath, keeping covenant and showing steadfast love to your servants who walk before you with all their heart" (8:23).
5. "But will God indeed dwell on the earth? Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house that I have built!" (8:27).
6. "Hear in heaven your dwelling place, and when you hear, forgive" (8:30).
7. "For there is no one who does not sin" (8:46).

8 “That all the peoples of the earth may know that the LORD is God; there is no other” (8:60).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The cloud that fills the temple is a sign that God has accepted the house. It echoes the glory at Sinai and in the wilderness tabernacle. The priests cannot stand to minister. The reality of God’s presence overwhelms them. This is the high point of the temple’s history. It is the moment when the dream of God dwelling with his people seemed to come true.

Solomon’s prayer is a masterpiece of theology. It starts with praise: there is no God like you, who keeps covenant and shows steadfast love. It acknowledges that God has kept his promise to David. And then comes the great honesty of verse 27: “Will God indeed dwell on the earth? Heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house.” Solomon knows that the temple does not limit God. It is a place where God chooses to put his name, not a box that holds him.

The heart of the prayer is a series of seven situations: wrong done between neighbors, defeat in war, drought, famine and plague, the foreigner who comes, battle, and exile. In each, Solomon asks God to hear in heaven and forgive. The temple becomes a house of prayer. The assumption throughout is that the people will sin: “There is no one who does not sin.” The temple, then, is above all a place of forgiveness. It is where sacrifice is offered, where sins are atoned, and where the lost may turn back.

Verses 41 to 43 are a remarkable window: the foreigner who comes from a far country “for your name’s sake” is to be heard, “that all the peoples of the earth may know your name.” The temple was meant to be a light to the nations.

The dedication ends with a benediction and a feast of fellowship offerings. “The people went to their homes joyful and glad of heart for all the goodness that the LORD had shown to David his servant and to Israel his people.”

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the true dwelling of God, the glory in the flesh (John 1:14). He is greater than the temple (Matthew 12:6). On the cross, the temple curtain was torn, opening the way into the presence of God (Matthew 27:51; Hebrews 10:19-22). He called the temple “a house of prayer for all nations” (Mark 11:17). Acts 2 shows the Spirit filling the church, as the glory once filled the house.

STEP 6

## Application

Pray the pattern of Solomon's prayer: praise, honest confession, and a request for forgiveness.

Remember that God cannot be contained by any building. Where do you try to confine him?

Pray for someone from another nation to come to know the name of the LORD.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Praise God that heaven cannot contain him and yet he dwells with his people.
- Tell him what you want him to hear and forgive.
- Thank Jesus, the true temple.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 296 · WEEK 43

# Psalm 48

*Great is the LORD in the city of our God*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 48. It is a song of Zion, the city of God. Imagine walking around Jerusalem, counting its towers, and giving thanks for God's protection.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 48 is a song of the sons of Korah and one of the Songs of Zion (see also Psalms 46, 76, 84, 87, 122). Written to celebrate God's deliverance of Jerusalem, perhaps from a military threat, it praises the city as the place of God's presence. Following the dedication of the temple, it is a fitting song for the pilgrims who came to worship there.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Great is the LORD and greatly to be praised in the city of our God! His holy mountain, beautiful in elevation, is the joy of all the earth" (vv. 1-2).
2. "Mount Zion, in the far north, the city of the great King" (v. 2).
3. "Within her citadels God has made himself known as a fortress" (v. 3).
4. "For behold, the kings assembled; they came on together. As soon as they saw it, they were astounded" (vv. 4-5).
5. "As we have heard, so have we seen in the city of the LORD of hosts" (v. 8).
6. "We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple" (v. 9).
7. "Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers, consider well her ramparts" (vv. 12-13).
8. "That you may tell the next generation that this is God, our God forever and ever. He will guide us forever" (vv. 13-14).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with a declaration of the greatness of God, and then celebrates the city where he lives. Zion is called beautiful in elevation, the joy of all the earth. It is not praised because of its architecture or defenses, but because of who lives there. “God has made himself known as a fortress” within her. The city’s security is the LORD himself.

The picture of the kings assembling and being astounded is dramatic. They see the city and flee in panic. It does not describe a human victory. They are overcome by the sight of God’s presence. The psalm echoes the stories of Jerusalem’s deliverance, perhaps in the days of Jehoshaphat or Hezekiah.

Verse 9 gives the center: “We have thought on your steadfast love, O God, in the midst of your temple.” The temple is not a source of national pride. It is a place to meditate on the covenant love of God. And that praise reaches “to the ends of the earth.”

The psalm then gives a unique invitation: “Walk about Zion, go around her, number her towers.” Pilgrims are told to go around the city and look carefully, as if to say, “Check for yourself. Count the towers.” The purpose is not tourism. It is so that “you may tell the next generation that this is God, our God forever and ever.” The tour is for the sake of testimony. Remembering what God has done is a duty to the young.

The psalm ends with a promise: “He will guide us forever.” The God who lives in Zion is not just a defender but a guide. The psalm makes the city a symbol of the permanent protection of God’s people.

STEP 5

## Connection

Hebrews 12:22-24 says that believers have come “to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem,” and to Jesus. Matthew 5:35 calls Jerusalem “the city of the great King.” Revelation 21 describes the New Jerusalem coming down from heaven, safe forever. Jesus said he would build his church, and the gates of hell would not prevail against it (Matthew 16:18).

STEP 6

## Application

Walk around your own “Zion” in your mind and count what God has done for your church and family. Tell it to someone younger.

Ask where you are depending on your own towers rather than on God.

Meditate on God’s steadfast love in prayer or in worship this week.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Praise God, in your own words, for being great.

Tell him what you have thought on of his steadfast love.

Ask him to help you tell someone younger that this is God.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 297 · WEEK 43

# Psalm 84

*How lovely is your dwelling place*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 84. It is a pilgrim's song, a longing for the courts of the LORD. Read it slowly and notice the happy people it describes.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 84 is a psalm of the sons of Korah, who were temple singers and doorkeepers. It is a song for pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem for one of the feasts, probably Tabernacles. It is among the most beloved psalms of all time. Following the dedication of the temple and the song of Zion, it expresses the deep desire of the heart to be where God is.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "How lovely is your dwelling place, O LORD of hosts!" (v. 1).
2. "My soul longs, yes, faints for the courts of the LORD; my heart and flesh sing for joy to the living God" (v. 2).
3. "Even the sparrow finds a home, and the swallow a nest for herself, where she may lay her young, at your altars" (v. 3).
4. "Blessed are those who dwell in your house, ever singing your praise!" (v. 4).
5. "Blessed are those whose strength is in you, in whose heart are the highways to Zion" (v. 5).
6. "As they go through the Valley of Baca they make it a place of springs" (v. 6).
7. "For a day in your courts is better than a thousand elsewhere. I would rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God than dwell in the tents of wickedness" (v. 10).

8 “For the LORD God is a sun and shield; the LORD bestows favor and honor. No good thing does he withhold from those who walk uprightly” (v. 11).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with exclamation. “How lovely!” It is not a calm analysis but an outburst of longing. The poet’s soul “faints” for the temple. “My heart and flesh sing for joy to the living God.” Worship is not merely duty. It is joy and desire. The psalm teaches us to want what we ought to want.

The sparrow and the swallow are a charming picture. Even the smallest birds make their homes near the altar. The poet envies them. They live in the presence of God. It is an image of belonging: the smallest and least can find a home in God’s house.

Then come two beatitudes. First, “Blessed are those who dwell in your house.” Second, “Blessed are those whose strength is in you, in whose heart are the highways to Zion.” The second is subtle. The pilgrim has the roads to Zion in his heart. Even when he is far away, his heart is already traveling. A heart set on pilgrimage makes the journey a blessing.

“As they go through the Valley of Baca they make it a place of springs.” Baca means “weeping.” The pilgrim route passes through a dry valley, a place of sorrow. But those who go with their hearts set on God transform the valley into springs. Suffering becomes a source of refreshment. And “they go from strength to strength.” The pilgrimage is a journey in which strength grows.

The famous tenth verse puts it simply: “A day in your courts is better than a thousand elsewhere.” The poet would rather be a doorkeeper, the lowest servant, at God’s house than live in luxury elsewhere. Being near God is the greatest good. The psalm ends with a promise: “No good thing does he withhold from those who walk uprightly.”

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the sun and shield, and the true dwelling place (John 1:14; Malachi 4:2). He said, “Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden” (Matthew 11:28). In him, believers have access to the Father (Ephesians 2:18; Hebrews 10:19-22). Romans 8:32 echoes verse 11: “He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?” Philippians 3:8-14 shows Paul pressing on to know Christ.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask whether you long for God’s presence. If not, ask him to give you the desire.

When you walk through your own “Valley of Baca,” consider how God may turn it into springs.

Meet with God’s people this week, and treat it as a gift.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God what your soul longs for.
- Ask him to make your strength be in him.
- Say aloud that a day in his courts is better than a thousand elsewhere.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

“And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever.”

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 298 · WEEK 43

# Psalm 87

*Glorious things of you are spoken, O city of God*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 87. This short psalm is a song about Zion and the nations. Read it slowly. It makes a surprising claim about who belongs to God's city.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 87 is another psalm of the sons of Korah and another song of Zion. It is only seven verses, and it is one of the most unusual psalms. It names the great enemies of Israel (Rahab, Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, Cush) and declares that people from these nations will be counted as born in Zion. It looks forward to the day the nations share in the blessing of God.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "On the holy mount stands the city he founded" (v. 1).
2. "The LORD loves the gates of Zion more than all the dwelling places of Jacob" (v. 2).
3. "Glorious things of you are spoken, O city of God" (v. 3).
4. "Among those who know me I mention Rahab and Babylon; behold, Philistia and Tyre, with Cush: This one was born there" (v. 4).
5. "And of Zion it shall be said, This one and that one were born in her" (v. 5).
6. "For the Most High himself will establish her" (v. 5).
7. "The LORD records as he registers the peoples, This one was born there" (v. 6).
8. "Singers and dancers alike say, All my springs are in you" (v. 7).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

This psalm turns expectations upside down. Rahab is a poetic name for Egypt. Babylon, Philistia, Tyre, and Cush are the major powers around Israel, and most of them were Israel's enemies. In the psalm, God says that he will count them among "those who know me." People from those nations will be said to have been born in Zion.

Being "born in Zion" means being a full citizen, a native of God's city. The psalm imagines the LORD keeping a register. As he reads the list, he says of Egyptians, Babylonians, Philistines, and Ethiopians, "This one was born there." It is a vision of grace beyond Israel. The people who were enemies become citizens of the city of God. The wall of separation is broken.

Why is this so important? It reflects the promise to Abraham that all nations would be blessed (Genesis 12:3). It anticipates the prophets, who spoke of the nations streaming to Zion (Isaiah 2:2-3). The Davidic covenant was not simply for Israel's benefit. God's purpose was a family drawn from every nation.

The last verse ties it together. "All my springs are in you." The singers and dancers find all their joy in Zion. For those who are born there, it is the source of life itself.

This psalm shows how the Old Testament prepares for the gospel. It is not a late idea that the nations are welcome. It was always God's plan. When Peter and Paul preach to the Gentiles, they are fulfilling what psalms like this foretold.

STEP 5

## Connection

Galatians 4:26 speaks of "the Jerusalem above" as our mother. Ephesians 2:19 says, "You are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God." Jesus said, "You must be born again" (John 3:7). Philippians 3:20 says, "Our citizenship is in heaven." Revelation 7:9 pictures a multitude from every nation standing before the throne.

STEP 6

## Application

Thank God that you are a citizen of his city, whatever your background.

Ask whether you have drawn lines around who belongs. Is there a group you consider an outsider?

Pray for a nation that seems far from God, that people from it would be counted as born in Zion.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for counting you as born in Zion.

Ask him to make you welcoming to those who are far off.

Pray that people from every nation would belong to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 299 · WEEK 43

# Psalm 101

*I will sing of steadfast love and justice, David's royal vow*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 101. David describes the kind of king he intends to be. Read it as a vow, and ask how it applies to anyone who has influence over others.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 101 is a psalm of David, and it reads like a king's inaugural pledge. He promises to rule with integrity, to avoid evil in his house, and to remove the wicked from the city. In the sequence of this unit, it comes after the temple is built and before the story of Solomon's downfall. David's vow stands in contrast to what Solomon will become.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "I will sing of steadfast love and justice; to you, O LORD, I will make music" (v. 1).
2. "I will ponder the way that is blameless. Oh when will you come to me? I will walk with integrity of heart within my house" (v. 2).
3. "I will not set before my eyes anything that is worthless" (v. 3).
4. "The one who has a haughty look and an arrogant heart I will not endure" (v. 5).
5. "I will look with favor on the faithful in the land, that they may dwell with me; he who walks in the way that is blameless shall minister to me" (v. 6).
6. "No one who practices deceit shall dwell in my house; no one who utters lies shall continue before my eyes" (v. 7).
7. "Morning by morning I will destroy all the wicked in the land" (v. 8).
8. "Cutting off all the evildoers from the city of the LORD" (v. 8).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with praise, not boasting. “I will sing of steadfast love and justice.” The twin themes of God’s own character become the foundation of David’s kingship. A king must reflect both love and justice. If either is missing, the rule fails.

The heart of the psalm is the integrity of the king’s own life. “I will walk with integrity of heart within my house.” Before David concerns himself with the nation, he concerns himself with the household. Private character comes first. A person’s integrity is tested where no one sees. “I will not set before my eyes anything that is worthless.” It is a commitment to guard what he looks at, an important thought for a man who fell through what he saw from his roof.

David then describes the kind of people he will have around him. He will not tolerate slander or arrogance. He will look for the faithful and honor them. A leader’s choice of associates shapes his rule. He will not let deceit dwell in his house.

The language of the closing verse may seem harsh, “Morning by morning I will destroy all the wicked,” but it refers to the king’s duty to administer justice, to purge evil from the community. The “morning by morning” recalls the daily court sessions held at the city gate.

We know that David did not live up to this vow. His sin with Bathsheba, his failure with his sons, and the rest of the story show that he fell short. And Solomon, who inherited the throne, would let deceit, idolatry, and compromise into his house. The psalm stands as an ideal that no human king achieved. It is an unfulfilled vow waiting for the king who would.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the king whose life matches this vow. He walked in the way that is blameless (Hebrews 4:15), and he will one day remove all evil from his kingdom (Matthew 13:41; Revelation 21:27). He looks with favor on the faithful (Matthew 25:21). Paul says that Christians should guard their eyes and hearts (Philippians 4:8). 1 John 2:16 warns about “the desires of the eyes.”

STEP 6

## Application

Make a small vow like David’s about what you will not set before your eyes.

Reflect on how your integrity at home compares with your public self.

Consider who you allow near you as friends and advisers.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God to help you walk with integrity at home.
- Ask him to guard what you set before your eyes.
- Confess where you have fallen short, and ask for help.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 300 · WEEK 43

# 1 Kings 9:1-11:43

*God's warning; Solomon's foreign wives; the kingdom fractures*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Reading · 99 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read 1 Kings 9:1-11:43. God appears to Solomon a second time with a warning. Then the story shows Solomon's wealth, his many wives, and his fall into idolatry. Read chapter 11 with care. It is the end of the unit's story.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After the temple's dedication, God appears to Solomon with a conditional promise and a warning. The following chapters describe Solomon's accomplishments: cities, ships, the visit of the Queen of Sheba, and enormous wealth. Then, in chapter 11, the narrator gives a sad accounting of Solomon's heart. The kingdom that began with wisdom ends in compromise. God announces the division of the kingdom, but for David's sake, not all of it.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. God says, "If you will walk before me, as David your father walked… then I will establish your royal throne over Israel forever" (9:4-5).
2. "But if you turn aside from following me… then I will cut off Israel from the land" (9:6-7).
3. The Queen of Sheba says, "The half was not told me. Your wisdom and prosperity surpass the report that I heard" (10:7).
4. "Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delighted in you" (10:9).
5. Solomon's gold: 666 talents a year, ivory, horses, and chariots (10:14-29).
6. "King Solomon loved many foreign women… he had 700 wives, who were princesses, and 300 concubines. And his wives turned away his heart" (11:1-3).

7. “His heart was not wholly true to the LORD his God, as was the heart of David his father” (11:4).

8. “Because you have done this… I will tear the kingdom from you… However, I will not do it in your days, for the sake of David your father… I will give one tribe to your son, for the sake of David my servant” (11:11-13).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

God’s second appearance to Solomon repeats the pattern of the covenant: the promise is sure, but the individual’s blessing depends on obedience. “If you will walk before me… I will establish your throne. But if you turn aside… Israel will become a proverb and a byword among all peoples.” It is a clear warning, delivered right after the temple’s dedication.

Chapter 10 shows the glory. The Queen of Sheba comes from far away to test Solomon with hard questions. She is overwhelmed. Her response is one of the most moving praises in Kings: “Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delighted in you.” The nations are drawn to the wisdom of Israel’s king. For a moment, it looks as though the promise to Abraham is being fulfilled.

But the details are ominous. “Gold, ivory, horses from Egypt.” Deuteronomy 17:16-17 had warned the king not to acquire many horses, wives, or silver and gold. Solomon does all three. The narrator lists them with growing weight. What looks like prosperity is the accumulation of what he was told to avoid.

Chapter 11 is the tragic center. Solomon loved many foreign women, and they turned his heart away to other gods. The wisest man in Israel is a fool for love. He builds high places for Chemosh and Molech. “His heart was not wholly true to the LORD.” It is not that he stops believing in the LORD, but that he divides his heart. Divided loyalty is a form of idolatry.

God’s judgment is real: the kingdom will be torn. But even here, mercy shines. Not in Solomon’s lifetime, “for the sake of David,” and not the whole kingdom, “for the sake of Jerusalem which I have chosen.” God’s covenant with David is the reason the line continues. The promise holds, not because of Solomon’s merit, but because of God’s faithfulness.

The unit ends with a question the whole Old Testament will keep asking: if even Solomon fails, who can be the king God promised?

STEP 5

## Connection

Jesus is the king who did not divide his heart, who resisted every temptation (Matthew 4:1-11), and whose wisdom exceeds Solomon's (Matthew 12:42). He is the true Son of David who will never fall. Where Solomon was led astray by foreign wives, the church is the bride of Christ, kept faithful by his grace (Ephesians 5:27). James 4:4-8 calls for single-hearted devotion. Hebrews 3:12 warns against an "evil, unbelieving heart."

STEP 6

## Application

Ask whether your heart is wholly true to the LORD or divided.

Look at what you have accumulated. Does anything have a hold on you?

Thank God that his promise rests on his faithfulness, and not on yours.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask God for an undivided heart.
- Ask him to keep you from accumulating what turns you from him.
- Thank him that his promise stands, even when people fail.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 43

"And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 SAMUEL 7:16

DAY 301 · WEEK 43

# Review and Sabbath Rest

*Unit 9 review, The Davidic Covenant*

Year 1 · Unit 9 · Review and Sabbath

MEMORY

## Unit Verse

> "And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."
>
> 2 SAMUEL 7:16

REST

## Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and Sabbath rest. This is a combined day, so take it slowly. Rest first, then remember.

Begin with the anchor verse of Unit 9, printed above. Read it aloud several times. Say it from memory if you can. This promise holds together everything you have read in the last sixty-seven days: the anointing of David, the covenant with his house, his sin and his repentance, the glory of Solomon's temple, and the sad division at the end. The throne is established forever. That is God's promise, and he does not break his promises.

Notice the sweep of what you have read. A barren woman prays, and a prophet is born. A people ask for a king and get Saul, who fails. God chooses a shepherd boy, who defeats a giant and flees through the wilderness. The throne comes to him, and with it a covenant that outlasts him. He falls, and he is forgiven. His son builds the temple and then loses his heart. The story ends in compromise, but the promise remains.

Read the verse once more, and think of Jesus. Gabriel said to Mary, "The Lord God will give to him the throne of his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever" (Luke 1:32-33). The promise stands because of him. He is the offspring who is also the Son of God, the king who does not fail.

Then rest. Do not catch up on missed readings. Do not do extra work. Take the Sabbath as a gift, a sign that the work of salvation does not depend on you.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This final week of the unit followed the story from the end of David to the beginning of the end of Solomon. You read David's last words, in which he trusted the everlasting covenant, and the account of the census and plague that ended at the temple mount. You saw Solomon anointed, ask for wisdom, and build the temple, and you read his great prayer at its dedication. In the Psalms you read the royal wedding song of Psalm 45 and the prayer for the king in Psalm 72, and the songs of Zion in Psalms 48, 84, and 87, and David's vow of integrity in Psalm 101. You ended with Solomon's fall, and God's decision to tear the kingdom, but for David's sake. The week taught that God's presence is the glory of his people, that his promises stand in spite of human failure, and that we need a greater king.

LOOK BACK

## Unit Recap

In Unit 9 you have followed the story of the Davidic covenant through 1 and 2 Samuel, 1 Kings 1 to 11, and a large selection of the Psalms. The books of Samuel began with Hannah's song and ended with David's altar. In between, you saw Israel ask for a king and receive Saul, whose partial obedience cost him the throne. You saw God choose David, a shepherd, whom he looked at by the heart and not by the appearance.

You saw David as a fugitive: spared Saul twice, learned to strengthen himself in the LORD, and wrote some of the Bible's greatest prayers in caves and deserts. You saw him become king, take Jerusalem, and bring the ark to the city. And you read the center of the unit, 2 Samuel 7, where God promised David a house, a kingdom, and a throne forever.

You also saw his fall. The affair with Bathsheba and the murder of Uriah were followed by Nathan's confrontation and David's confession. You read Psalms 32 and 51, the great songs of forgiveness. And you saw the consequences: the violence in his house, Absalom's rebellion, and David's weeping flight. God did not abandon the king, and he did not hide the cost of sin.

Solomon's reign was the high point: wisdom, peace, and the temple. But the narrator also showed the quiet compromises that led to his fall. The kingdom would be torn in two, and yet, for David's sake, a lamp would remain in Jerusalem.

The Psalms in this unit were the voice of the king and of the people. Psalm 2 showed the anointed Son. Psalms 3 to 5, 13, 18, 22, 24, 32, 34, 51, and 63 gave words for fear, longing, repentance, and trust. Psalms 45 and 72 pointed to the king whose throne is forever and whose rule reaches to the ends of the earth. The theme throughout was that David's greater Son would come, and that God would keep his word.

REFLECT

## Review Questions

### What is the covenant God makes with David in 2 Samuel 7?

Recall the promises: a great name, a place for Israel, a son who will build the temple, and a throne established forever. God says he will be a father to the king and discipline him, but his steadfast love will not depart. Notice that David wanted to build God a house, and God said he would build David a house. Write a few sentences about what this covenant promises and why it matters for the rest of the Bible. How does Jesus fulfill it? Look at Luke 1:32-33 and Acts 2:29-36.

### How does David's sin with Bathsheba illustrate both grace and consequence?

Look back at 2 Samuel 11 and 12 and Psalms 32 and 51. David's sin was serious, and God sent Nathan to confront him. When David confessed, Nathan said, "The LORD has put away your sin." Yet the child died and the sword did not leave his house. Write about how forgiveness and consequence can both be true. Where do you see this pattern in your own life? How does the cross hold both justice and mercy together?

### What makes Solomon's reign both the high point and the beginning of the end?

Think about the wisdom, the peace, the temple, and the prayer of dedication, and then about the horses, the wives, and the high places. The Deuteronomy 17 warnings were ignored one by one. Write a few sentences about how great gifts can lead to great failures. What does Solomon's story teach about the need for an undivided heart? How does Jesus succeed where Solomon failed?

### What do the Messianic Psalms teach us about the kind of king God ultimately promises?

Look back at Psalms 2, 22, 45, and 72. The king is God's Son, he suffers and is abandoned, he is addressed as God with an eternal throne, and he defends the poor and rules to the ends of the earth. Write a few sentences describing the king these psalms portray. Which of these features surprises you most? How do they come together in Jesus?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for keeping covenant with David and fulfilling it in Jesus.

Confess where your heart has been divided.

Rest and ask him to keep the unit verse before you.